

Hunger

Companion Texts

A reading companion to Knut Hamsun's novel

The Art of Starving

Here is a novel in which almost nothing happens. A young man walks the streets of a city. He is hungry. He tries to write. He fails. He succeeds. The success evaporates. He walks some more. He lies to strangers, gives away money he does not have, falls half in love with a woman he has invented a

name for, gnaws a bone in a dark alley, quarrels with God, tries to pawn five buttons, cannot calculate the price of cheese, and boards a ship. The ship sails. The novel ends. There is no murder, no marriage, no inheritance, no revelation. The young man does not become a better person. He does not become a worse one. He simply persists, and then he leaves.

And yet *Hunger* is one of the most gripping novels ever written. It was gripping in 1890, when it arrived in Scandinavian letters like a detonation, and it remains gripping now, more than a century later, when its innovations have been so thoroughly absorbed into the texture of modern fiction that most readers encounter them without knowing where they came from. The question of why it grips--why a plotless novel about a man who cannot eat should produce in the reader something closer to suspense than most thrillers manage--is worth taking seriously. The answer has to do with structure, with tone, with what the novel includes and what it refuses to include, and with a proposition about the nature of fiction itself that remains radical even now.

The Spiral

Hunger is divided into four parts, and each part tells the same story. The narrator begins in a state of fragile hope. He has some small resource--a few coins, a manuscript he believes in, a room to sleep in, a week's worth of meals provided by a landlady. He writes, or tries to write. He submits work to an editor. The work is rejected, or accepted for a pittance that cannot sustain him. His resources dwindle. Hunger takes hold. His behavior becomes erratic, his perceptions hallucinatory, his pride both more magnificent and more self-destructive. He reaches a nadir--sleeping in the woods, collapsing against a wall, tearing his manuscript to shreds in the street. And then, at the last possible moment, something saves him. A letter arrives. An acquaintance pawns a watch. An editor gives him money. The cycle resets. Hope returns. Part ends.

This is not plot. It is pattern. And the pattern, once you see it, raises an obvious question: why does the novel not feel repetitive? Four times the same arc, four times the same trajectory from hope through effort through failure through rescue--by rights, the reader should grow bored by Part III, exasperated by Part IV. But the opposite happens. Each cycle

tightens. Each descent goes deeper. Each rescue feels less certain, less sufficient, more contingent. The spiral narrows as it turns.

The reason is that each repetition changes the narrator's relationship to his own situation, and the reader's relationship to the narrator. In Part I, the narrator's hunger is alarming but also, in a way, exhilarating. He is new to us. His perceptions are vivid, his lies inventive, his pride almost charming. When he tells the shopkeeper that his parcel contains "two costly glass vases" bound for Smyrna, when he gives a false aristocratic name to the bewildered woman at the door, there is a performative bravado that retains a touch of comedy. He is a man improvising his way through catastrophe, and improvisation, even desperate improvisation, has a certain energy. The reader watches with something like admiration.

By Part II, the comedy has darkened. The narrator is no longer improvising from a position of residual strength. He is making a paper cornet from a blank page and throwing it on the pavement so a policeman will pick it up, and his laughter at the trick is "hushed and feverish to the intensity of tears." By Part III, the narrator's hands are wrapped in rags because the touch of his own breath on them is unbearable, and the hair is coming out of his head in clumps. By Part IV, he

cannot add a column of simple figures. The cheese defeats him. Five-sixteenths of a pound at nine pence. He stares at it and his mind goes blank.

What the spiral structure achieves is something that no linear narrative could. A conventional plot moves forward: things happen, consequences accumulate, a resolution arrives. Hamsun's spiral moves forward and inward simultaneously. Each cycle covers the same emotional territory--hope, effort, failure, rescue--but the territory itself has shrunk. The hope is thinner. The effort is more desperate. The failure is more complete. The rescue is more accidental. And because the reader has been through the pattern before, each new iteration carries the weight of all the previous ones. When the narrator in Part IV tears his drama to shreds and stamps on his hat in the street, we feel the accumulated futility of all his torn manuscripts, all his stamped-upon hopes. The repetition is not redundancy. It is accumulation. It is the formal equivalent of hunger itself, which does not progress toward a climax but simply intensifies, the same sensation recurring with increasing severity until the body cannot sustain it.

There is a musical analogy here, and Hamsun seems to have sensed it. Hunger is structured less like a novel than like a set of variations on a theme. Each Part takes the same melodic material--the walk through the city, the encounter

with authority, the episode of irrational generosity, the moment of hallucinatory perception--and develops it in a different key. Part I is in something like a major key, despite its suffering: the narrator's energy is high, his inventions are exuberant, and the Part ends with the triumphant discovery of the editor's letter, the narrator jodeling through the streets at dawn. Part II drops into a minor key: the paper cornet scene, the Ylajali hallucination, the guard-house. Part III modulates into something stranger, more intimate, more volatile: the encounter with the woman he has been watching, the visit to the editor who offers money he cannot accept, the devastating evening in Ylajali's apartment. And Part IV is a coda, a final statement of the theme stripped to its essentials, with the allegory that will not come, the cheese that cannot be calculated, and the ship that carries the narrator away.

The variation form explains why no two readings of *Hunger* feel the same. On a first reading, the spiral is suspenseful: will he eat? will he sell the article? will he survive? On a second reading, the suspense evaporates--you know he survives, you know the article will be rejected--and what replaces it is something more interesting: a growing awareness of the pattern itself, of the terrible predictability of the narrator's behavior, the way his pride will always sabotage his rescue, the way his generosity will always outrun his resources. The

novel becomes, on rereading, a study in the mechanics of self-destruction, and the spiral becomes visible not as plot but as fate.

The Funny Catastrophe

Hunger is one of the funniest serious novels in European literature. It is also one of the most harrowing. These two facts are not in tension with each other. They are the same fact.

Consider the scene with the cake vendor in Part IV. The narrator, starving, approaches a woman who sells cakes in the market. He has, at some earlier point, given her money--flung coins at her in a fit of irrational generosity. Now he returns to claim what he is owed. The exchange that follows is a masterpiece of escalating absurdity. The narrator insists he paid in advance. The cake vendor protests. He takes a cake and begins eating it. She tries to protect her wares. He threatens to call the police. He lectures her on business customs abroad. He inquires, with devastating politeness, whether she has ever left the country. She has not? Well, then, she could of course have no opinion on the subject. He takes several more cakes. She snatches one from his hand. He accuses her of robbery. She flings a final cake at him and tells him to go.

Ha! a match for this dishonest cake-vendor was not to be found. The whole time, whilst I walked to and fro in the market-place and ate my cakes, I talked loudly about this creature and her shamelessness, repeated to myself what we both had said to one another, and it seemed to me that I had come out of this affair with flying colours, leaving her nowhere.

This is very, very funny. It has the timing and structure of a vaudeville routine. The narrator's escalating indignation, his deployment of worldly sophistication against a bewildered cake vendor, the magnificent absurdity of his claim that paying in advance is "a common practice abroad"--all of it produces genuine laughter. But the laughter does not relieve the scene's horror. It deepens it. The narrator is stealing food from a woman who sells cakes in a market. He is doing it with such elaborate rhetorical machinery because he cannot bear to simply ask for help. The comedy is the mechanism by which his pride transforms theft into a performance of righteous indignation, and the reader laughs because the performance is brilliant and weeps because the performance is necessary.

This is the distinctive tonal register of *Hunger*, and no other novel achieves it quite this way. The comedy and the tragedy are not alternating modes, like the oscillation between comic and serious scenes in Shakespeare. They are simultaneous.

They occupy the same sentence, the same gesture, the same moment. When the narrator in Part IV swears by the Father, Son, and Holy Ghost that the potatoes in a passing cart are cabbages--swearing a solemn oath over a vegetable he can plainly see--the passage is hilarious and it is also a portrait of a mind disintegrating. The oath is funny because it is so wildly disproportionate to its object. It is terrifying because the narrator knows the potatoes are potatoes, knows he is lying, and cannot stop himself. He describes this perjury as a "matchless sin" and gets "intoxicated" with the "vicious satisfaction" of committing it. The hunger has pushed him past the boundary where the will controls the mouth, and what comes out is a kind of deranged comedy that the narrator both performs and observes.

Samuel Beckett, who learned from Hamsun more than he usually acknowledged, would perfect this mode in *Waiting for Godot* and the trilogy of novels that followed. Vladimir and Estragon's routines--the hat-swapping, the carrot-eating, the contemplation of hanging themselves from a tree that cannot support their weight--are comedy and despair fused at the molecular level. But Beckett's fusion is philosophical. His characters know they are performing. They are clowns who have read Schopenhauer. Hamsun's narrator does not know he is performing. Or rather, he knows and does not know, simultaneously. He is aware that he has just swindled a cake

vendor, and he is genuinely convinced that she was the dishonest party. He holds both truths at once, and the reader, trapped inside his consciousness, holds them too. This is more disturbing than Beckett, because there is no ironic distance, no frame. We are not watching a clown. We are inside a mind that is producing comedy as a survival mechanism, the way a fever produces sweat.

The cheese scene operates on the same principle. Five-sixteenths of a pound of cheese at nine pence. The narrator cannot do the arithmetic. He stares at the figures. His landlady watches him. He moves his lips, slides his finger down the column, performs the posture of calculation. And when he fails, his response is not despair but a frantic internal monologue in which he proves to himself that his mind is still sound. He noticed the landlady was pregnant, did he not? He can hear a song from the kitchen. He can follow children quarreling in the street. "Set me, if you like, at five-sixteenths of good dairy butter," he tells himself. "That is another matter." The logic is absurd: because he can perceive, he can think; because he can think, the cheese was an anomaly; because the cheese was an anomaly, he is fine. It is a perfect comedy of self-deception, and it is also the moment where the narrator's identity as a writer--a man whose

instrument is his mind--receives its most devastating blow. The funny and the catastrophic are not adjacent. They are identical.

The Writer Who Cannot Write

Hunger is a novel about a writer, and it is a novel about writing. These are not the same thing. Plenty of novels have writer protagonists whose writing is incidental to the plot, a profession like any other. In Hunger, writing is the protagonist's entire reason for existing. It is the activity that keeps him in Christiania when he could leave. It is the source of whatever money he earns. It is the wellspring of his identity, his pride, his delusions, his moments of genuine transcendence. The novel is, among other things, the most honest account of the literary vocation ever set down on paper.

The narrator writes constantly. He writes in churchyards at dusk, on park benches, in his miserable rooms, on the steps of buildings. He writes articles for newspapers, character sketches, a drama set in the Middle Ages, an allegory about a fire. And almost everything he writes is rejected, or rejected by himself before it can be submitted, or torn to pieces in fits

of rage and self-loathing. The cycle of composition in *Hunger* is as repetitive and as devastating as the cycle of starvation: inspiration, effort, exaltation, doubt, despair, destruction.

What makes this portrait so remarkable is its refusal to sentimentalize the act of writing. There is no muse. There is no quiet garret where the sensitive soul communes with beauty. There is a man with a pencil and some paper, sitting in the cold, trying to make sentences while his stomach eats itself. The material conditions of literary production--the need for a desk, a candle, a room with a door that locks, a body that is not shaking with hunger--are foregrounded with brutal clarity. The narrator's writing does not transcend his physical condition. It is produced by his physical condition, shaped by it, distorted by it. When he writes well, it is often because fever has loosened his inhibitions and his exhausted brain has stumbled into a kind of delirium that resembles inspiration. When he writes badly, it is because the same fever has burned away the capacity for sustained thought.

Consider the great scene of composition in Part I. The narrator wakes in the night, takes up his pencil, and begins to write. The work flows. He is ecstatic:

An intense, peculiar exhalation of light and colour emanates from these fantasies of mine. I start with surprise as I note one good thing after another, and tell

myself that this is the best thing I have ever read. My head swims with a sense of satisfaction; delight inflates me; I grow grandiose.

He values the manuscript at five shillings, then revises upward to half a sovereign. He decides his room is no longer worthy of him. He bows to the lighthouse director's notice on the wall. He writes a note to his landlady promising money. He walks to the newspaper office, delivers the manuscript, and waits. Hours pass. Doubt creeps in. He runs through the streets. He arrives at the office, breathless. The editor has not read it. More hours. And then, at the end of Part I, the letter: accepted, set in type, half a sovereign. "Worked out with talent--therefore a little masterpiece--a stroke of genius." The narrator's inflation of the editor's polite phrase into a declaration of genius is simultaneously the purest expression of writerly vanity and the purest expression of writerly need. He does not just want to be paid. He wants to be told he is extraordinary. The money is almost an afterthought.

But the novel never lets us know whether the narrator is any good. This is one of its most cunning strategies. We never read a word of the narrator's writing. We see him compose, exult, doubt, and despair, but we never see the product. The articles he submits to the editor are described only by their subjects: a piece on Correggio, an allegory about a fire. Whether these are works of genuine talent or the ravings of a

starving mind is a question the novel refuses to answer. The editor accepts some and rejects others, but editors are fallible, and the narrator himself oscillates so wildly between grandiosity and self-contempt that his own assessment is worthless. The reader is left in a state of permanent uncertainty about the one thing that would determine whether the narrator's suffering has meaning.

This uncertainty is the novel's deepest insight into the writing life. The writer can never know if the work is good. Not really. Not in the moment of composition, when the blood is up and the sentences are flowing. Not in the moment of doubt, when every word looks dead on the page. Not even in the moment of acceptance, because acceptance might be a fluke, a kindness, a slow day at the office. The narrator's wild swings between "this is the best thing I have ever read" and "downright worthless" are not symptoms of instability. They are the ordinary weather of any writer's mind, compressed by hunger into a single day, a single hour. Hamsun understood that writing is an act of faith performed without evidence, and he built the novel's structure to embody that understanding. The narrator writes and writes and writes, and we never find out if any of it matters.

There is also the question of what the narrator writes versus what Hamsun writes. The narrator's drama about the Middle Ages, with its monks and its Deemster and its church

bell, sounds terrible. It sounds like exactly the kind of derivative period piece that a young writer who has read too much would produce. Meanwhile, the novel we are reading--the novel that contains this failed drama--is one of the most original works of fiction ever written. The narrator cannot write *Hunger*. Only Hamsun can. The narrator is trying to produce literature through willpower and subject matter: the Middle Ages, Correggio, allegory. Hamsun produces literature by attending to what is actually in front of him: the starving body, the lying mouth, the streets of Christiania at dusk. The narrator wants to write about everything except his own life. Hamsun writes about nothing else. The irony is structural, and it is devastating. The great novel about a writer who cannot write is itself the proof that the act of writing, when it finally finds its true subject, can produce something extraordinary. The narrator just never finds it. He is looking in the wrong direction, toward monks and allegories, while the real material--the material Hamsun seizes--is the looking itself.

The Novel of Omission

There are novels that achieve their effects through inclusion--through the sheer density of information, the piling up of detail, the creation of a world so thick with furniture and history and social texture that the reader feels they could move through it with their eyes closed. Balzac does this.

Dickens does this. Tolstoy does this. Hunger does the opposite. It achieves its effects through what it leaves out, and what it leaves out is almost everything.

We do not know the narrator's name. We do not know where he comes from, or who his parents are, or whether he has siblings, or how he was educated, or what brought him to Christiania, or how long he has been there. We do not know his age, though he seems young. We do not know his nationality for certain, though he appears to be Norwegian. We have no backstory, no childhood memory, no formative trauma, no explanation for why he is the way he is. He arrives on the first page already starving, already proud, already writing, already lying, and the novel offers not one sentence of explanation for any of it.

This is radical. In 1890, the dominant modes of European fiction--naturalism, realism, the social novel--depended on explanation. Zola's characters were products of heredity and environment, and the novelist's job was to demonstrate the mechanism. Ibsen's characters carried their pasts like luggage, and the drama consisted of unpacking it. Even Dostoevsky, the great precursor of psychological fiction, gave his characters histories, motives, philosophical positions. The Underground Man tells us exactly why he is spiteful. Raskolnikov's crime has a theory behind it. But Hamsun's narrator has no theory, no history, no position. He

is pure present tense. He exists only in the moment of perception, and the novel refuses to explain him because explanation would be a betrayal of the thing it is trying to do.

What it is trying to do is render consciousness as it is actually experienced, and consciousness, as it is actually experienced, does not come with footnotes. We do not walk down the street thinking, "I am doing this because my father was a tailor and my mother was cold and I was sent away at the age of nine." We walk down the street and see a woman with a single tooth in her gum and feel nauseated, and we do not know why. We give money to a stranger and cannot explain the impulse. We invent a name--Ylajali--and repeat it to ourselves for hours, and the name means nothing, refers to nothing, and yet it fills the mind with a sensation that cannot be paraphrased. Consciousness is not a narrative. It is a weather system. And Hamsun's refusal to provide backstory is not a failure of craft. It is the craft. The omission is the point.

There is also no politics in *Hunger*. This is remarkable given the moment of its composition. Norway in the late 1880s was in the final stages of a long struggle for independence from Sweden, a struggle that would culminate in the dissolution of the union in 1905. Christiania was a city of intense political activity: labor organizing, feminist agitation, the Bohemian rebellion, the clash between conservative and progressive

forces in the Storting. The narrator walks through this city every day and notices none of it. He does not read the news. He does not attend meetings. He does not have political opinions. The workers and the bourgeoisie, the radicals and the reactionaries, the whole apparatus of social conflict that would have furnished a novel by Ibsen or Zola with its central drama--all of it is invisible to the narrator, because the narrator is too hungry to care.

This is not an oversight. It is an argument. The novel proposes, through its very structure, that consciousness under extreme pressure contracts to a point. The starving man does not think about society. He thinks about bread. He thinks about the price of a candle. He thinks about the woman in black who stands under the gas lamp. Politics requires the luxury of a full stomach and a warm room, and the narrator has neither. By omitting the political world entirely, Hamsun makes a claim about the hierarchy of human needs that is more persuasive than any treatise: that before we are citizens, before we are members of a class, before we are participants in history, we are bodies, and bodies that are not fed cannot think about anything else.

The omission of the narrator's inner life is equally striking. I do not mean that the narrator has no inner life--on the contrary, the novel is nothing but inner life. I mean that the narrator never reflects on his own psychology. He never asks

himself why he lies. He never wonders why he gives away money he cannot afford. He never analyzes his relationship to Ylajali, or to the editor, or to God. He does not, in other words, do the thing that characters in novels are supposed to do: he does not interpret himself. He acts and reacts and perceives and feels, but he never stands back from his own experience and draws a conclusion. The interpretation is left to the reader, and the reader, like the narrator, never has quite enough information to complete it.

This refusal of self-interpretation is what makes *Hunger* feel so modern, so much more like a novel written in the twentieth century than in the nineteenth. The great discovery of modernist fiction--the discovery usually attributed to Joyce and Woolf and Proust--was that consciousness is not transparent to itself, that we do not understand our own behavior, that the reasons we give for our actions are usually wrong. But Hamsun got there first, not by theorizing about the opacity of consciousness but by simply refusing to let his narrator explain himself. The narrator of *Hunger* is a mystery to himself, and the novel's refusal to solve that mystery is what gives it its peculiar, lasting power. We finish the book knowing the narrator's mind more intimately than we know almost any character in fiction, and we cannot explain him at all.

The Consciousness Machine

Here, then, is the radical proposition at the heart of *Hunger*, the proposition that makes it the founding text of a certain kind of fiction and the ancestor of everything from Kafka to Beckett to Bernhard to the present day. The proposition is this: consciousness is enough. The movement of a mind through time is, in itself, a sufficient subject for a novel. You do not need a plot. You do not need a social panorama. You do not need a moral. You need a mind, and you need to follow it closely enough that the reader begins to experience it from the inside.

This sounds obvious now. We have had more than a century of novels that do little else. But in 1890 it was not obvious at all. The novel was understood to be a narrative art, and narrative meant events: things happening to people in a social world, producing consequences that could be traced and judged. Even the most interior novelists before Hamsun--Dostoevsky, Flaubert, the Goncourts--embedded their psychological explorations in plots. There were crimes and punishments, marriages and affairs, social rises and falls. The consciousness was the lens through which these events were perceived, but the events were the subject.

Hamsun reversed the equation. In *Hunger*, the events are negligible. A man walks, eats or does not eat, writes or does not write, talks to people or does not talk to them. Nothing of consequence happens in the entire novel, if consequence is measured by the standards of plot. But the consciousness through which these non-events are perceived is so vivid, so volatile, so unpredictable that it generates its own suspense. We do not read *Hunger* to find out what happens. We read it to find out what the narrator will think next, what association will fire, what lie will spring from his mouth, what perception will ambush him on the street. The mind is the event. The weather of consciousness is the plot.

And the weather is extraordinary. The narrator's perceptions arrive in the text with a specificity and strangeness that makes ordinary realist description look like wallpaper. He sees his own shoes and is overwhelmed by a "delicate, wonderful shock," a recognition that something of his own nature has "gone over into these shoes." He sees a woman's single tooth and describes it as "a little finger pointing out of her gum." He walks through the streets and the buildings seem to breathe, the cobblestones seem to pulse, the gas lamps seem to watch him. This is not metaphor in the literary-device sense. It is the way a hungry, exhausted, overstimulated brain actually processes the world: every

sensation amplified, every object charged with significance, every surface vibrating with a meaning that cannot quite be articulated.

The novel's formal achievement is to make this hypersensitivity into a reading experience. We do not merely observe the narrator's strange perceptions. We undergo them. The prose does not describe the sensation of hunger-induced hallucination. It produces it. The shifts in register--from lucidity to delirium, from comedy to despair, from grandiosity to abjection--happen without warning and without transition, because that is how they happen inside a hungry mind. The reader is given no stable vantage point from which to watch. We are inside the skull, looking out through the narrator's eyes, and the world we see is the world as hunger makes it: brilliant, terrifying, hilarious, and utterly unreliable.

This is what distinguishes *Hunger* from the stream-of-consciousness novels that followed it. Joyce's *Ulysses*, Woolf's *Mrs Dalloway*, Faulkner's *The Sound and the Fury*--these are all novels of consciousness, but they are also novels of technique. Their innovations are formal and deliberate: interior monologue, free indirect discourse, the dissolution of syntax to represent disordered thought. Hamsun's innovation is not technical. His prose is clear, sequential, grammatical. There is no typographical experiment, no suppression of

punctuation, no stream-of-consciousness in the textbook sense. What there is, instead, is the relentless pressure of a single sensibility, a narrator who is so fully present in every sentence that the reader cannot pull away. The technique is not in the style. It is in the intimacy.

And this intimacy produces something that the more technically adventurous modernists rarely achieve: the reader's complete identification with a consciousness that is, by any reasonable standard, unreliable, self-deluding, and half-mad. We do not watch the narrator of *Hunger* from a distance and diagnose him. We think with him. We believe his lies in the moment he tells them. We feel the surge of pride when he refuses the editor's money. We feel the righteous indignation against the cake vendor. We feel the grandiosity when the editor says "worked out with talent" and the narrator's mind inflates it to "a stroke of genius." And then we feel the horror of recognizing, a beat later, that we have been fooled, that the narrator is fooling himself, that the lie was a lie and the pride was a mask and the genius was just a hungry man on a park bench. *Hunger* does not represent unreliable consciousness. It transmits it. The reader is infected.

The Non-Ending

The final paragraph of *Hunger* is one of the most famous in modern fiction, and also one of the strangest:

Out in the fjord I dragged myself up once, wet with fever and exhaustion, and gazed landwards, and bade farewell for the present to the town--to Christiania, where the windows gleamed so brightly in all the homes.

There it is. The whole ending. A man on a ship, looking back at a city full of lighted windows. He is wet, feverish, exhausted. He bids farewell "for the present"--that careful qualification, as if this were a temporary departure, as if he might return next week, as if the ship were a short holiday rather than an escape from starvation. And the windows gleam "in all the homes." All the homes. The phrase is quiet and it is devastating. The narrator has never had a home in this novel. He has had rooms--a gasping attic, a tinker's workshop, a lodging-house from which he is expelled--but never a home, never a place where windows gleam for him. The last image the novel gives us is an image of belonging seen from the position of someone who does not belong and is moving farther away with every moment.

Nothing is resolved. The narrator does not succeed as a writer. He does not fail definitively, either. He does not die. He does not have an epiphany. He does not learn a lesson. He does not reconcile with Ylajali. He does not reconcile with himself. He boards a ship because a ship was there and a captain said he could have a try, and the conditional phrasing of the captain's acceptance--"If it doesn't work, well, we can part in England"--echoes every other conditional arrangement in the novel: the rooms that might be kept for another week, the articles that might be accepted, the woman who might be met again at eight o'clock. The future is as uncertain as the past. The ship sails, and the novel stops.

In 1890, this was shocking. Novels ended. They resolved. The marriage plot concluded with a marriage. The bildungsroman concluded with a self that had been formed. Even the naturalist novel, with its grim determinism, concluded with a fate that had been determined. The idea that a novel could simply stop, that a character could walk out of one life and into no particular other, that the last sentence could be an image of ambiguous departure rather than a statement of arrival--this was new. It was so new that many of the novel's early readers did not know what to make of it. Some read the ending as hopeful: the narrator is escaping, starting over, putting the bad times behind him. Some read it as despairing: the narrator has given up,

abandoned his vocation, turned his back on the only city where he might have made his name. Both readings are plausible. Neither is adequate. The ending resists interpretation because it is not an ending in the conventional sense. It is a cessation. The music stops.

The non-ending inaugurated a tradition that would become central to modern fiction. Kafka's *The Trial* ends with an execution that resolves nothing. Beckett's *Molloy* ends with one narrative dissolving into another. Camus's *The Stranger* ends with Meursault wishing for a crowd of spectators at his execution, a desire that explains nothing and resolves nothing. Coetzee's *Disgrace* ends with David Lurie giving up a dog, a gesture whose meaning remains permanently opaque. In each case, the non-ending is not a failure of craft but a refusal of the consolation that endings traditionally provide. The story does not wrap up because life does not wrap up. The character does not arrive because there is no destination. The reader is left holding something that does not close, and the openness is the meaning.

But Hamsun's non-ending is different from all of these, because it is not austere. It is lyrical. Those gleaming windows are beautiful. The fjord is beautiful. Even the narrator's fever has a kind of beauty, the way he "dragged himself up once" to look back, as if the effort of raising his head were an act of devotion. The ending does not withhold

feeling. It is saturated with feeling. What it withholds is sense, explanation, resolution. We feel everything and understand nothing, and this, the novel proposes, is what it is like to be alive: to be moved by things we cannot explain, to leave places we cannot quite understand, to look back at lighted windows from a darkening ship and feel something for which there is no name.

What Remains

I want to end with the question that any honest essay about *Hunger* must eventually confront, which is the question of why this novel matters. Not why it mattered in 1890, when it detonated the conventions of nineteenth-century fiction. Not why it mattered to the modernists who followed Hamsun, from Kafka to Beckett to the whole lineage of writers who learned from this book that a novel could be built from the inside out. But why it matters now, to a reader picking it up for the first time in a world that has no shortage of novels about consciousness, about unreliable narrators, about the comedy of desperation.

The answer, I think, is that *Hunger* has not been surpassed. It has been elaborated, extended, refined. The techniques it pioneered have been developed into systems and schools. But the thing itself--the raw, unmediated sensation of being

inside a mind that is both brilliant and breaking, that is simultaneously the funniest person in the room and the most wretched, that lies with the fluency of an artist and believes its own lies with the credulity of a child--has not been equaled. The novel's power does not come from its innovations, which have long since been absorbed. It comes from its intensity, which has not.

There is a passage near the end of Part I that I think about often. The narrator, homeless, has sneaked back into the room he abandoned that morning. He finds a letter on the table and assumes it is his eviction notice. He carries it downstairs, puts on his shoes in the dark, walks to a gas lamp, and opens it.

A stream of light, as it were, darts through my breast, and I hear that I give a little cry--a meaningless sound of joy.

A meaningless sound of joy. The phrase is perfect. The cry has no content. It does not say anything. It is not a word, not a sentence, not a thought. It is the body's response to good news before the mind has processed it, a sound that is prior to language, prior to meaning, prior to the whole apparatus of interpretation that the narrator deploys so relentlessly throughout the novel. For one instant, the narrator is not performing, not lying, not analyzing, not composing. He is just a body making a noise, and the noise is joy.

Hunger is full of such moments--instants where the narrator's relentless self-consciousness cracks open and something unmediated comes through. The shock of seeing his own shoes. The tears that arrive without explanation when a policeman speaks kindly. The silent, feverish laughter on the harbor bench. The final backward glance at the gleaming windows. These are the moments when the novel's machinery stops and something else appears, something that cannot be paraphrased or explained, that belongs to no tradition and serves no argument. They are moments of pure consciousness: not consciousness thinking about itself, but consciousness encountering the world without a filter, the starved mind meeting the raw surface of experience.

This is the art of starving. Not the art of writing about starvation, though Hunger does that. Not the art of using starvation as a metaphor for the artistic condition, though it does that too. The art of stripping away everything--comfort, security, explanation, backstory, plot, resolution, the very capacity for rational thought--until what remains is the irreducible fact of a mind perceiving, a consciousness moving through time, registering the world with the terrible clarity of a body that has nothing left between itself and what it sees. Hamsun found, at the bottom of hunger, something that every novelist since has been trying to reach: the place where fiction and consciousness become the same thing, where the

act of perceiving and the act of narrating are indistinguishable, where the novel is not about experience but is experience, transmitted directly from one mind to another across the silence of the page.

The windows still gleam. The ship is still sailing. And the novel, which began more than a century ago in a bare room papered with old newspapers, continues to do what it did on the day it was written: it places you inside a starving mind and does not let you out until the last sentence, and when you emerge, blinking, into your own life, the world looks slightly different, as it always does when you have been seeing, for a little while, through someone else's hunger.

The Invention of the Interior

Before there was stream of consciousness, there was starvation. Before the novel learned to follow the erratic, self-interrupting, associative tumble of a mind thinking, it had to find a mind under enough pressure to crack open and become visible to itself. In 1890, thirty-two years before Joyce published *Ulysses* and thirty-five years before Woolf gave us *Mrs Dalloway*, a twenty-nine-year-old Norwegian named Knut Hamsun produced a short novel that did something no work of fiction had done before: it made the inside of a skull the entire landscape of the story. There is no plot in *Hunger* in any conventional sense. A young writer wanders the streets of Christiania, starving. He tries to write. He fails, or succeeds, and the success and the failure feel equally delirious. He gives away what little he has. He lies to strangers. He falls half in love. He sleeps in the woods. And none of this matters as action, as event, because the real subject is the wild, ungovernable weather of his consciousness, the way thought itself becomes the only drama worth recording.

The Room, the Newspaper, the Light

Consider how the novel begins. One sentence of scene-setting, a single line so compressed it functions almost as an epigraph:

It was during the time I wandered about and starved in Christiania: Christiania, this singular city, from which no man departs without carrying away the traces of his sojourn there.

Then an abrupt cut, a horizontal rule, and we are in a room. Not a room described from the outside, as Balzac or Dickens might have described it, furnishing every surface with social meaning. We are inside the narrator's consciousness as he wakes, and the room comes to us only as he perceives it, piece by piece, detail by unreliable detail:

I was lying awake in my attic and I heard a clock below strike six. It was already broad daylight, and people had begun to go up and down the stairs. By the door where the wall of the room was papered with old numbers of the *Morgenbladet*, I could distinguish clearly a notice from the Director of Lighthouses, and a little to the left of that an inflated advertisement of Fabian Olsens' new-baked bread.

A lighthouse director's notice and an advertisement for bread. These are not accidental details. The writer lives inside other people's language. His walls are literally papered with text he did not write, the published words of others, and the first thing his eyes seek in the morning is something to read. The bread advertisement is almost sadistic in its proximity to a starving man, but Hamsun does not underline this. The narrator does not comment on the cruelty of waking to the word "bread" when you have none. He simply sees it, registers it, moves on. The restraint is everything. In a naturalist novel, this detail would have been wielded like a hammer. Here it just exists, the way details exist in a mind before the mind has decided what to feel about them.

And then the room itself, drawn not as a set of dimensions but as a set of sensations:

The bare room, the floor of which rocked up and down with every step I took across it, seemed like a gasping, sinister coffin. There was no proper fastening to the door, either, and no stove. I used to lie on my socks at night to dry them a little by the morning. The only thing I had to divert myself with was a little red rocking-chair, in which I used to sit in the evenings and doze and muse on all manner of things.

The floor that "rocked up and down" like breathing, the room as coffin, the rocking chair as the sole furniture of thought. This is already, on the first page, a new kind of writing. The room is not described; it is experienced. It is perceived as the body perceives things when the body is weak and hungry and the boundary between self and world has begun to dissolve. The rocking chair will return at the end of Part I, remembered with scorn when the narrator is high on the delusion that his fortunes have turned. But here, at the start, it is simply the site of consciousness: the place where the narrator sits and muses, the only object in his life that invites interiority.

The Whisper of Blood

In 1890, the same year *Hunger* was published in full, Hamsun delivered a lecture and wrote an essay called "From the Unconscious Life of the Mind." In it, he attacked the reigning gods of Scandinavian letters, argued against the heavy social machinery of Ibsen and the naturalist school, and demanded that literature attend to what he called "the whisper of blood and the pleading of bone marrow." He wanted fiction to register the irrational, the fleeting, the contradictory, the thoughts that arrive from nowhere and vanish before they can be examined. He wanted novels about minds, not about problems.

Part I of *Hunger* is the laboratory in which this theory becomes practice. Watch the narrator step outside into the streets of Christiania for the first time:

The roll of vehicles and hum of voices filled the air, a mighty morning-choir mingled with the footsteps of the pedestrians, and the crack of the hack-drivers' whips. The clamorous traffic everywhere exhilarated me at once, and I began to feel more and more contented. Nothing was farther from my intention than to merely take a morning walk in the open air. What had the air to do with my lungs? I was strong as a giant; could stop a dray with my shoulders.

This is a man who has nothing, who cannot pay his rent, who has been rejected from the fire brigade for bad eyesight. And he feels like a giant. The euphoria is pure hunger, the body's first manic response to deprivation, but the narrator does not know that and neither, at first, does the reader. This is the radical insight at the heart of the novel: that we do not experience our physical states as physical states. We experience them as moods, as convictions, as weather. The starving man does not think, "I am light-headed from hunger and therefore feel grandiose." He thinks, "I am strong as a giant." The body lies to the mind, and the mind believes it.

Hamsun understood, decades before psychoanalysis had the vocabulary for it, that consciousness is not transparent to itself. The narrator of *Hunger* does not understand his own behavior. He cannot explain why the sight of a woman with one tooth in her head makes him nauseated ("The long yellow snag looked like a little finger pointing out of her gum"), or why the slow progress of a lame old man ahead of him in the street fills him with violent rage, or why he invents the name "Ylajali" for a woman he has never met and then cannot stop repeating it. These are not motivated actions. They are not symbolic. They are the way a hungry, exhausted, overstimulated mind actually works, lurching from one fixation to the next, converting every passing stimulus into an occasion for extreme feeling.

The Underground and the Street

There is a precursor to Hamsun's narrator, and it is impossible to ignore him. Dostoevsky's *Underground Man*, that furious, self-lacerating clerk who speaks to us from beneath the floorboards of St. Petersburg in 1864, was the first narrator in fiction to make his own abjection into a kind of performance. He is spiteful and he knows he is spiteful. He sabotages his own friendships, ruins a dinner party, pursues a prostitute

only to humiliate her, and then confesses it all in a tone of such aggressive self-awareness that confession itself becomes another form of cruelty.

Hamsun's narrator descends from the Underground Man, but the two are fundamentally different creatures. Dostoevsky's narrator is driven by spite. He destroys his relationships because he cannot bear to be seen as inferior, and he tells us so, at length, with philosophical apparatus. He is a theorist of his own misery. Hamsun's narrator has no theory. He is driven by a pride so extreme that it has become involuntary, reflexive, almost physical, a spasm rather than a position. When he pawns his waistcoat to give money to a stranger, he is not performing generosity out of spite, the way the Underground Man might. He is performing it out of a need so deep it has no name, a compulsion to be the one who gives rather than the one who receives, even when he has nothing, even when the giving will destroy him.

Watch the extraordinary scene with the old beggar. The narrator catches up to the lame man, slaps his shoulder, and the man whines for money for milk. The narrator, who has nothing, goes and pawns his waistcoat, gives the man the money, and is then outraged when the old man stares at his knees:

My good fellow, you have adopted a most unpleasant habit of staring at a man's knees when he gives you a shilling.

When the confused old man tries to return the money, the narrator stamps on the pavement and insists he keep it, inventing on the spot a fiction that he owed the man a debt. This is not the Underground Man's calculated cruelty. This is something wilder, more involuntary, more modern. The narrator must be generous because he cannot bear to be pitied. He must give because to receive would be to admit what he is. And the lie about the old debt is not a conscious performance; it arrives in his mouth fully formed, the way all his lies do, as though some deeper self were writing the script. Dostoevsky gave us the narrator who knows he is lying. Hamsun gave us something more unsettling: the narrator who lies and does not quite realize it, who is always one step behind his own performance.

The Body Thinks

What separates *Hunger* most sharply from its precursors, and what makes it most clearly the ancestor of the modernist novel, is its treatment of the body. Before Hamsun, the body in fiction was either a social surface (clothes, beauty, deformity, the visible markers of class) or a site of sensation

to be described from the outside. In *Hunger*, the body is the organ of thought. Consciousness does not happen in the head and then get relayed to the body. Consciousness happens in the body, and the head is merely one of the places it passes through.

The most astonishing passage in Part I is the scene with the shoes. The narrator sits on a park bench, unable to write, and lets his gaze fall on his own feet:

I half rise and look down at my feet, and I experience at this moment a fantastic and singular feeling that I have never felt before--a delicate, wonderful shock through my nerves, as if sparks of cold light quivered through them--it was as if catching sight of my shoes I had met with a kind old acquaintance, or got back a part of myself that had been riven loose.

He begins to weep. He studies the shoes as though they were faces: "I discover that their creases and white seams give them expression--impart a physiognomy to them. Something of my own nature had gone over into these shoes; they affected me, like a ghost of my other I--a breathing portion of my very self."

This is not metaphor. Or rather, it is metaphor that has become experience. The starving body has begun to lose its boundaries, and the narrator's sense of self starts leaking into objects, into his shoes, into the city around him. The shoes are not like a part of himself; they feel like a part of himself, a detached limb that he has just rediscovered. This is the body thinking, the body doing philosophy without the mind's permission. It is precisely the kind of perception Hamsun demanded in his essay: not an idea about experience, but the experience itself, in all its irrationality and physical strangeness.

A similar dissolution occurs later, when the narrator has been walking for hours on an empty stomach:

A singular sense of confusion suddenly darted through my head. I stumbled on, determined not to heed it; but I grew worse and worse, and was forced at last to sit down on a step. My whole being underwent a change, as if something had slid aside in my inner self, or as if a curtain or tissue of my brain was rent in two.

The image of the brain-curtain tearing is hallucinatory, but it is also precise in a way that no clinical description could be. The narrator does not say he felt dizzy or confused. He says that something structural changed inside him, that a curtain tore. This is what hunger does to consciousness, not gradually

but all at once, a sudden shift in the architecture of perception, and Hamsun captures it not by describing symptoms but by inhabiting the changed state from within.

The Architecture of Self-Sabotage

Part I establishes what becomes the novel's great recurring structure: a pattern of pride, delusion, collapse, and irrational generosity that repeats with variations like a musical theme. The narrator gets a little money and immediately gives it away. He writes something brilliant and immediately doubts it. He encounters kindness and immediately ruins the encounter with a lie. The pattern is not tragic in the classical sense, because there is no single fatal flaw, no hamartia. The narrator's pride, his lying, his generosity, his paranoia--these are not flaws in an otherwise sound character. They are the character. They are the weather of his consciousness.

Take the scene at the pawnshop, after he has retrieved his pencil. The pawnbroker is polite, helpful, obliging. And the narrator, seized by some inexplicable compulsion, begins to lie to him:

It was with this pencil that I wrote my dissertation on "Philosophical Cognition," in three volumes.

The lie has no purpose. It gains him nothing. But he cannot stop. The pawnbroker is polite, so the narrator must be extraordinary. A simple transaction must become a performance of importance. And then, having performed importance, he must perform generosity: he voluntarily tries to give money to a woman on the stairs, and is humiliated when he finds his pockets empty. The lying and the generosity come from the same source: an absolute inability to occupy his actual position in the world. He cannot be a starving man retrieving a pencil from a pawnshop. He must be a great author condescending to visit one.

The pattern reaches its fullest expression in the long scene with the blind old man on the bench. The narrator, having invented the name Happolati for a nonexistent landlord, finds himself building an entire fantasy world around the name: Happolati the agent, Happolati the former Minister of State in Persia, Happolati's beautiful daughter Ylajali (the same invented name he gave the woman on the street), who "reclined on a couch of yellow roses" and had "three hundred slaves." The lies accumulate with a momentum that even the narrator cannot control:

I was entirely absorbed in stories of my own which floated in singular visions across my mental eye. The blood flew to my head, and I roared with laughter.

And then, when the old man accepts everything placidly, the narrator turns furious, precisely because the old man's credulity has robbed him of the friction he needs. The pleasure was not in being believed but in the act of invention, the feeling of creative power. When the old man simply nods along, the narrator explodes: "Hell and fire, man! Do you imagine that I am sitting here stuffing you chock-full of lies?" He is angry at the old man for believing him, because belief makes the lies mundane. The narrator needs his fabrications to astonish. He is, in this moment, both the creator and the destroyer of his own fictions, and the reader sees for the first time that his lying and his writing come from the same desperate wellspring.

Consciousness as Starvation

There is a direct line from *Hunger* to Fernando Pessoa's *The Book of Disquiet*, that great, unfinished, undatable collection of fragments written by the semi-heteronym Bernardo Soares. Soares, like Hamsun's narrator, wanders a city in a state of perpetual, aestheticized suffering. He is a clerk in Lisbon the way Hamsun's narrator is a writer in Christiania: the occupation is almost irrelevant, a thin pretext for the real activity, which is the ceaseless, self-consuming work of consciousness.

But where Hamsun's narrator is desperate and physical, Soares is cerebral and resigned. Hamsun's narrator runs through the streets, weeps, stamps his feet, gives away his waistcoat. Soares sits at his desk and contemplates the dust motes in a shaft of light. The distance between the two writers is the distance between hunger and satiety, between a consciousness driven to extremity by physical need and a consciousness that has arrived at extremity through sheer attentiveness. Hamsun's narrator would not survive Soares's life; the boredom would kill him faster than the starvation. And Soares would not survive Hamsun's; the physical indignity would be unbearable.

Yet the lineage is unmistakable. What Hamsun discovered in 1890, and what Pessoa inherited and transformed, is the idea that consciousness itself is a kind of hunger. The mind wants. It wants objects, fixations, narratives, fictions. Deprived of food, Hamsun's narrator feeds on everything else: on the old man's newspaper, on the invented name Ylajali, on the imaginary Happolati, on the sight of his own shoes. The mind is omnivorous when the body is starved. It devours details, manufactures stories, generates fantasies, and then, exhausted, collapses into vacancy: "I was conscious of the gaping vacuum in my skull with every fibre of my being. I seemed to myself to be hollowed out from top and toe." The emptiness is not just physical. It is cognitive.

The mind, having consumed everything in reach, finds itself empty, a skull with nothing in it, and even that emptiness is experienced with hallucinatory intensity.

This is what Hamsun gave to the novel, and it has never been surpassed, only elaborated. Joyce and Woolf would develop the technical apparatus of stream of consciousness into something more controlled, more architectural, more deliberate. But the raw discovery, the revelation that fiction could track the actual movement of a mind through time, with all its gaps and surges and irrational swerves, belongs to Hamsun. He found it not in theory but in the body, in the specific derangements of hunger, in the way a starving man's thoughts scatter and concentrate and scatter again.

A Letter Under the Lamp

Part I ends with one of the great scenes in European fiction, though nothing happens in it. The narrator, homeless, freezing, broke, has sneaked back into the attic room he abandoned that morning. On the table he finds a letter. He assumes it is his landlady's final dismissal. He carries it downstairs, puts on his shoes in the dark, walks to a gas lamp, and opens it in the flickering light:

A stream of light, as it were, darts through my breast, and I hear that I give a little cry--a meaningless sound of joy. The letter was from the editor. My story was accepted--had been set in type immediately, straight off! A few slight alterations.... A couple of errors in writing amended.... Worked out with talent ... be printed tomorrow ... half-a-sovereign.

The passage is broken, telegraphic, elliptical. The narrator cannot hold the information in complete sentences. It comes to him in fragments, separated by those breathless ellipses, because that is how joy arrives when you have been expecting catastrophe: not as a steady current but as a series of shocks. "Worked out with talent"--the editor's polite professional phrase becomes, in the narrator's shattered state, a kind of sacrament. And then the final lines of Part I:

All through the night until the bright dawn I "jodled" about the streets and repeated--"Worked out with talent--therefore a little masterpiece--a stroke of genius--and half-a-sovereign."

The logic is lunatic and perfect. "Worked out with talent" becomes "a little masterpiece" becomes "a stroke of genius," each phrase inflating the last, the hungry mind doing what it has done all day--transforming the modest into the grandiose. And the half-sovereign comes at the end, tacked

on with an "and," as though money were an afterthought, a minor detail appended to the real news, which is that the narrator is a genius. We know, of course, that by tomorrow the money will be gone, the euphoria will collapse, and the pattern will start again. But Hamsun does not tell us this. He leaves the narrator spinning in the street, jodeling into the dark, half-mad with relief and self-love, and the reader is left to feel, with a kind of vertigo, that this joy is as real and as unreliable as everything else that has come before it.

This is what Hamsun invented: a fiction in which the reader inhabits another mind so completely that there is no outside from which to judge it. We are not watching the narrator. We are thinking with him, starving with him, lying with him, weeping with him, and when the letter comes, we feel the shock of light in our own chests. It is the birth of the interior novel, and it happened not in Paris or London or Dublin but in Christiania, in a bare room papered with old newspapers, in 1890.

Close Reading: Part I

What follows is a passage-by-passage companion to Part I of *Hunger*. It is meant to be read alongside the novel or just after finishing it -- the voice of someone sitting beside you, pointing at the page and saying: look what he just did there. I will quote generously. I will try to stay close to the sentences themselves, to the peculiar texture of Hamsun's prose, the way it swerves and contracts, the way it renders a starving man's consciousness with a precision that has never quite been matched. The broader arguments about *Hunger* as a landmark of psychological modernism are taken up in the companion essay, *The Invention of the Interior*. Here, we stay with the words on the page.

The Epigraph That Is Not an Epigraph

Part I opens with a single sentence, set apart from everything that follows by a horizontal rule:

It was during the time I wandered about and starved in Christiania: Christiania, this singular city, from which no man departs without carrying away the traces of his sojourn there.

This is one of the great opening sentences in European fiction, and its greatness lies partly in how much work it does while seeming to do almost nothing. Notice the tense: past. "It was during the time." The narrator is telling us this story from some later vantage point, looking back. He survived. He got out. This is crucial because the novel will proceed to immerse us so completely in the present tense of starvation that we will forget there is a storyteller behind it, someone who lived to tell. The retrospective frame is established in one sentence and then essentially abandoned. Hamsun gives us just enough distance to know we are hearing testimony, and then he collapses the distance entirely.

Notice too the strange repetition: "Christiania: Christiania." The colon acts as a hinge, pivoting from the specific memory into a general declaration. The first "Christiania" is a place on a map, the city where the narrator starved. The second is something more -- a mythic force, a singular city that marks everyone who passes through it. The repetition has an almost incantatory quality, as if the narrator cannot quite say the name without needing to say it again, to hold it in his mouth. And the final clause -- "from which no man departs without

carrying away the traces of his sojourn there" -- is both a warning and a boast. Christiania scarred him, yes. But he carries the scars with something like pride. He is, after all, writing this.

Then the horizontal rule drops like a curtain, and we are somewhere else entirely: inside a room, inside a body, inside the present tense of waking up hungry.

The Room of Newspapers and Light

The opening proper begins not with a declaration but with a sensation:

I was lying awake in my attic and I heard a clock below strike six. It was already broad daylight, and people had begun to go up and down the stairs. By the door where the wall of the room was papered with old numbers of the *Morgenbladet*, I could distinguish clearly a notice from the Director of Lighthouses, and a little to the left of that an inflated advertisement of Fabian Olsens' new-baked bread.

The narrator is awake, but he is not yet up. He is lying there, perceiving. And the room comes to us not as a described space but as a sequence of perceptions: first the clock (sound), then the daylight and the footsteps on the stairs (sight and sound together), then the wall beside the door,

papered with old issues of the *Morgenbladet*, a real Christiania newspaper. The details are not selected for symbolic weight, or rather, they are, but they are disguised as the casual inventory of a man whose eyes are drifting around a room. A lighthouse director's notice. An advertisement for bread.

The bread advertisement is almost sadistic in context -- a starving man wakes to the word "bread" printed on his wall -- but Hamsun does not underline the irony. The narrator does not remark on it. He simply sees it, the way a waking mind sees whatever is in front of it. This is the method of the entire novel: to let the reader feel the cruelty that the narrator does not yet consciously register.

What follows is a brief survey of the narrator's situation -- he has been "somewhat hard-up," has pawned his belongings, has "grown nervous and irritable," has sometimes earned five shillings for a newspaper piece. This is delivered in the past habitual tense ("I had," "I used to"), a mode that compresses weeks or months of experience into a few sentences. It is backstory, but compressed and understated, the narrator flicking through his recent decline the way one might flip through a calendar.

Then comes the room itself:

The bare room, the floor of which rocked up and down with every step I took across it, seemed like a gasping, sinister coffin. There was no proper fastening to the door, either, and no stove. I used to lie on my socks at night to dry them a little by the morning. The only thing I had to divert myself with was a little red rocking-chair, in which I used to sit in the evenings and doze and muse on all manner of things.

That floor that "rocked up and down" -- the word "rocked" is doing double duty, describing both the physical instability of cheap construction and anticipating the rocking chair two sentences later, the sole piece of furniture that offers any comfort. And the image of the room as "a gasping, sinister coffin" is delivered almost in passing, as if this were simply how the room seems to him, not a metaphor he is constructing but a perception he is reporting. The coffin breathes; the room gasps. The walls are papered with someone else's language. And the narrator lies on his socks to dry them with his body heat. Every detail is both realistic and quietly devastating.

The rocking chair deserves attention. It is "little" and "red," the only object in the room described with any warmth. It is the place where he sits and "muses on all manner of things" -- in other words, it is the seat of his inner life, the one piece of furniture that corresponds to consciousness rather than

survival. It will return near the end of Part I, remembered with contempt when the narrator's fortunes seem to have turned. But here it is simply the center of a bare life, the one thing that remains when everything else has been pawned.

Notice what is absent from this room: there is no stove, no lock on the door, no comb, no book. The narrator catalogs these absences with a dry precision that is almost comic: "I had not even a comb left, not even a book to read, when things grew all too sad with me." The word "even" does heavy lifting -- a comb is the minimum, a book the last luxury, and both are gone. The man who lives inside language, who wallpapers his room with newspapers and will spend the day trying to write an article, cannot even read when things grow "all too sad." And note the understatement of that phrase -- "all too sad" -- which in a different writer might be "desperate" or "unbearable." Hamsun's narrator does not dramatize his deprivation. He describes it with the flat affect of someone for whom this has become ordinary, which makes it worse.

One more detail from the opening inventory: "When it blew hard, and the door below stood open, all kinds of eerie sounds moaned up through the floor and from out the walls, and the *Morgenbladet* near the door was rent in strips a span long." The newspaper that wallpapers his room is being destroyed by the wind -- the words that surround him are

literally tearing apart. It is an image of language under physical stress, text becoming material, and it quietly anticipates the narrator's own relationship to writing throughout Part I: words that come apart, articles that cannot hold together, thoughts that scatter before they can be captured.

The Job Search: Comedy of Refusal

The narrator searches his bundle for breakfast, finds nothing, and returns to the window. What follows is one of the finest passages of compressed social comedy in the novel:

God knows, thought I, if looking for employment will ever again avail me aught. The frequent repulses, half-promises, and curt noes, the cherished, deluded hopes, and fresh endeavours that always resulted in nothing had done my courage to death. As a last resource, I had applied for a place as debt collector, but I was too late, and, besides, I could not have found the fifty shillings demanded as security. There was always something or another in my way. I had even offered to enlist in the Fire Brigade.

The rhythm of "repulses, half-promises, and curt noes" is beautiful in its precision -- three stages of rejection, escalating from outright refusal through the cruelty of maybe to the final clipped dismissal. And the litany that follows --

debt collector (too late, no security deposit), Fire Brigade (rejected for eyesight, then recognized when he tries again without glasses) -- has the quality of a comic routine, each attempt failing for a different, increasingly absurd reason.

But the finest touch is the Fire Brigade scene:

There we stood and waited in the vestibule, some half-hundred men, thrusting our chests out to give an idea of strength and bravery, whilst an inspector walked up and down and scanned the applicants, felt their arms, and put one question or another to them. Me, he passed by, merely shaking his head, saying I was rejected on account of my sight. I applied again without my glasses, stood there with knitted brows, and made my eyes as sharp as needles, but the man passed me by again with a smile; he had recognized me.

The image of fifty men puffing out their chests to perform strength and bravery is already comic, a herd of peacocks in a vestibule. But the narrator's return without his glasses, standing there with "knitted brows" trying to make his eyes "as sharp as needles," is something else -- it is pathetic and resourceful and doomed all at once. The inspector's smile is the killing detail. He does not reject the narrator with a shake of the head this time but with a smile, because the ruse is transparent, because the effort is touching and also slightly

ridiculous. The narrator is already someone who performs -- who tries to make himself look different than he is -- and already someone who gets caught.

And then the passage turns on a single devastating observation: "I could no longer apply for a situation in the garb of a respectable man." The decline is not just economic. It is sartorial, visible, written on the body. You cannot pretend to be employable when your clothes betray you. This sets up one of Part I's great recurring motifs: the narrator's obsession with the surfaces of respectability -- the shiny knees of his trousers, his missing waistcoat, the blanket he cannot carry without shame.

The Street: Euphoria and the Butcher's Woman

The narrator dampens his trouser-knees with water, pockets paper and pencil, and slips past his landlady. He emerges into Christiania at nine in the morning, and something extraordinary happens:

The roll of vehicles and hum of voices filled the air, a mighty morning-choir mingled with the footsteps of the pedestrians, and the crack of the hack-drivers' whips. The clamorous traffic everywhere exhilarated me at once, and I began to feel more and more contented. Nothing was farther from my intention than to merely take a morning

walk in the open air. What had the air to do with my lungs?
I was strong as a giant; could stop a dray with my
shoulders.

The city is rendered as music -- a "mighty morning-choir" -- and the narrator meets it with a euphoria that is completely disproportionate to his circumstances. He has no food, no money, no prospects, and he feels like a giant. The prose performs this euphoria: the sentences are long, rolling, cumulative, gathering momentum. "A sweet, unwonted mood, a feeling of lightsome happy-go-luckiness took possession of me." The adjective "lightsome" is perfect -- it means both cheerful and physically light, the feeling of a body that has nothing in it, that is buoyed by its own emptiness.

This is the first of the novel's great mood-swings, and Hamsun renders it from inside, without clinical commentary. The narrator does not know he is experiencing the manic phase of starvation. He simply feels wonderful. The reader, armed with the knowledge that the narrator has not eaten, begins to see the gap between what the narrator reports and what is actually happening to him -- a gap that will widen and close and widen again throughout Part I, becoming the novel's primary source of tension.

And then, into this euphoria, one of the novel's most disturbing images:

At a butcher's stall a woman stood speculating on sausage for dinner. As I passed her she looked up at me. She had but one tooth in the front of her head. I had become so nervous and easily affected in the last few days that the woman's face made a loathsome impression upon me. The long yellow snag looked like a little finger pointing out of her gum, and her gaze was still full of sausage as she turned it upon me.

The single tooth "like a little finger pointing out of her gum." This is not a simile the narrator has composed; it is a perception that has arrived unbidden, the kind of grotesque transformation that happens when a mind is overstimulated and under-nourished. The tooth becomes a finger, an accusation, a pointing. And the woman's gaze is "still full of sausage" -- an extraordinary phrase that blurs the boundary between the woman and the food she is contemplating, as if her eyes have absorbed the sausage she was looking at and now project it onto the narrator. She looks at him with sausage-eyes, and his stomach turns.

The narrator "immediately lost all appetite" and goes to the fountain to drink water. But consider: what appetite? He has had no breakfast. The nausea is not a response to fullness but to emptiness, to the sight of food he cannot have, mediated through the grotesque figure of the one-toothed woman. The body rebels against what it wants most. This is a

pattern that will intensify throughout Part I -- the narrator increasingly unable to eat even when food is available, his hunger turning against itself.

The Cripple on the Hill

What follows is one of the novel's most psychologically revealing sequences. The narrator is wandering "listlessly, without troubling myself about anything at all," when he finds himself behind an old lame man carrying a bundle:

For quite ten minutes I had had an old lame man ahead of me. He carried a bundle in one hand and exerted his whole body, using all his strength in his endeavours to get along speedily. I could hear how he panted from the exertion, and it occurred to me that I might offer to bear his bundle for him, but yet I made no effort to overtake him.

Notice the narrator's first impulse: to help. He thinks of offering to carry the man's bundle. This charitable instinct is genuine, and it is immediately suppressed. "But yet I made no effort to overtake him." The "but yet" is crucial -- it registers the gap between intention and action, the way a good impulse can arise and die in the same moment. The narrator does not explain why he fails to help. He simply does not, and the failure sits there, uncommented upon.

What happens next is remarkable. The narrator's charity curdles into irritation, and the irritation mounts into rage:

The sight of this infirm creature constantly in front of me, commenced to irritate me--his journey seemed endless; perhaps he had made up his mind to go to exactly the same place as I had, and I must needs have him before my eyes the whole way. In my irritation it seemed to me that he slackened his pace a little at every cross street, as if waiting to see which direction I intended to take, upon which he would again swing his bundle in the air and peg away with all his might to keep ahead of me.

This is paranoia, but of a very specific and recognizable kind. The narrator has projected intention onto the old man -- the cripple is not merely slow, he is deliberately slow, he is watching the narrator at each cross street and then hurrying to stay ahead. The old man has become an antagonist, an obstruction that is personal. And the narrator's language rises to match: "He looks like a great sprawling reptile striving with might and main to win a place in the world and reserve the footpath for himself." The cripple has become a reptile, a creature competing for territory. The narrator's rage is about space, about precedence, about who gets to occupy the path.

There is something else at work here, something the narrator cannot see. The old cripple is a version of himself -- poor, struggling, carrying his meager bundle. The narrator's fury is the fury of a man who cannot bear to see his own condition reflected back at him. He does not want to be behind this man because being behind him means being in his company, being of his kind. The shoulder-slap that follows -- "I made three or four furious onward strides, caught him up, and slapped him on the shoulder" -- is an act of aggression disguised as contact, a violent bid to break through the intolerable mirror of another person's poverty.

And then the reversal:

| "A halfpenny for milk!" he whined, twisting his head askew.

The man is a beggar. The slap on the shoulder, which the narrator meant as a confrontation, the old man receives as the gesture of a potential benefactor. The narrator has been furious at a man who is even worse off than himself, and the man's response is to ask for charity. "So that was how the wind blew." The narrator must now either admit his rage was groundless, or become the benefactor the old man assumes he is. He chooses the latter. He goes and pawns his waistcoat.

Pawning the Waistcoat: Pride as Physics

The pawnshop scene is dispatched quickly -- the waistcoat fetches one-and-six, the narrator pockets the money and the ticket -- but the logic of what follows is extraordinary. He has pawned one of his last garments, in autumn, to give money to a stranger he was furious at thirty seconds ago. And he feels great about it:

Considering all things, pawning that waistcoat was a capital notion. I would have money enough over for a plentiful breakfast, and before evening my thesis on the "Crimes of Futurity" would be ready. I began to find existence more alluring; and I hurried back to the man to get rid of him.

"To get rid of him" -- the phrase is perfect. The narrator is not returning to perform a generous act. He is returning to discharge an obligation so that the old man will no longer exist for him. The gift is a dismissal.

And then the encounter goes wrong. The old man takes the money and stares at the narrator's knees -- those shiny, water-dampened knees that betray his poverty. The narrator erupts:

"My good fellow, you have adopted a most unpleasant habit of staring at a man's knees when he gives you a shilling."

This is one of the most revealing sentences in the novel. The narrator cannot bear to be seen for what he is. He has just pawned his waistcoat to give money to a beggar, and the beggar's gaze threatens to expose the truth: that the giver is as poor as the recipient. The narrator's outrage is not about rudeness; it is about being read correctly. His performance of generosity depends on the audience not looking too closely at the performer.

When the confused old man tries to return the money, the narrator stamps his foot and invents a fiction on the spot: "If all came to all, perhaps I owed him this shilling; I had just recollected an old debt." The lie arrives fully formed, the way all the narrator's lies do -- not as a calculated deception but as an involuntary response to a situation his pride cannot tolerate. He cannot be giving charity. He must be repaying a debt. The transaction must be reframed so that the narrator is the one in control, the one with obligations to meet, not the one with nothing.

Before the narrator leaves, he delivers one more rebuke: "I threw back my shoulders, and said: 'My good fellow, you have adopted a most unpleasant habit of staring at a man's knees

when he gives you a shilling.'" The throwing back of the shoulders is a physical gesture of self-enlargement -- the narrator making himself bigger, taking up more space -- and it precedes the most absurd command imaginable: do not look at me while I give you charity. The old man, bewildered, tries to return the money. The narrator stamps on the pavement, swears, and invents the fiction of the old debt. And then, in one of the novel's most quietly devastating lines: "he was standing before an honest man, honourable to his finger-tips -- in short, the money was his." The narrator has just lied, and the lie is about his honesty. The sentence contains its own contradiction without showing the smallest awareness of it.

Then the grocer's shop. "A piece of cheese and a French roll," the narrator requests, throwing his sixpence on the counter. The woman asks, with irony: "Bread and cheese for the whole of it?" She is incredulous that someone would spend an entire sixpence on so little. The narrator, "unruffled," says yes. The exchange is tiny but charged. The woman has seen through him in a single question -- she knows that a man spending sixpence on cheese and bread is not a man with money to spare. And the narrator's "unruffled" composure is another performance, the studied calm of a man who cannot afford to seem rattled.

He heads to the park "full tilt," as if the momentum of spending can outrun the reality that he has just pawned an article of clothing in autumn to feed himself for a single meal.

Writing in the Park: The Article That Cannot Be Written

The narrator eats and feels better. His "courage rose mightily," and in a passage of beautiful comic inflation, he abandons his planned article on the "Crimes of Futurity" as too simple:

I could no longer be satisfied with writing an article about anything so simple and straight-ahead as the "Crimes of Futurity," that any ass might arrive at, ay, simply deduct from history. I felt capable of a much greater effort than that; I was in a fitting mood to overcome difficulties, and I decided on a treatise, in three sections, on "Philosophical Cognition."

The escalation is pure Hamsun: a man who has just eaten his first meal in days decides he is too brilliant for his original idea and must instead write a three-part philosophical treatise that will "crush pitifully some of Kant's sophistries." The food has gone to his head, quite literally -- the body's

gratitude at receiving nourishment is experienced as intellectual grandiosity. And then, the comic deflation: he has left his pencil in his pawned waistcoat.

This is one of the novel's structural masterstrokes. The pencil is in the waistcoat pocket. The waistcoat is in the pawnshop. The narrator pawned the waistcoat to give money to a stranger, and in doing so, he pawned his ability to write. His generosity has directly sabotaged his only means of earning a living. The irony is total and the narrator does not see it, or sees it only as an exasperating accident: "Good Lord! how everything seems to take a delight in thwarting me today!"

He cannot simply go back and ask for the pencil. He must first think about it, fret about it, inflate the importance of the treatise -- "mayhap many human beings' welfare, no one could say" -- and then deflate his own ambitions in a parenthetical revision: "On second thoughts, I would not lay violent hands on Kant; I might easily avoid doing that." The narrator is revising his unwritten article before he has a pencil to write it with. The mind races ahead of the hand, the ambition outruns the capacity, and the gap between the two is where the comedy lives.

Ylajali: The Invention of a Name

On his way to retrieve the pencil, the narrator brushes against a woman's arm. What follows is one of the most extraordinary passages in the novel, a sequence in which desire, creativity, and madness become indistinguishable:

I looked up; she had a full, rather pale, face. But she blushes, and, becomes suddenly surprisingly lovely. I know not why she blushes; maybe at some word she hears from a passer-by, maybe only at some lurking thought of her own. Or can it be because I touched her arm? Her high, full bosom heaves violently several times, and she closes her hand tightly above the handle of her parasol. What has come to her?

The narrator cannot know why the woman blushes, but he cannot stop speculating. His mind cycles through possibilities -- a word from a passer-by, a private thought, his own touch -- and the uncertainty itself becomes erotic. The blush is unreadable, and its unreadability is what makes it fascinating. The narrator is a man who has just been furious at a cripple for walking too slowly and who now finds himself transfixed by a stranger's involuntary change of color. His attention is completely ungoverned, seizing on whatever stimulus presents itself with equal intensity.

And then the name:

I feel myself seized with an odd desire to make this lady afraid; to follow her, and annoy her in some way. I overtake her again, pass her by, turn quickly round, and meet her face-to-face in order to observe her well. I stand and gaze into her eyes, and hit, on the spur of the moment, on a name which I have never heard before--a name with a gliding, nervous sound--Ylajali!

The name "Ylajali" is one of the most famous invented words in Scandinavian literature. It comes from nowhere -- "a name with a gliding, nervous sound" -- and it attaches to the woman the way a spell attaches to its object. The narrator does not choose the name; he "hits on" it, as if it were already there, waiting to be found. And the name does not describe the woman; it replaces her. From this moment on, she is not a woman he saw on the street. She is Ylajali, a creation of his own mind, a figure in a private mythology that will persist through the novel.

What the narrator does next is genuinely unnerving. He tells the woman she is losing her book. She has no book. This is not a pick-up line; it is a hallucination dressed as a social gambit, a piece of pure fiction delivered to a stranger as fact. "You are losing your book, madam!" The woman is confused. Her companion dismisses the narrator as drunk. And the

narrator, watching the woman fumble in her pockets for a book that does not exist, is "delighted" by her confusion. The pleasure he takes is not sexual, exactly -- it is the pleasure of the creator, the fiction-writer, the man who can make another person believe in something that is not there.

The scene plays out across several blocks, with the narrator following the two women, repeating his claim about the book, and then retreating in shame when the women's "forbearance" makes him feel guilty. But even his shame is spectacular:

By degrees, a wonderful feeling stole over me of being far, far away in other places; I had a half-undefined sense that it was not I who was going along over the gravel hanging my head.

Dissociation. The narrator is separating from himself, watching himself from outside. Hunger has begun to loosen the bonds between self and body, and the result is not confusion but a strange, dreamlike clarity. He can see everything -- "A large, brown dog sprang right across the street towards the shrubbery," "a servant-maid leant out of it, with her sleeves turned up" -- with a hyper-real precision that is the flip side of his dissociation. The more disconnected he feels from himself, the more vividly he perceives the world.

And consider the moment when the companion says "He is drunk; can't you see that the man is drunk?" The narrator is not drunk. He is starving. But from the outside, starvation and drunkenness produce similar effects: unsteady gait, flushed face, erratic behavior. The companion's diagnosis is wrong in its specifics but right in its intuition that something is chemically off. The narrator does not correct her. He lets the misdiagnosis stand, the way he lets all misreadings of himself stand, because any reading is better than the truth.

The two women turn back, and the narrator follows them to Cisler's music shop, up University Street, toward St. Olav's Place. The pursuit covers several blocks and is rendered with a meticulous attention to geography -- Hamsun names every street, every turning point -- that grounds the scene in the physical reality of Christiania even as the narrator's mind floats further and further from reality. He notes that the women send him "a half-fearful, half-questioning look" with "no resentment nor any trace of a frown in it." This interpretation -- that the women are not angry, merely curious -- may be accurate or may be another projection. The narrator reads faces the way he reads everything: with an intensity that cannot distinguish between what is there and what he has put there.

The sequence ends at the woman's building, No. 2 St. Olav's Place, where the narrator stands at a lamp-post and watches a head appear at a window:

Then something odd happened. The curtains above were stirred, and a second after a window opened, a head popped out, and two singular-looking eyes dwelt on me. "Ylajali!" I muttered, half-aloud, and I felt I grew red.

The name he invented has become a summons. He speaks it and the woman appears. The power of his own fiction has, for one astonishing moment, been confirmed by reality -- or so it seems. Then she turns away, and the narrator describes her turning with an erotic precision that verges on delirium: "I see a shoulder that turns, a back that disappears across the floor. That reluctant turning from the window, the accentuation in that movement of the shoulders was like a nod to me." A shoulder turning becomes a communication, a nod, a message meant for him. The narrator is reading the world the way he reads the newspaper on his wall -- finding meaning everywhere, whether it is there or not.

The Pawnbroker and the Pencil: Performing the Great Author

The narrator recovers his pencil from the pawnshop without difficulty. The pawnbroker is polite, helpful, unremarkable. And the narrator, for absolutely no reason, begins to lie:

"It would never have entered my head to come such a long way for any and every bit of pencil, but with this one it was quite a different matter; there was another reason, a special reason. Insignificant as it looked, this stump of pencil had simply made me what I was in the world, so to say, placed me in life."

The lie is gratuitous. The pawnbroker has asked nothing. He has simply returned a pencil. But the narrator cannot permit a simple transaction. He must transform it into a scene in which he is not a man retrieving a pencil from a pawnshop but a Great Author condescending to visit one. The pencil is not a pencil; it is the instrument of a three-volume dissertation on "Philosophical Cognition." The pawnbroker nods, and the narrator, emboldened, performs his exit "with the bearing of one who had it in his power to place a man in a high position, say in the fire-office."

That parenthetical -- "say in the fire-office" -- is quietly devastating. The fire brigade rejected him. He could not even get hired to fight fires. And now, in his fantasy, he is the one with the power to hire and fire, to place men in positions. The lie has inverted his actual situation so completely that the rejected applicant becomes the patron.

On the stairs, he meets a woman with a travelling-bag and instinctively reaches into his pocket to give her money -- another flash of involuntary generosity -- only to find his pockets empty. He passes on "with my head down." This small moment is the novel in miniature: the impulse to give, the empty pocket, the lowered head.

Carl Johann Street: The Beautiful People and the Yellow Rose

The narrator walks into the fashionable promenading hour on Carl Johann Street, Christiania's main boulevard, and his mood shifts again:

How gaily and lightly these people I met carried their radiant heads, and swung themselves through life as through a ball-room! There was no sorrow in a single look I met, no burden on any shoulder, perhaps not even a clouded thought, not a little hidden pain in any of the happy souls.

This is self-pity, but it is also observation of a very particular kind. The narrator is not just feeling sorry for himself; he is constructing the world around him as a place of universal happiness in order to make his own suffering more singular, more exceptional. Everyone else is radiant. Only he has "forgotten the very look of happiness." The exaggeration serves his pride: he is not merely unfortunate, he is uniquely so.

And then a beautiful passage about the tyranny of detail:

I could not sit down on a bench by myself or set my foot any place without being assailed by insignificant accidents, miserable details, that forced their way into my imagination and scattered my powers to all the four winds. A dog that dashed by me, a yellow rose in a man's buttonhole, had the power to set my thoughts vibrating and occupy me for a length of time.

This is the starving mind described from inside: a mind that cannot filter, cannot prioritize, cannot distinguish between the significant and the trivial. A yellow rose in a buttonhole occupies him "for a length of time." The world has become a series of equal, overwhelming stimuli, each one capable of hijacking his attention. It is not that the narrator is distracted; it is that his distraction has become his primary mode of

being. Everything matters equally, which means nothing matters more, which means the mind simply vibrates, a tuning fork struck by every passing detail.

God's Whims and the Man from South America

At the first scene break within the body of the text, the narrator's attention turns upward, toward God. The transition is startling in its logic:

What was it that ailed me? Was the hand of the Lord turned against me? But why just against me? Why, for that matter, not just as well against a man in South America? When I considered the matter over, it grew more and more incomprehensible to me that I of all others should be selected as an experiment for a Creator's whims.

"Why not a man in South America?" The question is absurd, but it is also perfectly logical within the narrator's frame of reference: if God is choosing to torment someone, why has He picked this particular Norwegian writer? Why not Bookseller Pascha, or Hennechen the steam agent? The narrator names actual Christiania citizens, as if God's selection process were an employment decision, a matter of candidates and qualifications. The effect is both comic and theologically astute. The narrator is arguing with God the way

he argued with the Fire Brigade inspector -- with the baffled indignation of someone who has been passed over for no good reason.

The brevity of this scene is important. It stands between the long first section and the long central section as a kind of hinge, a moment where the narrator lifts his head from his immediate circumstances and asks the big question -- Why me? -- before being pulled back down into the details of his suffering. The second scene break comes just twenty-some lines later, and the effect is of a mind that cannot sustain abstraction, that reaches for theology and then falls back into the body.

The God Passage: A Finger in the Nerves

After the second scene break, the narrator's quarrel with God intensifies into one of the most remarkable passages in the novel. He has been sitting on a park bench, growing "more and more bitter against God for His prolonged inflictions," and he addresses the Almighty directly:

If He meant to draw me nearer to Him, and make me better by exhausting me and placing obstacle after obstacle in my way, I could assure Him He made a slight mistake. And, almost crying with defiance, I looked up towards Heaven and told Him so mentally, once and for all.

The tone here is superb -- not blasphemous rage but a kind of exasperated reasonableness, as if the narrator were writing a letter of complaint to a government office. God has made "a slight mistake." The phrasing is that of a man who is too proud to beg but too angry to stay silent, who will address the Creator of the universe the way he addressed the old beggar: with an insistence on his own dignity that is both heroic and slightly mad.

What follows is the novel's most extraordinary piece of sustained prose, a passage in which the narrator's consciousness slides from defiance into a kind of involuntary liturgy:

Fragments of the teachings of my childhood ran through my memory. The rhythmical sound of Biblical language sang in my ears, and I talked quite softly to myself, and held my head sneeringly askew. Wherefore should I sorrow for what I eat, for what I drink, or for what I may array this miserable food for worms called my earthy body? Hath not my Heavenly Father provided for me, even as for the sparrow on the housetop, and hath He not in His graciousness pointed towards His lowly servitor?

The narrator has not decided to pray. The language of the Bible has simply risen in him, unbidden, the way the name Ylajali rose when he saw the woman on the street. He speaks

in King James cadences -- "Wherefore should I sorrow," "Hath not my Heavenly Father" -- and the language has its own momentum, carrying him forward into territory he did not intend to enter. The sneering posture ("held my head sneeringly askew") is maintained even as the language becomes devotional. He is performing both mockery and prayer simultaneously, and neither one is quite voluntary.

Then the passage breaks through into something wilder:

The Lord stuck His finger in the net of my nerves gently-- yea, verily, in desultory fashion--and brought slight disorder among the threads. And then the Lord withdrew His finger, and there were fibres and delicate root-like filaments adhering to the finger, and they were the nerve-threads of the filaments. And there was a gaping hole after the finger, which was God's finger, and a wound in my brain in the track of His finger.

This is astonishing. The narrator has created an image of God that is at once biblical in its language and neurological in its content. God does not smite or punish. He sticks a finger into the net of the narrator's nerves and withdraws it, pulling filaments and threads with it, leaving a gaping hole. The image is of brain damage described in the language of Genesis, a medical event narrated as scripture. The "desultory

fashion" -- casual, without method -- is the most terrifying part. God is not even paying attention. He pokes, he withdraws, he leaves a wound, and he moves on.

The passage continues: "But when God had touched me with His finger, He let me be, and touched me no more, and let no evil befall me; but let me depart in peace, and let me depart with the gaping hole." This is not comfort. It is abandonment dressed in the language of mercy. God has damaged the narrator and then let him go, which is worse than continued punishment because it means the damage is permanent and purposeless. The "gaping hole" is both a literal description of what hunger does to the brain and a theological proposition: God is the one who makes holes in people and then wanders off.

The Shoes: Recognition of the Self

The narrator cannot write. Mosquitoes land on his paper and will not be blown away. He watches them set "their heels against a comma" -- a wonderful detail, the insects anchoring themselves to his punctuation. He gives up, leans back, and lets his gaze fall on his own body:

As I lie in this position, and let my eyes glide down my breast and along my legs, I notice the jerking movement my foot makes each time my pulse beats. I half rise and

look down at my feet, and I experience at this moment a fantastic and singular feeling that I have never felt before--a delicate, wonderful shock through my nerves, as if sparks of cold light quivered through them--it was as if catching sight of my shoes I had met with a kind old acquaintance, or got back a part of myself that had been riven loose.

The pulse in the foot is the starting point -- the body calling attention to itself, the visible proof that he is still alive. And then the shoes become something more than shoes. They are "a kind old acquaintance," a part of himself that has been "riven loose." The narrator is so hungry, so dissociated, that his own shoes have become Other, and the act of seeing them is an act of reunion. He begins to weep.

What follows is one of the most discussed passages in the novel (explored at greater length in *The Invention of the Interior*), but it deserves to be quoted again here for its prose alone:

As if I had never seen my shoes before, I set myself to study their looks, their characteristics, and, when I stir my foot, their shape and their worn uppers. I discover that their creases and white seams give them expression--impart a physiognomy to them. Something of my own

nature had gone over into these shoes; they affected me, like a ghost of my other I--a breathing portion of my very self.

"A breathing portion of my very self." The shoes breathe. They have a face. They are not like the narrator; they are the narrator, or a part of him that has migrated into leather and thread. This is not a metaphor. It is a description of what dissociation actually feels like from inside -- the experience of encountering your own belongings as if they were alive, as if they contained more of you than your body does. The narrator scolds himself -- "Weakness!" -- and clenches his fists, but the feeling persists. The shoes have a physiognomy. They have expression. They are, in some uncanny way, more real to him than his own face.

The Old Man on the Bench: Happolati

A little old man sits down at the other end of the bench, and the narrator's attention swings toward him with the same ungovernable intensity it brought to the shoes, the yellow rose, the woman's tooth. The old man is holding a newspaper with something rolled up inside it, and the narrator becomes consumed with curiosity about this package:

The insane idea entered my head that it might be a quite peculiar newspaper--unique of its kind. My curiosity increased, and I began to move backwards and forwards on the seat. It might contain deeds, dangerous documents stolen from some archive or other; something floated before me about a secret treaty--a conspiracy.

A newspaper wrapped around some food (as it will turn out to be) becomes, in the narrator's mind, a vessel for stolen documents, secret treaties, conspiracies. The escalation from curiosity to paranoid fantasy takes about three sentences. The narrator's imagination works the way fire works: give it a small piece of fuel and it will consume everything in reach.

The narrator offers the old man a cigarette he does not have -- "I slapped my empty breast-pocket" -- another performance of a social gesture backed by nothing. The old man declines; he is nearly blind. They begin to talk, and the narrator, asked where he lives, gives the address of the woman he followed earlier: "St. Olav's Place, No. 2." The lie is "involuntary," "without any object," "without any *arriere pensee*." It simply comes, the way all his lies come, a reflex rather than a strategy.

The old man asks for a landlord's name, and the narrator invents one:

"Happolati!" said I.

This single word -- Happolati -- launches one of the great comic set-pieces in the novel. The name is absurd, foreign, unmistakably invented. And the old man accepts it without a blink. "Happolati, ay!" he nods, "and he never missed a syllable of this difficult name." The narrator is amazed and annoyed. He expected the lie to astonish. Instead it was swallowed whole.

So he escalates. Happolati becomes an agent -- "Cranberries from China; feathers and down from Russia; hides, pulp, writing-ink." Then an inventor of electric psalm-books. Then a former Minister of State in Persia ("You perhaps have no conception of what it means to be Minister of State in Persia?"). Then the father of Ylajali, "a fairy, a princess, who had three hundred slaves, and who reclined on a couch of yellow roses."

The yellow roses are a callback to the roses on Carl Johann Street, the ones in the man's buttonhole that occupied the narrator "for a length of time." And Ylajali has migrated from the woman on the street to Happolati's daughter, gathering fantasy-attributes as she goes: "Eyes like raw silk, arms of amber! Just one glance from her was as seductive as a kiss; and when she called me, her voice darted like a wine-ray right into my soul's phosphor."

"A wine-ray right into my soul's phosphor." This is not a description of a woman. It is a description of the experience of inventing a woman, the intoxicating pleasure of language creating beauty out of nothing. The narrator is drunk on his own fictions. "The blood flew to my head, and I roared with laughter." He is, at this moment, a man creating literature -- not the article he cannot write, but an oral performance of pure invention, stories that "floated in singular visions across my mental eye."

And then, because this is Hunger, the pleasure collapses into rage. The old man accepts everything placidly, and the narrator explodes:

"Hell and fire, man! Do you imagine that I am sitting here stuffing you chock-full of lies?" I roared furiously. "Perhaps you don't even believe that a man of the name of Hapolati exists! I never saw your match for obstinacy and malice in any old man."

The logic is insane and perfect. The narrator is furious at the old man for believing him. He has been telling elaborate lies, and the old man's credulity has robbed the lies of their power. The pleasure was in the performance, in the friction between invention and reality, and the old man's mildness has eliminated the friction. So the narrator rages at him for being

too trusting, accuses him of "obstinacy and malice" -- the exact opposite of what the old man has displayed -- and drives him away.

The narrator watches the old man's retreating figure "that seemed to shrink at each step" and feels no remorse: "I had never in my life seen a more vile back than this one." The back is vile because it is retreating -- because the old man is leaving, and the narrator's audience is gone, and the performance is over, and the performer is alone on a bench in a park with nothing.

Autumn in the Park: The Carnival of Decay

After the old man's departure, the narrator's mood descends, and the prose descends with it into one of the novel's most beautiful lyric passages:

The day began to decline, the sun sank, it commenced to rustle lightly in the trees around, and the nursemaids who sat in groups near the parallel bars made ready to wheel their perambulators home.

The nursemaids have been there since the beginning of the park sequence -- they were mentioned early on, "two nursemaids trundling their perambulators" near the Queen's arbour. Now they are leaving. The park is emptying. The narrator's world is contracting.

He tries again to write. He sits and writes "the date, 1848, in each corner" -- 1848, forty-two years in the past, a date that has no connection to anything except the disorder in his mind. (This date will return with devastating consequences when it appears on his job application.) And then, unable to produce an article, he produces instead a prose poem about autumn:

It is the reign of Autumn, the height of the Carnival of Decay, the roses have got inflammation in their blushes, an uncanny hectic tinge, through their soft damask.

"The Carnival of Decay." The phrase is magnificent. Autumn is not a decline but a celebration of decline, a carnival in which everything is dying gorgeously. The roses have "inflammation in their blushes" -- they are sick, the redness that makes them beautiful is a fever, a "hectic tinge." The word "hectic" carries its older medical meaning here (the flush of tuberculosis), and the personification is both lush and menacing. The roses are beautiful because they are dying, and the narrator identifies

with them: "I felt myself like a creeping thing on the verge of destruction, gripped by ruin in the midst of a whole world ready for lethargic sleep."

But notice what precedes this passage. The narrator has been watching insects -- not the mosquitoes on his paper, now, but the insects in the grass around the bench: "They poke their yellow heads up from the turf, lift their legs, feel their way with long feelers and then collapse suddenly, roll over, and turn their bellies in the air." The insect observation is presented as part of the autumn meditation, but it is also the narrator's own situation in miniature. He pokes his head up, lifts his limbs, feels his way, and collapses. The identification is never made explicit -- the narrator does not say "I am like these insects" -- but the reader feels it. And then the gorgeous sentence about the stubbles and the falling leaves: "The stubbles straggle wanly sunwards, and the falling leaves rustle to the earth, with a sound as of errant silkworms." The simile is extraordinary -- leaves sounding like silkworms -- because it converts autumn into something textile, something that can be woven, and because "errant" carries the double meaning of wandering and mistaken. The leaves are both lost and wrong, which is exactly what the narrator is.

He pulls himself together, forces himself to write, and produces "a couple of pages as an introduction." But his thoughts disintegrate again, and one of the novel's starkest images emerges:

I felt how my brain positively snapped and my head emptied, until it sat at last, light, buoyant, and void on my shoulders. I was conscious of the gaping vacuum in my skull with every fibre of my being. I seemed to myself to be hollowed out from top and toe.

The brain "snapped" -- not cracked, not broke, but snapped, the sound of something small and definitive. And then the head is "light, buoyant, and void," floating on the shoulders like a balloon. The narrator is becoming hollow, a shell, and he can feel the hollowness with "every fibre." The image rhymes with the earlier passage about God's finger leaving "a gaping hole" in the brain. The hole has expanded. The narrator is now all hole.

"In my pain I cried: 'Lord, my God and Father!' and repeated this cry many times at a stretch, without adding one word more." This is perhaps the closest the novel comes to genuine prayer -- stripped of the sneering posture, stripped of the biblical parody, reduced to a single repeated cry. The narrator has run out of words. The man who invents

names and tells elaborate lies and writes articles that never get finished has been reduced to a single phrase, repeated over and over. It is the zero point of language.

The Old Man Again: Claws and Bread

Leaving the park, the narrator encounters the old man from the bench again. The mysterious package has been opened:

The mysterious new paper parcel lay opened on the seat next him, filled with different sorts of victuals, of which he ate as he sat. I immediately wanted to go over and ask pardon for my conduct, but the sight of food repelled me. The decrepit fingers looked like ten claws as they clutched loathsomely at the greasy bread and butter.

The "stolen documents" and "secret treaty" turn out to be bread and butter. The conspiracy was a packed lunch. But the narrator cannot register this comic anticlimax because his attention has been seized by the old man's fingers, which look "like ten claws" clutching "loathsomely" at the food. The adverb "loathsomely" is applied to the bread and butter, not to the fingers -- the food itself is loathsome, contaminated by the act of being eaten by someone the narrator despises. And the narrator, who has not eaten since his cheese and roll

that morning, is "repelled" by the sight of food. His body has turned against sustenance again, the way it turned against sausage when the one-toothed woman looked at him.

"He did not recognize me; his eyes stared at me, dry as horn, and his face did not move a muscle." The old man has already forgotten the narrator. The performance of Happolati, the rage, the invented princess -- none of it has left a mark. The narrator is invisible to the man he terrorized. This is a more devastating rejection than any of the job refusals, because it is a rejection of his very existence as a person who can affect others.

"And so I went on my way." This is one of the simplest sentences in Part I, and one of the saddest. The narrator cannot apologize (the food repels him), cannot connect (the old man does not recognize him), and so he simply walks on. The sentence has the rhythm of resignation, of a man who has used up all his energy on fictions and performances and has nothing left for actual human contact. It is also, quietly, a structural pivot: the narrator is now heading out of the park, out of the long central day, and into the evening that will test him more severely than anything before.

The Landlady's Note and the Rocking Chair at Night

Arriving home, the narrator finds a note from his landlady asking him to pay his rent or move out. "Friendlily Mrs. Gundersen" -- the adverb, so awkward in English, carries a particular sting. The landlady is being friendly about an eviction. She has even apologized: "I must not be offended, it was absolutely a necessary request." The courtesy is genuine and the necessity is real, and the narrator, who has spent the day performing generosity to strangers, must now confront the fact that a woman who has housed him is forced to beg for what she is owed.

He writes an application to the grocer, posts it, and returns to the rocking chair: "I sat down in the rocking-chair to think, whilst the darkness grew closer and closer. Sitting up late began to be difficult now." The darkness is literal -- he has no lamp, no candle -- but the sentence "Sitting up late began to be difficult now" is doing something else. It describes a man who is running out of ways to occupy himself after dark. Without light, without a book, without a stove, the evening becomes a cavity to be endured. The rocking chair, site of musing and consciousness, is now just a place where a man sits in the dark until he can justify going to sleep.

The Grocer and the Date: 1848

The narrator spots an advertisement for a bookkeeping position, writes an application, and posts it. He returns to his room, sits in the rocking chair, and the next morning produces a burst of inspired writing. The writing scene is rendered with an ecstatic energy that matches the narrator's experience:

Suddenly a few good sentences fitted for a sketch or story strike me, delicate linguistic hits of which I have never before found the equal. I lie and repeat these words over to myself, and find that they are capital. Little by little others come and fit themselves to the preceding ones. I grow keenly wakeful. I get up and snatch paper and pencil from the table behind my bed. It was as if a vein had burst in me; one word follows another, and they fit themselves together harmoniously with telling effect.

"As if a vein had burst in me" -- the image is violent. Inspiration is not a gentle rising but a rupture, a hemorrhage of language. The narrator writes "as one possessed," fills "page after page, without a moment's pause." Thoughts come "so richly that I miss a number of telling bits, that I cannot set down quickly enough." The hand cannot keep up

with the mind. This is the inverse of the park scene, where the mind was empty and the hand had nothing to write. Now the mind is overflowing, and the hand is inadequate.

Notice the physicality of this scene. The narrator writes in bed, in the dark, in the hours before dawn. The words come through his body -- "a vein had burst" -- and the hand races to keep up. He writes "fifteen -- twenty" pages, and the uncertainty about the count is part of the rapture. He does not know how many pages he has produced. He has been in a state beyond counting. And then the shift into daylight: "I can half distinguish the lighthouse director's announcement down near the door." The first thing he read when he woke the morning before -- the notice on the wall -- is the first thing he sees when he emerges from his writing trance. The room has not changed. He has.

His confidence inflates immediately. He values his work "at a loose guess, for five shillings on the spot," then revises upward: "getting it for half-a-sovereign might be considered dirt-cheap." And in a passage of exquisite comedy, he surveys the room he is about to leave and finds it contemptible:

The poor little rocking-chair over in the corner was in reality a mere attempt at a rocking-chair; with the smallest sense of humour, one might easily split one's sides with laughter at it.

The rocking chair -- the "only thing I had to divert myself with," the seat of his inner life -- is now an object of scorn. The narrator has already left this room in his mind. He writes a note to his landlady promising five shillings, kneels at the bedside to thank God, and slips down the stairs.

Then the long, agonizing wait. He wraps his blanket at Semb's shop, inventing a story about "two costly glass vases" going to Smyrna. He meets an acquaintance called "Missy" and tells him he is a bookkeeper at "Christensen's -- a wholesale house." The lie is specific and ordinary, the opposite of Happolati. The narrator can modulate his fictions: fantastical for the blind man, plausible for the social acquaintance. Missy recommends his tailor; the narrator demands repayment of a ten-shilling debt (which may or may not exist); then regrets it; then escapes.

At Semb's shop, the narrator wraps his blanket in paper and tells the shop boy it contains "two costly glass vases" destined for Smyrna. The lie is perfectly scaled to its audience: the shop boy is a young man who can be awed, and the specificity of "Smyrna" -- not just "overseas" but a

particular Turkish port -- lends the fiction an air of cosmopolitan authority. "This had a famous effect. The fellow apologized with every movement he made." The shop boy, who had shrugged at the blanket, now holds the door open and bows twice. The narrator has converted contempt into deference with a single invented detail. He is, in his way, an astonishing performer.

Then the encounter with "Missy," an acquaintance, in the marketplace. The narrator tells him the blanket-parcel is cloth for a new suit and that he is employed as a bookkeeper at "Christensen's -- a wholesale house." Missy recommends his tailor. The narrator is annoyed: "What did he want to poke his nose in my affairs for?" The annoyance is a mirror of the scene with the beggar -- any scrutiny of his situation, even well-meaning, is intolerable. And then, in a characteristic swerve, the narrator demands repayment of ten shillings, immediately regrets it, "got ashamed and avoided meeting his eyes," and escapes. The shame is not about the money. It is about having revealed need. To ask for money back is to admit that money matters, and the narrator's entire performance depends on money not mattering.

He drops off his manuscript at the newspaper office, where "Scissors" (a wonderful nickname for the sub-editor who clips and pastes) treats it casually. Then hours of wandering, of waiting, of confidence draining away. He sits in

Our Saviour's Cemetery near the Mortuary Chapel -- a choice of resting place that is both practical (it is quiet, the seat is free) and grimly symbolic. "Was it certain that the story really was a little masterpiece of inspired art? ... It was perhaps mediocre enough in its way, perhaps downright worthless."

The reversal is complete. The narrator who valued his work at half-a-sovereign that morning now suspects it is "downright worthless." His confidence, like his euphoria on the street, is a function of his physical state -- high when fed, collapsing as the hours pass. The writing has not changed; his body has. And because he cannot separate his assessment of his work from his physical condition, every fluctuation in blood sugar becomes a literary judgment. This is one of the novel's most unsettling insights: that our sense of our own talent is as much a bodily phenomenon as our sense of warmth or cold.

In his panic, he walks out of the city entirely -- "past St. Han's Hill, until I came to the open fields; on through the narrow quaint lanes in Sagene, past waste plots and small tilled fields, and found myself at last on a country road, the end of which I could not see." This is flight. The narrator is literally running from the possibility that his manuscript is no good. He burns the anxiety off through his legs, through miles of walking, until he reaches a road whose end is invisible and must turn back. On the return, he meets two hay-cart drivers

who whip his hat off and laugh. The whip-lash across his ear is a small, gratuitous cruelty -- the kind of thing that happens to people who look vulnerable -- and the narrator responds with characteristic understatement: "I raised my hand to my head more or less confusedly." The hat in the ditch, the swollen ear, the laughter of men who have work and hay and a destination -- the scene compresses class and humiliation into a single flick of a whip.

The rush to the editor's office is one of Part I's great set-pieces of physical desperation. The narrator has been told by a man on the road that it is "past four," and he sprints back to town: "I ran, jostled against folk, stumbled, knocked against cars, left everybody behind me, competed with the very horses, struggled like a madman to arrive there in time." The verbs accumulate like footsteps -- ran, jostled, stumbled, knocked, competed, struggled -- each one faster than the last. And then the arrival: "I wrenched through the door, took the stairs in four bounds, and knocked." No answer. The narrator thinks the editor has left. He tries the door -- open -- knocks again, enters. The editor is sitting at his desk and has not yet read the manuscript. "Oh, I haven't found time to read your sketch yet." The narrator, who has just sprinted through the city in a state of mortal panic, replies with elaborate courtesy: "Oh, pray, sir, don't mention it. I quite understand -- there is no hurry; in a few days, perhaps --" The

gap between his physical state (gasping, desperate, starving) and his verbal performance (calm, deferential, unhurried) is pure Hamsun. The narrator can always find one more mask.

But he forgets to give his new address, which means the editor's response, when it comes, will go to the room he has already abandoned. This small oversight will structure the entire rest of Part I: the letter is waiting in a room the narrator thinks he has left forever.

He applies to the grocer, Christie, in person. The grocer pulls out the application and begins to laugh:

"Well now, you shall see," he said, taking my letter out of his breast-pocket, "if you will just be good enough to see how you deal with dates, sir. You dated your letter 1848," and the man roared with laughter.

The date from the park. The date the narrator wrote "criss-cross, in all possible fashions" while he sat on the bench trying to produce an article. The meaningless, obsessive scribbling of 1848 has migrated from his private distraction into his formal correspondence and destroyed his only prospect of employment. The grocer has already hired someone else. The narrator's madness, which seemed harmless and even comic in the park, has reached out and sabotaged his life.

This is one of Hamsun's most devastating structural devices: a detail planted early (the date), treated as a trivial eccentricity, and then detonated much later as a catastrophe. The narrator's inner disorder is not separate from his outer circumstances. It is his outer circumstances. His mind is destroying his life, and it is doing so through the smallest possible mechanism -- a date written in the wrong century.

The Young Lady in Grey: Mistaken for a Beggar

Fury propels the narrator through the streets. He jostles pedestrians, screams at a man, nearly provokes a fight with a policeman. And then, in one of the novel's most painful scenes, he finds himself running up the stairs of a building and ringing a doorbell on the second floor. He does not know why he has done this. "Why should I stop exactly on the second floor? And why just seize hold of this bell?"

A young lady in a grey gown opens the door:

"No, we have not got anything today," and she made a feint to close the door.

She has mistaken him for a beggar. The narrator's clothes, his manner, his frantic ringing -- all of it reads, to this woman, as a man looking for a handout. This is the moment the

narrator's performance of respectability finally fails. He has dampened his trouser-knees, he has wrapped his blanket to look like a parcel from Smyrna, he has lied to every acquaintance about his circumstances -- and none of it matters. A stranger takes one look at him and sees a beggar.

The narrator's recovery is instantaneous and brilliant. He invents on the spot a fiction about "an invalid gentleman who has advertised for a man to wheel him about in a chair," drops the name Wedel-Jarlsberg (one of Norway's most prominent aristocratic families), and bows his way out with such dignity that the young lady "blushed crimson" and "could not stir from the spot." He has turned a humiliation into a performance, a refusal into an occasion for someone else's embarrassment. But the moment has registered:

So it had gone so far with me that any one might point at me, and say to himself, "There goes a beggar--one of those people who get their food handed out to them at folk's back-doors!"

For all his lies and performances, the narrator has arrived at a moment of brutal self-recognition. He is a beggar. Not by his own account, not in his own mind, but in the eyes of the world. The gap between his inner life -- grandiose, inventive,

full of schemes and fictions -- and his outer appearance has become uncrossable. The woman in the grey gown has seen through everything.

The Night: No Shelter

The final section of Part I tracks the narrator through an increasingly desperate night. He has no room (having left his lodgings that morning in a fit of grandiose confidence), no money, no food. The city contracts around him. He stands outside the fire brigade watch-house, considers trying to sneak inside, and approaches the watchman -- who lifts his ax in salute. "The uplifted ax, with its edge turned against me, darts like a cold slash through my nerves." The ax is not a threat; it is a greeting. But the narrator, in his state of nervous exhaustion, experiences the salute as a weapon. The fire brigade rejected him once, and now its watchman holds a blade between them. He slinks away, "as if I had forgotten something or other," performing casual forgetfulness to cover his terror.

He tries to visit the artist C. Zacharias Bartel, who has "a little girl inside this evening" and cannot receive him. The brevity of this encounter is the point -- the narrator knocks, is turned away in three exchanges, and departs. The door closes. The social world has no room for him. He considers

sleeping in the woods, wanders past a provision shop where "a cat lay there and slept beside a round French roll" -- one of the novel's most piercing juxtapositions: the cat is warm, fed, asleep beside bread, while the narrator stands in the street and stares. He walks all the way out to Bogstad's wood, past Majorstuen, along the road "the end of which I could not see," and makes a bed of heather and juniper.

The walk itself deserves attention. He walks "very slowly, passed by Majorstuen, went on, always on -- it seemed to me for hours." Hamsun names the actual neighborhoods and streets of Christiania, and the effect is of a man walking through a real city that is slowly becoming unreal. The streets have names. The houses have numbers. The lamps have light. And none of it belongs to him. He passes through the city like a ghost, visible to no one, heading for the woods at the edge of town where he can lie down without being asked to leave.

The night in the woods produces one of the novel's most beautiful passages:

And the great spirit of darkness spread a shroud over me ... everything was silent--everything. But up in the heights souged the everlasting song, the voice of the air, the distant, toneless humming which is never silent. I listened

so long to this ceaseless faint murmur that it began to bewilder me; it was surely a symphony from the rolling spheres above. Stars that intone a song....

The "everlasting song" is the sound of wind in trees, or the sound of blood in his own ears, or the sound of nothing at all -- the hum that the brain manufactures in the absence of other stimuli. The narrator, cold and hungry and alone in the dark, transforms this ambient noise into a cosmic symphony, "stars that intone a song." His mind is doing what it always does: making meaning, making beauty, making too much of too little.

And then the characteristic self-correction:

"I am damned if it is, though," I exclaimed; and I laughed aloud to collect my wits. "They're night-owls hooting in Canaan!"

The cosmic symphony becomes owls. The narrator catches himself in mid-transcendence and pulls himself back to earth with a curse and a laugh. This is the novel's recurrent rhythm: the climb toward ecstasy, the sudden collapse into bathos. The narrator cannot sustain any state for long. His consciousness is a pendulum, swinging between grandiosity and deflation, and the speed of the swing is accelerating.

The Morning After: The Brain Curtain Tears

He wakes in the woods, walks back to town, and hunger begins "to assail me downright in earnest." He reads the menu at the Dampkokken and shrugs his shoulders "in a way to attract attention, as if corned beef or salt pork was not meet food for me." Even starving, even desperate, the narrator is still performing -- performing indifference to food, performing the role of a man too refined for corned beef.

Then something structural breaks:

A singular sense of confusion suddenly darted through my head. I stumbled on, determined not to heed it; but I grew worse and worse, and was forced at last to sit down on a step. My whole being underwent a change, as if something had slid aside in my inner self, or as if a curtain or tissue of my brain was rent in two.

"A curtain or tissue of my brain was rent in two." This is not metaphor in the ordinary sense. The narrator is describing a physical sensation -- the feeling that something has torn inside his head, that the architecture of consciousness has been altered. The image of the brain-curtain recalls the earlier passage about God's finger poking through the "net of

nerves," but it is more severe. The finger left a hole; this is a rending, a tearing in two. The narrator's mind is coming apart at the seams, and he can feel it happening.

He considers pawning Hans Pauli's blanket -- the blanket that belongs to someone else, the one he has been carrying all day in its Smyrna wrapping paper. He is "already on my way to the pawn-shop" but stops at the door, "shook my head irresolutely, then turned back. The farther away I got the more gladsome, ay, delighted I became, that I had conquered this strong temptation." Watch the word "gladsome" -- it is archaic, elevated, almost biblical. The narrator's relief at not stealing is expressed in the language of spiritual triumph. He has conquered a temptation, and the conquest fills him with "a splendid sense of having principle, character, of being a shining white beacon in a muddy, human sea amidst floating wreck." The metaphor is absurd in its grandiosity -- he is not a beacon; he is a starving man who decided not to pawn a blanket -- but it is also moving, because the narrator has so little left that his own integrity is the only thing he can still be proud of. The temptation to steal is treated as a moral crisis of the first order:

Pawn another man's property for the sake of a meal, eat and drink one's self to perdition, brand one's soul with the first little scar, set the first black mark against one's honour, call one's self a blackguard to one's own face, and needs must cast one's eyes down before one's self?

The passage is magnificent in its escalation. A single act -- pawning a blanket -- becomes perdition, a scarred soul, a blackguard's face in the mirror. The narrator's moral universe is as inflated as his literary ambitions: every small decision is a crisis of honor, every temptation a fall from grace. He cannot simply decide not to pawn the blanket because it would be wrong. He must dramatize the decision into an epic of integrity, must feel himself "a shining white beacon in a muddy, human sea amidst floating wreck." Even his virtue is a performance.

The Night in Town: Policemen and the Return

Denied the grocer's job, unable to eat, the narrator drifts through the evening streets. He discovers his shaving-tickets -- six of them, worth about sixpence. "The Lord be praised," he had exclaimed earlier, "I can still get shaved for a couple of weeks, and look a little decent." Shaving-tickets are a tool of respectability, and now they are currency. He decides to sell them, along with his tie, to an acquaintance he spots

outside the Opland Cafe. But the acquaintance has no money -- "I was out last night and got totally cleared out!" -- and his blue eyes are "moist" with genuine regret. The narrator retreats, pressing the little packet on him as a gift: "Keep it! keep it ... There are only a few trifles in it -- a bagatelle; about all I own in the world."

The phrase "about all I own in the world" is delivered as if it were an insignificance, a bagatelle, but the narrator hears his own words and is undone by them. He weeps in the street:

I walked, and cried as I walked, down the whole street; felt more and more commiseration with myself, and repeated, time after time, a few words, an ejaculation, which called forth fresh tears whenever they were on the point of ceasing: "Lord God, I feel so wretched! Lord God, I feel so wretched!"

This is one of the rawest moments in the novel. The narrator is not performing for anyone. He is alone in the dark, walking and crying and talking to himself. And the repetition of "Lord God, I feel so wretched!" is both a genuine cry of anguish and a mechanism for producing more anguish -- he says the words, feels their pathos, weeps, and says them again. He is feeding on his own suffering the way he earlier fed on his own fictions. The mind is omnivorous.

He finds a spot behind a deal hoarding and is discovered by a policeman:

"Good-night," he said.

"Good-night," I answered and got afraid.

"Where do you live?" he queried.

I name, from habit, and without thought, my old address, the little attic.

The policeman's "Good-night" is tender, almost paternal. He does not arrest the narrator or threaten him; he suggests he go home. And the narrator, "from habit, and without thought," gives the address of the room he has already vacated. This is not a lie in the usual sense. It is a reflex, the body's muscle memory answering a question the mind has not processed. The narrator has been performing a homeless man who has an address, and the performance has become automatic.

So he goes back. He creeps up the stairs, removes his shoes, counts the creaking steps -- "there were eight steps in all, and only the two top ones creaked under my tread." The precision of this detail is heartrending. He knows exactly which steps make noise. He has crept up and down these stairs many times, evading his landlady, and his body has memorized the topography of evasion.

The Letter: Light Under a Gas Lamp

Inside the room, everything is as he left it. The curtains are aside, the bed is empty. But there is a letter on the table. The narrator assumes it is from his landlady, a final eviction notice:

I fumbled with my hands over the white spot, and felt, to my astonishment, that it was a letter. I take it over to the window, examine as well as it is possible in the dark the badly-written letters of the address, and make out at least my own name.

He does not open the letter in the room. He cannot read it in the dark, and he has no lamp. So he carries it downstairs, puts on his shoes, and walks to a gas lamp on the street. The physical journey from the dark room to the lit street is rendered with meticulous attention to each step: the shoes, the laces, the sitting quietly, the walking, the leaning against the lamp-post. Hamsun slows time almost to a standstill. The reader knows something is in the letter. The narrator assumes the worst. And the delay -- the shoes, the laces, the walk -- stretches the anticipation to a point of almost unbearable tension.

Then:

A stream of light, as it were, darts through my breast, and I hear that I give a little cry--a meaningless sound of joy. The letter was from the editor. My story was accepted--had been set in type immediately, straight off! A few slight alterations.... A couple of errors in writing amended.... Worked out with talent ... be printed tomorrow ... half-a-sovereign.

The passage is extraordinary in its fragmentation. The narrator cannot hold the information in complete sentences. It arrives in pieces, separated by ellipses, each phrase a separate shock: "A few slight alterations.... A couple of errors in writing amended.... Worked out with talent..." The most important phrase -- "Worked out with talent" -- is the editor's polite professional assessment, but to the narrator, in his shattered state, it is a sacrament. He cannot paraphrase it; he can only repeat it.

And notice "I hear that I give a little cry." He hears himself cry, as if from outside his own body. The dissociation that has troubled him all day -- the feeling of being "far, far away in other places" -- is here converted into something like rapture. He is outside himself with joy, hearing his own voice the way he might hear a stranger's.

The final lines of Part I are among the most famous in Scandinavian literature:

All through the night until the bright dawn I "jodled" about the streets and repeated--"Worked out with talent-- therefore a little masterpiece--a stroke of genius--and half-a-sovereign."

The logic is lunatic and perfect. "Worked out with talent" becomes "a little masterpiece" becomes "a stroke of genius," each phrase inflating the last, the narrator's mind doing exactly what it has done all day: transforming the modest into the magnificent. The word "therefore" -- that little logical connector -- is doing absurd work, pretending that each inflation follows necessarily from the one before, as if talent logically implies masterpiece implies genius. And the half-sovereign comes last, tacked on with an "and," as if money were an afterthought, a minor detail appended to the real news.

The word "jodled" -- yodeled -- is the final touch. The narrator is not walking or even singing. He is yodeling, making the wild, ululating sound of the Alpine mountains, alone in the streets of Christiania at dawn. The verb carries both ecstasy and absurdity. It is the sound of uncontainable joy, and it is also the sound of a half-mad, starving man howling in the street because a newspaper has agreed to print his sketch for ten shillings.

The Architecture of Part I

Step back for a moment and look at the shape of the thing. Part I covers roughly thirty-six hours -- from six in the morning of the first day to dawn of the second. In that time, the narrator wakes, goes out, gives away money he does not have, eats his one meal, follows a woman, invents a mythology, terrorizes an old man, fails to write an article, leaves his lodgings, submits a manuscript, applies for a job, sleeps in the woods, returns to town, is mistaken for a beggar, weeps in the street, sneaks back into his room, and reads the letter that saves him. The emotional trajectory looks like an EKG -- violent spikes of euphoria separated by deepening troughs of despair, the amplitude increasing as the body weakens.

But the true architecture is not in the events. It is in the narrator's relationship to his own fictions. Part I is organized around a series of lies, inventions, and performances: the dampened trouser-knees, the waistcoat pawned for a stranger, the name Ylajali, the three-volume dissertation, the landlord Happolati, the glass vases bound for Smyrna, the bookkeeping job at Christensen's, the aristocratic name Wedel-Jarlsberg, the invalid gentleman in the chair. Each invention is more elaborate than the last, and each one

serves the same function: to place a fiction between the narrator and his actual situation, to construct a self that the world might find worthy of respect.

And the manuscript -- the one real piece of writing the narrator produces -- sits at the center of this web of fictions as the one fiction that might become true. The narrator cannot distinguish between his lies and his art, because they come from the same source: the desperate, generative, ungovernable activity of a mind that cannot stop making things up. When the editor writes "Worked out with talent," he is confirming not just the quality of the sketch but the legitimacy of the narrator's entire way of being. The lies are vindicated by the art. The performance of being a writer has been validated by actually writing something good.

This is why the ending of Part I feels like salvation even though we know -- or should know -- that it is temporary. The half-sovereign will be spent. The euphoria will collapse. Part II will begin, and the cycle will start again. But for this one moment, in the flickering light of a gas lamp, the narrator's faith in himself and God's faith in him and the editor's faith in his talent all converge in a single stream of light through the breast, and the man yodels in the street at dawn, and everything is possible, and nothing is solved.

A Note on Translation

A word about what we are reading when we read this translation. The text used here is George Egerton's 1899 English translation, the first in English, and still the version that many readers encounter. Egerton (the pen name of Mary Chavelita Dunne Bright) was herself a writer of considerable power, a figure in the New Woman movement, and a translator of uncommon sensitivity to the rhythms of Scandinavian prose. Her *Hunger* preserves much of the strange, lurching energy of Hamsun's Norwegian, the way sentences veer from formality into colloquialism, from self-pity into rage, from despair into comedy.

But it is a translation of its era, and it smooths some of Hamsun's rougher edges. Where Hamsun's Norwegian shifts tenses abruptly, sometimes within a single sentence, moving from past to present and back in a way that mimics the disorder of the narrator's mind, Egerton tends to regularize. Where Hamsun's phrasing is blunt and even crude, Egerton sometimes reaches for a Victorian gentility -- "the garb of a respectable man," "my Uncle" (for the pawnshop). The word "shillings" for the Norwegian currency flattens the Christiania specificity into a generically British register.

Still, Egerton gets the essential thing right: the voice. Her narrator is unmistakably the same creature as Hamsun's -- proud, frantic, inventive, self-sabotaging, capable of both the sublimest flights and the most embarrassing deceptions. The translation has the feel of a performance, which is appropriate for a novel that is itself one long, desperate, brilliant performance. Later translations by Robert Bly (1967) and Sverre Lyngstad (1996) are closer to the Norwegian in various ways, but Egerton's remains the one with the most distinctive pulse, the one that sounds most like a voice speaking from inside a state of emergency.

What to Watch For in Part II

Part I ends with the narrator yodeling in the street. Part II will begin with him in a room again -- a different room, but the same situation. The half-sovereign will be gone. The euphoria will be a memory. And the cycle will start again, but with differences. The lies will become more elaborate. The encounters will become more charged. The body will fail more dramatically. And the narrator's relationship to food -- already strange in Part I, already marked by nausea and revulsion -- will become genuinely disturbing.

Watch, too, for the deepening of the Ylajali thread. The name the narrator invented on the street will return, attached now to a woman he actually meets, and the gap between the invented Ylajali and the real woman will become one of the novel's most painful subjects. The narrator cannot love a real person; he can only love the fiction he has placed over her, and the fiction keeps slipping.

And watch for the pencil. The narrator's relationship to his writing instruments -- pencils, paper, the physical tools of his trade -- will intensify into something like obsession. In Part I, the pencil left behind in the waistcoat was an inconvenience. By later parts, the act of gnawing on a pencil or a wood chip will become one of the novel's most disturbing images of a body that has begun to consume itself.

But that is for later. For now, the narrator yodels in the street, and the dawn comes, and somewhere a printing press is setting his words into type, and for one brief, magnificent, unsustainable moment, everything is exactly as he always said it would be.

Christiania: A City of Ghosts

In the autumn of 1888, a twenty-nine-year-old Norwegian named Knut Hamsun stood on the deck of the transatlantic steamer Thingvalla as it entered the Christiania fjord. The ship was bound for Copenhagen, but it stopped first in Christiania, the small northern capital where Hamsun had once wandered the streets half-starved, scribbling articles that no one would buy, sleeping in doorways and abandoned workshops. He could have disembarked. He chose not to. The city was too close to his skin. He stayed on board, watched the harbor slide past, and continued on to Copenhagen, where he rented a cheap attic room and began to write the novel that would make his name. The memories of Christiania, it turned out, were easier to bear on paper than on foot.

Two years later, in 1890, *Hunger* was published. It is a book set in a very specific city at a very specific moment, and Part II plunges us into that city more deeply than any other section. The narrator wanders from churchyard to harbor bench to guard-house to pawnshop, tracing a map of desperation across Christiania's streets. The city is named. Its

landmarks are real. Its weather is real. But something else is happening, too: the city is dissolving. Under the pressure of starvation and sleeplessness, Christiania becomes a hallucination of itself, a place where policemen clink across the cobblestones like ghosts and empty paper cornets shimmer with imaginary silver. To read Part II is to watch a real city become an unreal one, and to understand that the distance between the two was never very great.

The City on the Fjord

Christiania in 1890 was a city of perhaps 150,000 souls, small by European standards but growing fast, pressed between mountains and sea at the head of its long fjord. It had been called Christiania since 1624, when King Christian IV rebuilt it after a fire, and it would not become Oslo again until 1925. In the 1890s it was a city in the middle of becoming modern. Gas lamps were giving way to electric arc lights along Karl Johan Street, the city's central artery, where fashionable citizens promenaded in the evenings. The harbor at Pipervika, beneath the old fortress of Akershus, was being modernized to accommodate the steamships that now connected Norway to the world. The West Railway Station, opened in 1872, had pulled the city's center of gravity westward. New apartment buildings were going up in Frogner and

Majorstuen. The university was expanding. There were newspapers, theaters, bookshops, cafes. It was the kind of city that believed in progress.

But it was also a city of stark division. The east side, Gronland and Vaterland and the streets climbing toward Ekeberg, was working-class and often wretched. The west side, where Karl Johan led to the Royal Palace, was bourgeois and aspirational. And in between, in attic rooms and abandoned workshops, in churchyards and on harbor benches, lived the city's population of writers and artists and students who belonged to neither world. Hamsun's narrator is one of these people. He is educated, literate, possessed of what he believes is genuine talent. He is also starving, and the city he moves through is indifferent to this fact.

The geography of Part II is traceable. The narrator begins in a churchyard, writing by the last light of evening. He drifts to a bench near the railway bridge by the harbor, the Pipervika waterfront where the ships lay with their masts outlined against the sky. He is taken to the guard-house, perhaps the one near the Town Hall. In the morning he emerges into Young's Market, crosses toward Homandsbyen to find his friend, trudges to Tolbodgaden, then back up to Bernt Akers Street, then down to Pyle Street, then to a pawnshop at Stener's Street. The clock on Our Saviour's Church marks his hours. These are real places. You can still

find most of them in Oslo today, though the city has changed around them. But what matters is not the accuracy of the map. What matters is the way the narrator experiences these streets: as an obstacle course of hope and refusal, each destination promising rescue and delivering nothing.

The Bohemians' Shadow

Hamsun arrived in Christiania at the tail end of one of the most provocative cultural movements in Scandinavian history. In the 1880s, a small circle of writers and artists centered around the anarchist philosopher Hans Jaeger had declared war on bourgeois morality. They called themselves the Kristiania Bohemians. Their manifesto, published in the journal *Impressionisten* in 1889, consisted of nine commandments, the first and most famous of which was: "Thou shalt write thy life." They meant it literally. Jaeger's novel *Fra Kristiania-Bohemen* (From the Christiania Bohemia), published in 1885, was an autobiographical account of the group's experiments in free love, anarchism, and radical honesty. The Norwegian authorities confiscated it immediately, sentenced Jaeger to sixty days in prison, and stripped him of his position as a parliamentary stenographer. The painter Christian Krohg, another member of the circle,

had his novel *Albertine* confiscated the following year. The message from respectable Christiania was clear: write your life, and we will destroy it.

The young Edvard Munch joined this circle in 1884, and it changed everything for him. Jaeger encouraged Munch to abandon realism, to paint not what he saw but what he felt. The bohemians' emphasis on subjective experience, on the primacy of feeling over social convention, would shape the rest of Munch's career. It would also shape Hamsun's.

But here is the crucial distinction that Hunger draws: the bohemian poverty of Jaeger's circle was, at least in part, chosen. They were middle-class rebels slumming in garrets, performing their rejection of bourgeois life as a philosophical statement. The narrator of *Hunger* is not performing anything. His poverty is real, grinding, biological. He chews wood shavings. He sucks on pebbles. He tries to pawn five coat buttons and is laughed out of the shop. The bohemians wrote their lives as an act of defiance; Hamsun's narrator writes his articles because if he does not sell one soon, he will die. The line between artistic defiance and genuine destitution is exactly the fault line that *Hunger* runs along, and Part II is where that line becomes most visible. The narrator is a writer, yes, an intellectual who wears pince-nez and knows the name of the editor of the *Morgenbladet*. But he is also a man who has not eaten in three days, who runs

his forehead into lampposts on purpose, who digs his nails into his palms until they bleed. The bohemians' first commandment was "write thy life." Hamsun did. And what he found there was not liberation but terror.

The Paper Cornet

The most extraordinary scene in Part II, and one of the most extraordinary in all of nineteenth-century fiction, takes place on a harbor bench in the early darkness of a Christiania evening. The narrator, having escaped from the churchyard at closing time, has drifted down to the waterfront. He is carrying a manuscript, a penknife, a bunch of keys, and no money at all. He takes out his papers and, in a movement he describes as "mechanical" and "unconscious," makes a paper cornet from a blank page, folds it carefully to look full, and throws it onto the pavement.

I sat and coaxed myself quite audibly to guess the sum; if
I guessed aright, it was to be mine.

This is already strange. A starving man has made a fake package of money and is now bargaining with himself over its imaginary contents. But the scene has not yet found its true register. A policeman is patrolling nearby. The narrator hears him cough. And then, in a decision that arrives from

some deep recess of mischief, the narrator coughs too, three times, so the policeman will hear and come investigate the cornet.

I was drunk with starvation; my hunger had made me tipsy.

The policeman approaches. He sees the white paper packet on the ground, looking "so white and so full." He picks it up. He opens it with his big hands and looks inside. And the narrator, watching from the bench, laughs silently, maniacally, slapping his thighs:

I laughed, laughed, slapped my thighs, and laughed, like a maniac. And not a sound issued from my throat; my laughter was hushed and feverish to the intensity of tears.

What kind of laughter is this? It is not the laughter of superiority, though the narrator has tricked the policeman. It is not the laughter of joy, though the narrator seems briefly ecstatic. It is the laughter of a man who has discovered that he still has one possession left: the ability to create a fiction. He has nothing. He cannot feed himself. He cannot pay rent. He cannot even give a halfpenny to a street musician. But he can fold a piece of paper into a shape that deceives a

policeman, and in that deception there is a flicker of power, of authorship, of being the one who writes the script rather than the one who suffers it.

The paper cornet is, in miniature, the novel itself. Both are empty containers made to look full. Both are acts of creation born from desperation. And both produce in their audience a response that the creator controls. The policeman opens the cornet and finds nothing; the reader opens *Hunger* and finds everything. The comedy is black, almost unbearable. Denis Johnson, in *Jesus' Son*, would later write scenes of similar register, in which a narrator whose perceptions are warped by drugs and circumstance finds himself in situations that are simultaneously devastating and hilarious. Johnson's narrator, known only as "Fuckhead," witnesses car crashes and overdoses and murders through a haze of chemicals that makes everything both more vivid and less real. Hamsun's narrator has no chemicals, only hunger, but the effect is remarkably similar: a loosening of the grip on ordinary reality that produces comedy where there should be none, beauty where there should be only suffering.

The Harbor at Night

After the policeman walks away, something happens to the narrator that is harder to name than laughter. A drowsy quiet settles over him. He puts his feet up on the bench, leans back, and surrenders to the darkness. The harbor scene that follows is one of the most lyrical passages in the novel, and one of the strangest:

I felt pleasantly empty, untouched by everything around me, and glad not to be noticed by any one. I put my feet up on the seat and leant back. Thus I could best appreciate the well-being of perfect isolation. There was not a cloud on my mind, not a feeling of discomfort, and so far as my thought reached, I had not a whim, not a desire unsatisfied.

This is a man who has not eaten in days. His clothes are insufficient. He has no home to return to, or rather, he has a home, an abandoned tinker's workshop above a stable, but it is so desolate that he dreads it. And yet here, on a bench by the harbor, he experiences what he calls "perfect isolation," a state of contentment so total that it borders on the mystical. The passage is disconcerting precisely because it feels genuine. Hamsun is not being ironic. The narrator really does feel this way, because starvation has burned through all the ordinary anxieties that normally crowd the mind. Hunger, at a

certain point, becomes its own anesthetic. The body, pushed past a threshold of deprivation, releases its grip on worry, on ambition, on desire, and what remains is a strange, unearned peace.

And then, from this peace, the hallucination of Princess Ylajali rises like a tide:

The dark monsters out there will draw me to them when night comes, and they will bear me far across the sea, through strange lands where no man dwells, and they will bear me to Princess Ylajali's palace, where an undreamt-of grandeur awaits me, greater than that of any other man.

Ylajali is one of the novel's recurring phantoms, a name the narrator has invented for a woman he once saw on Karl Johan Street, or perhaps for no one at all. She lives in a palace of amethyst and emerald and ruby, and she has been waiting twenty summers for him, and she will lead him through corridors where crowds cry "Hurrah!" The vision is absurd, grandiose, heartbreaking, and completely serious. It is also, in its way, a piece of urban geography. The narrator is sitting on a bench in Christiania, looking at ships in the harbor, and he is dreaming of another city, a fairy-tale city where he is not hungry and not cold and not forgotten. The dream-city is superimposed on the real city like a transparency. The harbor becomes a launching point; the

ships become monsters that will carry him away; the darkness becomes a corridor leading to the throne room. Christiania has not disappeared. It has been transfigured.

The Scream Across the Water

Three years after *Hunger* was published, Edvard Munch painted *The Scream*. The connection between the two works is not one of direct influence, though both men had breathed the same air. It is, rather, a connection of geography and feeling. In a diary entry written in Nice in January 1892, Munch described the experience that would become the painting: "I was walking along the road with two friends, the sun went down, I felt a gust of melancholy. Suddenly the sky turned a bloody red. I stood there trembling with anxiety, and I felt a vast infinite scream tear through nature."

The road was in Ekebergasen, on the outskirts of Christiania, overlooking the fjord. The bloody sky was above the same harbor where Hamsun's narrator sat on his bench, watching the ships with their black hulls. The anxiety Munch describes, a trembling that comes from nowhere and everywhere, that seems to emanate from the landscape itself, is the same anxiety that saturates Part II of *Hunger*. Both men were channeling something that belonged to the city as much as to themselves. Christiania in the late

nineteenth century was a place where the old certainties, religious, social, economic, were crumbling under the pressure of modernization, and the new certainties had not yet arrived. The electric lights on Karl Johan were brighter than the gas lamps they replaced, but they illuminated the same poverty, the same class divisions, the same gulf between aspiration and reality.

What Munch painted, Hamsun had already written. The narrator of *Hunger* does not scream. His agony is quieter than that. But the landscape is the same: the fjord, the darkening sky, the sense of reality buckling under pressure that is at once personal and cosmic. When the narrator hallucinates Ylajali, the city itself seems to be dreaming. When Munch felt the scream pass through nature, nature itself seemed to be suffering. Both men had found something in Christiania that was larger than autobiography, a dread that belonged to the city, to the century, to the condition of being human in a place that was changing too fast to comprehend.

The Guard-House Comedy

The narrator is eventually awakened from his harbor dream by the policeman, recalled "mercilessly to life and misery." He stumbles through the rain, discovers he has lost his keys, and

ends up at the guard-house, where he must report himself as homeless. What follows is a scene of pure social performance, desperate and inspired in equal measure. He gives a false name, Andreas Tangen, and when asked his occupation, he takes a step forward and says, "firmly, almost solemnly: A journalist." When asked which paper, he names the *Morgenbladet*, one of Christiania's most respectable dailies. He is shown to the reserved section, the cell for gentlemen rather than vagrants, and he exults in his triumph:

I felt ice run down my back at my own boldness, and I clenched my hands to steady myself a bit.

In the morning, he is offered no breakfast ticket, because he has performed his role too well. The other homeless men receive their tickets, the officer on duty repeating to his constable, "Don't forget to give them tickets; they look as if they wanted a meal!" But the narrator, playing the journalist who merely stayed out too late at a cafe, cannot ask for one. His lie has purchased him dignity at the cost of food. He leaves the guard-house with his head held high and his stomach empty, "the carriage of a millionaire, and hands thrust under my coat-tails."

This is the particular cruelty of poverty among the educated. The narrator knows how to impersonate a man of means. He has the vocabulary, the bearing, the cultural

references. He knows the name of the editor Friele. He can deploy the word "Stiftsgaarden." And these skills, which in another context would be assets, become instruments of his own torture. He is too good at pretending to be someone who does not need help, and so he never receives it.

Orwell's Shadow

George Orwell's *Down and Out in Paris and London*, published in 1933, is the most obvious companion text to *Hunger*, and also the most instructive contrast. Orwell, too, writes about educated poverty, about the experience of going hungry in a great city while possessing the ability to describe that hunger in precise prose. Both books traffic in the rituals of destitution: the pawning of belongings, the careful management of shame, the unexpected kindnesses and casual cruelties of strangers, the way hunger distorts time and thought.

But the two books are fundamentally different projects. Orwell is a journalist. His account of poverty is an investigation, a report from the front. He wants to understand how the poor live, and he wants his readers to understand it too. His prose is clear, measured, empirical. When he describes hunger, he describes its physical effects with clinical precision: "Hunger reduces one to an utterly

spineless, brainless condition, more like the after-effects of influenza than anything else." This is a useful observation. It helps us understand something. It is the kind of sentence that might appear in a policy paper.

Hamsun is doing something entirely different. He does not want to explain hunger. He wants to be hunger, to make the reader inhabit a consciousness so distorted by deprivation that the ordinary categories of experience, comedy, tragedy, reason, madness, no longer apply. Where Orwell describes, Hamsun enacts. Consider the moment in Part II when the narrator, having run all the way up Pyle Street in a fit of self-punishment, flings himself down on a step and then forces himself to stand again, "in order to torture myself rightly." This is not a description of how hunger feels. It is a dramatization of the specific madness that hunger produces, the way it turns the self against itself, the way deprivation creates a perverse relationship between the sufferer and his suffering.

Orwell's narrator is always, in some fundamental sense, a tourist in poverty. He has a safety net, even if it is a thin one. He can go home. Hamsun's narrator has no home, or rather, his home is a loft above a tinker's workshop where the snow blows in through the walls. There is no exit, no experiment concluding, no manuscript to deliver to a sympathetic publisher. There is only the next hour, the next bench, the next

humiliation. Orwell wrote about poverty from the outside, with great skill and moral seriousness. Hamsun wrote it from the inside, with the wild, hallucinatory precision of a man remembering his own fever.

The City as Psyche

What makes Part II of *Hunger* so remarkable, finally, is not its depiction of poverty, or its comedy, or its lyricism, but the way it uses the city itself as an instrument of psychological revelation. Christiania in this section of the novel is not a backdrop. It is an extension of the narrator's mind. When he is calm, the harbor is "peaceful and lovely in the murkiness," the sea stretching away "in pearly blueness." When he is agitated, the streets become an obstacle course of strangers who will not help him, doors that will not open, friends who have gone home. When he hallucinates, the ships become monsters and the darkness becomes a corridor to a fairy-tale palace.

This is not pathetic fallacy in the ordinary sense, the convention by which storms reflect anger and sunshine reflects joy. It is something more radical. The city does not reflect the narrator's state of mind. The city is the narrator's state of mind. There is no stable, external Christiania that the narrator perceives correctly or incorrectly. There is only the

Christiania that exists for him in this moment, on this bench, at this stage of starvation. The gas lamps go out and the darkness that follows is not merely dark but "a desperate element to which no one had hitherto paid attention." The nail hole in the wall of his cell is not merely a hole but "a downright intricate and mysterious hole, which I must guard against." Every surface of the city becomes charged with the narrator's hunger, his fear, his strange, intermittent joy.

Consider the long, agonizing sequence in which the narrator traverses the city in search of money. He goes first to the newspaper office: the editor is out. He walks to Homandsbyen to find his friend Hans Pauli Pettersen: Pettersen has moved. He walks to Tolbodgaden to get the new address, then to Bernt Akers Street: Pettersen has gone home for the holidays. He walks to the pastor's house: the pastor is out, his wife has gout. He walks to Cisler the music-seller: Cisler says no. He walks to a yarn shop: the owner is on a mountain tour. He tries to pawn his coat buttons: the pawnbroker laughs. Each of these encounters is a little drama of hope and refusal, and each one takes place at a different point on the map of Christiania. The effect is cumulative and devastating. The city becomes a series of locked doors, a labyrinth of no.

I will tell you one thing, my good Lord God, you are a bungler!

He shouts this in the open street, shaking his fist at the clouds. It is a moment of wild, blasphemous comedy, but it is also a moment of genuine metaphysical protest. The narrator is not merely hungry. He is offended by the structure of reality. The city has been organized, he feels, to maximize his suffering. Every person he needs is absent. Every institution is closed. The very architecture of Christiania seems designed to send him from one empty room to another, each room a little farther from the last, each staircase a little steeper, until he is so exhausted that he cannot stand.

The Ghosts That Remain

Part II ends with rescue, of a sort. Outside the pawnshop, the narrator meets an acquaintance who recognizes him, sees the buttons in his hand, and understands at once. "No; this is really going too far," the man says, and pushes the narrator back inside, pawning his own watch to get five shillings for them both. It is the most human moment in the chapter, and also the most painful, because the narrator has been saved not by his own efforts, not by the city's institutions, not by God's design, but by the accident of someone walking past at the right time. The whole architecture of destitution, the locked doors and absent friends and indifferent strangers, is undone by a coincidence. Five shillings. A pawn ticket. Another few days of life.

Christiania was renamed Oslo in 1925. The harbor was rebuilt, the gas lamps were finally extinguished in 1929, the slums were cleared, the city expanded. Akershus Fortress became a museum. Karl Johan Street is still there, still the city's spine, but the promenading burghers have been replaced by tourists and shoppers. The churchyard where the narrator wrote in the fading light, the bench where he dreamed of Ylajali, the guard-house where he played Cabinet Minister, these places have been absorbed into a modern Scandinavian capital that is prosperous and orderly and, by most measures, among the best cities in the world in which to live.

But the ghosts remain. They remain because Hamsun wrote them down with such hallucinatory precision that they cannot be erased by renovation or prosperity. The starving man on the harbor bench, laughing silently at a policeman who has picked up an empty paper cornet; the sleepless prisoner in his dark cell, probing a nail hole with his penknife and inventing a word that means nothing; the proud, desperate writer running up Pyle Street in a frenzy of self-punishment and then standing, swaying, refusing himself permission to sit down: these figures are permanent residents of the city. They inhabit a Christiania that no longer exists on any map, a city of the mind that Hamsun built from memory

and hunger and something close to genius. It is a city you enter by reading, and once you have been there, you do not entirely leave.

Close Reading: Part II

Opening: The Churchyard at Dusk

Part II opens with a sentence that establishes, in the space of a few clauses, the essential rhythm of the narrator's existence: the cycle of effort, failure, and the slow tightening of deprivation around every waking hour.

A few weeks later I was out one evening. Once more I had sat out in a churchyard and worked at an article for one of the newspapers. But whilst I was struggling with it eight o'clock struck, and darkness closed in, and time for shutting the gates.

Notice how much information Hamsun compresses into this opening. "A few weeks later" tells us time has passed since the events of Part I, but vaguely, as if the narrator cannot account for it precisely. "Once more" tells us this is a pattern, a ritual: he has been here before, working in churchyards as evening falls. The churchyard is a workspace of last resort, a public space where a man with no desk and no lamp can sit for free until the gates close. It is also, of course, a place of

the dead, and that irony, the starving man laboring among gravestones, is left entirely implicit. Hamsun does not underline it. He trusts us to feel it.

The three parallel clauses at the end of the sentence, "eight o'clock struck, and darkness closed in, and time for shutting the gates," work like a ratchet, each one tightening the constraint. Time is running out. Light is running out. Space is running out. The narrator is being squeezed from the world by the simple mechanics of a closing day.

Then comes the inventory:

I was hungry--very hungry. The ten shillings had, worse luck, lasted all too short. It was now two, ay, nearly three days since I had eaten anything, and I felt somewhat faint; holding the pencil even had taxed me a little. I had half a penknife and a bunch of keys in my pocket, but not a farthing.

This is the first of several catalogues in Part II, moments when the narrator counts what he has and what he lacks, as if by tallying his possessions he can measure the distance between himself and survival. Half a penknife. A bunch of keys. No money. The inventory is absurdly meager, and the half-penknife, that broken tool, is a small masterpiece of characterization: this is a man who keeps even broken things,

because broken things are still things. The self-correction, "two, ay, nearly three days," shows us a mind that clings to precision even as it fogs with hunger. He cannot afford to be vague about his own deprivation. He must know exactly how long he has been starving, because that number is the only measure of his situation that he controls.

Then an extraordinary pivot. Instead of going home to his room, a "vacant tinker's workshop, where all was dark and barren," he drifts, without purpose, toward the sea:

I stumbled on, passed, not caring where I went, the Town Hall, right to the sea, and over to a seat near the railway bridge.

The syntax itself stumbles. The parenthetical phrase "not caring where I went" interrupts the movement of the sentence just as the narrator's aimlessness interrupts the purposeful trajectory of a man going home. He passes the Town Hall, that emblem of civic order, and continues down to the harbor, the margin of the city. He is drifting toward the edge. And what he finds there, on that bench by the railway bridge, is not despair but something altogether stranger.

The Harbor Bench: Contentment in Deprivation

At this moment not a sad thought troubled me. I forgot my distress, and felt calmed by the view of the sea, which lay peaceful and lovely in the murkiness. For old habit's sake I would please myself by reading through the bit I had just written, and which seemed to my suffering head the best thing I had ever done.

This passage establishes a paradox that will recur throughout Part II, and indeed throughout the novel: the way hunger, at certain thresholds, produces not misery but a strange euphoria. The narrator forgets his distress. He feels calm. He even experiences a moment of artistic vanity, believing his half-written article to be the best thing he has ever done. That self-assessment, offered casually and without irony, reveals something about the relationship between deprivation and self-regard. When you have nothing, the one thing you have made becomes everything. The manuscript, scrawled in fading light among the gravestones, is both worthless (no editor has accepted it) and priceless (it is all the narrator possesses that is not a broken penknife or a set of keys).

The description of the harbor is precise and luminous:

Everything was still. The sea stretched away in pearly blueness, and little birds flitted noiselessly by me from place to place.

"Pearly blueness" is a painter's phrase, not a hungry man's. And yet it is exactly the kind of detail a hungry man might notice, because starvation, as Hamsun understood with forensic intimacy, does not merely blunt perception. It alters it. Colors become more vivid. Sounds become more distinct. The world takes on a hallucinatory clarity that is the body's last protest against its own diminishment. The birds flit "noiselessly," and that silence is part of the scene's uncanny beauty. The harbor at dusk is a world stripped of noise, of obligation, of other people. It is, for a few minutes, exactly the refuge the narrator needs.

Then the shift to present tense:

A policeman patrols in the distance; otherwise there is not a soul visible, and the whole harbour is hushed in quiet.

This is one of the most telling grammatical moments in Part II. The narrative has been in past tense: "I was out," "I had sat," "I stumbled." Now, without warning, it shifts to present: "A policeman patrols." The effect is immediate and physical. We are no longer being told about an evening; we are in it. The narrator is no longer remembering; he is experiencing.

This shift marks the beginning of what will become one of the novel's most remarkable sequences, a long descent into a present tense that will carry us through the paper cornet, the Ylajali hallucination, and the night in the guard-house cell. Hamsun shifts tense the way a film shifts from a wide establishing shot to a close-up: suddenly we are there, on the bench, in the dark, watching the policeman's iron heels clink across the pavement.

The Paper Cornet

I count my belongings once more--half a penknife, a bunch of keys, but not a farthing. Suddenly I dive into my pocket and take the papers out again. It was a mechanical movement, an unconscious nervous twitch. I selected a white unwritten page, and--God knows where I got the notion from--but I made a cornet, closed it carefully, so that it looked as if it were filled with something, and threw it far out on to the pavement.

The paper cornet scene is the comic and philosophical center of Part II. It begins with the second inventory of possessions, half a penknife, keys, no money, the same list as before, as if repetition might change the sum. Then comes the "mechanical movement," the "unconscious nervous twitch" that produces the cornet. The narrator insists he does not

know where the idea comes from. It arrives as an impulse, unbidden, from somewhere below or beyond conscious intention. And yet the care he takes, closing the cornet "carefully, so that it looked as if it were filled with something," reveals an artist's instinct at work. He is making something. He is shaping empty paper into a form that suggests fullness. He is, in the most literal sense imaginable, creating a fiction.

What follows is the narrator's game with himself:

By this time hunger had begun to assail me in earnest. I sat and looked at the white paper cornet, which seemed as if it might be bursting with shining silver pieces, and incited myself to believe that it really did contain something. I sat and coaxed myself quite audibly to guess the sum; if I guessed aright, it was to be mine.

"Incited myself to believe" is an astonishing phrase. The narrator knows the cornet is empty. He made it himself, from a blank page, moments ago. And yet he is coaxing himself, audibly, into belief, turning the act of self-deception into a game with rules: if he guesses the sum correctly, he wins. But wins what? There is no sum. There is nothing to win. The game is purely imaginary, a closed system of desire and fantasy that produces nothing but the pleasure of the game itself. It is also, unmistakably, an allegory of writing. The novelist fills empty pages with imaginary riches and then

"incites" the reader to believe they are real. The cornet is a story in miniature, a container that is empty and full at the same time.

Then the policeman enters the scene:

Then I hear the constable cough. What puts it into my head to do the same? I rise up from the seat and repeat the cough three times so that he may hear it. Won't he jump at the corner when he comes. I sat and laughed at this trick, rubbed my hands with glee, and swore with rollicking recklessness.

The narrator coughs to attract the policeman's attention. It is pure mischief, a prank born from desperation. The trickster energy here is extraordinary. This is a man who has not eaten in three days, who has nothing, who is sitting on a bench in the dark. And his response to this situation is not despair but invention, the creation of a little theater piece in which the policeman will play the dupe. The narrator rubs his hands "with glee" and swears "with rollicking recklessness." The language is exuberant, almost childlike. It is the language of someone who has found, in the depths of destitution, a source of power: the power to deceive, to control another person's experience, to write the scene.

I was drunk with starvation; my hunger had made me tipsy.

This sentence is the key to the entire scene, and perhaps to the entire novel. "Drunk with starvation" yokes together two states that should be opposites: intoxication and deprivation. To be drunk is to have taken in too much; to be starving is to have taken in nothing. But Hamsun's insight, and it is a physiological as well as a psychological one, is that extreme deprivation produces effects that mimic intoxication. The brain, starved of glucose, begins to misfire. Inhibitions dissolve. The ordinary censors of behavior go quiet. What emerges is not madness, exactly, but a wild, unsupervised freedom that can produce both laughter and terror, often in the same breath.

The policeman picks up the cornet:

He takes his time; he has the whole night before him; he does not notice the paper bag--not till he comes quite close to it. Then he stops and stares at it. It looks so white and so full as it lies there; perhaps a little sum--what? A little sum of silver money?... and he picks it up. Hum ... it is light--very light; maybe an expensive feather; some hat trimming.... He opened it carefully with his big hands, and looked in.

The narration here is a masterpiece of point of view. The narrator is on the bench, watching from a distance, and yet he narrates the policeman's inner experience as if reading his thoughts. "It looks so white and so full"; "perhaps a little sum"; "maybe an expensive feather; some hat trimming." These are the policeman's speculations, but they are rendered in the narrator's voice, with the narrator's vocabulary. The starving man is not only tricking the policeman; he is writing him, composing the policeman's thoughts as he watches. The scene is fiction-making at its most elemental: one person imagining another person's consciousness.

And then the laughter:

I laughed, laughed, slapped my thighs, and laughed, like a maniac. And not a sound issued from my throat; my laughter was hushed and feverish to the intensity of tears.

Silent laughter. Soundless, convulsive, "to the intensity of tears." This is one of the most physically precise descriptions in the novel. The laughter is so extreme that it crosses over into its opposite: it becomes weeping, or at least something indistinguishable from weeping. The narrator's body has lost the ability to differentiate between joy and grief. Both manifest as the same shaking, the same breathlessness, the same salt water on the cheeks. The phrase "feverish to the

intensity of tears" is itself a small oxymoron, fever being hot and tears being wet, and that contradiction captures the scene perfectly. Nothing here is one thing only. The prank is both cruel and innocent. The laughter is both ecstatic and agonized. The cornet is both empty and full.

He coughed as he threw it away--he coughed as he threw it away.

The narrator rehearses this line, refining it, adding "point," making it "catching and piquant." He is revising, editing, doing to this little verbal fragment what a writer does to a sentence. Even his laughter has a literary quality. He is not merely experiencing the joke; he is crafting its retelling, shaping the memory into an anecdote before the experience is even over. This compulsive narrativizing, this inability to simply feel something without simultaneously composing it, is one of the defining traits of the narrator's consciousness. He is always both inside and outside his own experience, both the sufferer and the writer of the suffering.

Princess Ylajali: The Hallucination on the Bench

After the cornet scene, the narrator's mood shifts from manic comedy to a dreamy, languid contentment:

Then a drowsy quiet overcame me; a pleasant languor which I did not attempt to resist. The darkness had intensified, and a slight breeze furrowed the pearl-blue sea. The ships, the masts of which I could see outlined against the sky, looked with their black hulls like voiceless monsters that bristled and lay in wait for me.

"Voiceless monsters that bristled and lay in wait for me." The ships have become animate, predatory. This is the first moment in the sequence where the narrator's perception begins to detach from reality. The ships are not actually monsters. But the way he perceives them, with their black hulls bristling against the sky, is so vividly rendered that the metaphor almost becomes literal. The word "voiceless" is particularly unsettling. These are silent predators, like the hunger itself, which gnaws without making a sound.

Then comes the passage that the thematic essay for Part II discusses in the context of Christiania's geography (see ["Christiania: A City of Ghosts"](#)), but which deserves attention here for its prose rhythm and its strange psychology:

I had no pain--my hunger had taken the edge off it. In its stead I felt pleasantly empty, untouched by everything around me, and glad not to be noticed by any one. I put my feet up on the seat and leant back. Thus I could best appreciate the well-being of perfect isolation. There was

not a cloud on my mind, not a feeling of discomfort, and so far as my thought reached, I had not a whim, not a desire unsatisfied.

"Pleasantly empty." The phrase is almost Buddhist in its implications, suggesting a state beyond desire, beyond attachment, a kind of involuntary enlightenment achieved not through meditation but through deprivation. The narrator has been emptied so thoroughly, of food, of money, of social connection, of hope, that he has arrived at a paradoxical fullness. He has "not a whim, not a desire unsatisfied." But the reason he has no unsatisfied desire is that he has no desires at all. Hunger has burned them away. What remains is the "well-being of perfect isolation," a bliss that is indistinguishable from numbness.

From this emptiness, the Ylajali fantasy rises:

Only the lonely, crooning voice of silence strikes in monotonous on my ear, and the dark monsters out there will draw me to them when night comes, and they will bear me far across the sea, through strange lands where no man dwells, and they will bear me to Princess Ylajali's palace, where an undreamt-of grandeur awaits me, greater than that of any other man.

The transition from reality to hallucination is seamless. There is no break, no signal that the narrator has crossed from the waking world into fantasy. The ships-as-monsters are a metaphor in one sentence and a vehicle of transportation in the next. The "crooning voice of silence" is an oxymoron that enacts its own meaning: silence has become audible, the absence of sound has become a presence. The narrator does not choose to hallucinate. He is "drawn" into it by the monsters, carried away from the harbor bench into a palace of amethyst and yellow roses.

And she herself will be sitting in a dazzling hall where all is amethyst, on a throne of yellow roses, and will stretch out her hands to me when I alight; will smile and call as I approach and kneel: "Welcome, welcome, knight, to me and my land! I have waited twenty summers for you, and called for you on all bright nights. And when you sorrowed I have wept here, and when you slept I have breathed sweet dreams in you!"

The Ylajali passage is written in the cadences of a fairy tale. "Welcome, welcome, knight." "Twenty summers." "All bright nights." These are formulas, the stock phrases of the folk tradition, and their appearance here, in the consciousness of a realistic, modern, starving intellectual, is deeply strange. The narrator is not a child. He is not naive. He is a writer who reads newspapers and knows the name of the editor of the

Morgenbladet. And yet his hunger has opened a door to a register of experience that is premodern, mythic, saturated with longing. The fairy-tale language is both ridiculous and heartbreaking. It is ridiculous because a grown man on a harbor bench is fantasizing about a princess in an amethyst palace. It is heartbreaking because the fantasy reveals, with painful clarity, what the narrator most craves: not food, not money, but recognition. "I have waited twenty summers for you." Someone has been expecting him. Someone knows he is coming. Someone thinks he matters.

The fantasy accelerates through corridors and gardens, through "three hundred tender maidens" and "choirs of musicians," until it reaches a climax of pure sensory overwhelm:

I clasp her hand in mine; I feel the wild witchery of enchantment shiver through my blood, and I fold my arms around her, and she whispers, "Not here; come yet farther!" and we enter a crimson room, where all is of ruby, a foaming glory, in which I faint.

The color sequence is worth noting: amethyst, emerald, ruby. Purple, green, red. Each room is a single saturated hue, and each hue is more intense than the last. The cumulative effect is overwhelming, a crescendo of color that mirrors the crescendo of desire. "A foaming glory, in which I faint." The

word "foaming" is bizarre and perfect, suggesting both champagne and the sea and something almost biological, the foaming of the blood in a moment of extreme arousal. The narrator faints. His body gives out, not from hunger this time, but from an excess of imagined pleasure.

Then I feel her arms encircle me; her breath fans my face with a whispered "Welcome, loved one! Kiss me ... more ... more...."

I see from my seat stars shooting before my eyes, and my thoughts are swept away in a hurricane of light....

"From my seat." That small phrase brings us crashing back to reality. The narrator is still on the bench. The stars he sees are not celestial but physiological, the fireworks that a starving brain produces as it teeters at the edge of consciousness. The "hurricane of light" is the last thing he sees before he falls asleep. And what he wakes to is devastating:

I had fallen asleep where I lay, and was awakened by the policeman. There I sat, recalled mercilessly to life and misery. My first feeling was of stupid amazement at finding myself in the open air; but this was quickly replaced by a bitter despondency, I was near crying with sorrow at being still alive.

"Near crying with sorrow at being still alive." The sentence is plain, unadorned, and brutal. The hallucination has given way to rain-soaked clothes, to darkness, to the policeman's matter-of-fact command. The narrator has been "recalled mercilessly to life," and the word "mercilessly" tells us everything about how he experiences that recall. Life is not a gift. It is a punishment. Sleep was the mercy; waking is the cruelty.

The Walk Home: Anger, Tenderness, Lost Keys

The policeman tells the narrator to move along, and what follows is one of the novel's most psychologically acute sequences: a long, stumbling walk through the nighttime streets in which the narrator's emotions shift with dizzying speed, from despondency to rage to tenderness to self-loathing, each mood lasting only a few sentences before giving way to the next.

First comes the fantasy of bread:

If one only had a little bread to eat; one of those delicious little brown loaves that one could bite into as one walked along the street.

The specificity is devastating. Not just bread: a particular kind of bread. Small, brown, bite-able. A bread you could eat while walking, not even needing to sit down. The fantasy is modest, almost humble, and its humility makes it more painful than the Ylajali vision. The narrator is not dreaming of palaces now. He is dreaming of a loaf.

Then the belated rage at the policeman:

Suddenly I stopped in the street, stamped on the pavement, and cursed loudly. What was it he called me? A "Juggins"? I would just show him what calling me a "Juggins" means.

The narrator turns and runs back toward the harbor, furious about an insult that most people would shrug off. But the narrator is not most people. He is a man with almost no identity left, no address, no profession, no possessions, and so every scrap of dignity, every word spoken to him or about him, takes on enormous significance. Being called a "Juggins" is an affront not because it is particularly wounding but because the narrator has nothing else to be affronted by. His pride has no larger objects, and so it fastens on this one, magnifies it, inflates it into a crisis.

But the anger exhausts itself before he reaches the harbor. He pulls up, panting, and reasons with himself:

Was it not, after all, a matter of perfect indifference to me what such a policeman said? Yes; but one couldn't stand everything. Right enough, I interrupted myself; but he knew no better. And I found this argument satisfactory. I repeated twice to myself, "He knew no better"; and with that I returned again.

The internal debate is rendered as dialogue, complete with interruptions and rebuttals. The narrator is arguing with himself as though he were two people, and the resolution, "He knew no better," is delivered with the finality of a courtroom verdict. Twice repeated, for emphasis. This habit of splitting into accuser and defender, prosecutor and advocate, is one of the narrator's most characteristic mental operations. He is never simply angry or simply calm. He is always both, and the two states argue with each other in real time.

Then comes the encounter with the second policeman, one of the most tonally complex passages in Part II:

I quickened my pace, went close up to him, and said, without the slightest provocation, "It is ten o'clock."

"No, it's two," he answered, amazed.

"No, it's ten," I persisted; "it is ten o'clock!" and, groaning with anger, I stepped yet a pace or two nearer, clenched my fist, and said, "Listen, do you know what, it's ten o'clock!"

This is magnificent. The narrator accosts a stranger to insist, with furious conviction, that the time is wrong. It is two in the morning. The narrator says it is ten. He is not mistaken; he is not confused about the time. He is picking a fight with reality itself, asserting his own version of events against the evidence. The policeman's response is unexpectedly gentle:

"In any case, it's about time ye were getting home. Would ye like me to go with ye a bit?"

And the narrator is undone:

I was completely disarmed by this man's unexpected friendliness. I felt that tears sprang to my eyes, and I hastened to reply: "No, thank you! I have only been out a little too late in a cafe. Thank you very much all the same!"

The lie, "out a little too late in a cafe," is the same story the narrator will tell at the guard-house. It is his cover narrative, the fiction he wraps around his destitution to make it presentable. But what shatters him is not having to lie; it is the kindness. The policeman offers to walk him home. It is a small gesture, a routine bit of courtesy, and the narrator

responds as though he has been handed a gift of immense value. He cries. He wishes he had a coin to give the man. He watches the policeman walk away and cries harder.

I cried with despair because I had not even a little coin to give him.

This is the emotional logic of extreme poverty: kindness is more unbearable than cruelty, because kindness reminds you of what you cannot reciprocate. The narrator can endure being called a Juggins. He cannot endure being treated well.

He arrives home to find he has lost his keys:

"Oh, of course," I muttered to myself, "why shouldn't I lose my keys? Here I am, living in a yard where there is a stable underneath and a tinker's workshop up above. The door is locked at night, and no one, no one can open it; therefore, why should I not lose my keys?"

The sarcastic catechism that follows is one of the darkest comic passages in the novel. Each rhetorical question adds another layer of misery: he is wet, he is hungry, he is tired, therefore of course he should lose his keys. The logic is flawless in its perversity. The narrator has constructed a theology of bad luck, a system in which every misfortune

follows naturally from every other misfortune, in which the universe is not merely indifferent but actively, methodically hostile.

The Guard-House: Performance and Its Cost

The single scene break in Part II (the only `<hr>` in the chapter) falls here, separating the harbor sequence from the guard-house. It is a fitting division. Everything before the break has been solitary, nocturnal, interior. Everything after it will involve performance, social encounter, the narrator navigating other people's expectations. The break marks a shift from the private theater of the bench to the public theater of the city.

"Your name?" inquired the guard.

"Tangen--Andreas Tangen!"

I don't know why I lied; my thoughts fluttered about disconnectedly and inspired me with many singular whims, more than I knew what to do with. I hit upon this out-of-the-way name on the spur of the moment, and blurted it out without any calculation. I lied without any occasion for doing so.

The false name is a pivot point in the chapter. Andreas Tangen is nobody, a fiction improvised on the spot, and yet from this fiction the narrator will build an entire identity. The lie has "no occasion," no practical purpose. It is not a calculated deception but an impulsive one, a "nervous twitch" of identity that parallels the nervous twitch that produced the paper cornet. The narrator creates fictions compulsively, not because they serve him but because creation is what he does. He is a writer. He cannot help it.

"Occupation?"

This was driving me into a corner with a vengeance. Occupation! what was my occupation? I thought first of turning myself into a tinker--but I dared not; firstly, I had given myself a name that was not common to every and any tinker--besides, I wore pince-nez.

The pince-nez is a brilliant detail. The narrator cannot claim to be a manual laborer because his eyeglasses betray him. His poverty is of a particular kind: educated poverty, genteel poverty, the poverty of a man who owns spectacles but not food. The pince-nez function as a class marker that he cannot remove (or rather, will not remove: they are the last emblem of the self he is trying to maintain). They dictate the terms of his lie. He must be something that wears pince-nez.

It suddenly entered my head to be foolhardy. I took a step forward and said firmly, almost solemnly: "A journalist."

The physical gesture matters: "a step forward." The narrator advances into his own lie. He commits to it with his body as well as his voice. And the word "solemnly" is perfect, because what he is doing is, in fact, a kind of consecration. He is anointing himself. He is giving himself a profession, a social position, a name that the guard will recognize and respect. The solemnity is both performance and sincerity. In this moment, the narrator is a journalist. He is Andreas Tangen of the *Morgenbladet*. The fiction is as real as anything else about him.

"Show this gentleman up to the reserved section. Good-night!"

The lie works. The narrator is shown to the good cell, the one for gentlemen rather than vagrants. He exults, and he trembles:

I felt ice run down my back at my own boldness, and I clenched my hands to steady myself a bit.

"Ice run down my back" is the physical sensation of a gamble that has paid off. The narrator is thrilled and terrified in equal measure. The thrill comes from the success of the deception; the terror comes from the knowledge that it could unravel at

any moment. He has claimed to work for the *Morgenbladet*, and "Friele could show his teeth when he liked." The real world, with its verifiable facts and its consequential people, lurks just beyond the walls of this pleasant fiction.

The Cell at Night: Darkness, the Nail Hole, and "Kuboa"

What follows in the guard-house cell is one of the most extraordinary passages Hamsun ever wrote, a sustained exploration of consciousness under extreme duress that anticipates the techniques of literary modernism by decades.

All at once out goes the gas with a strange suddenness, without diminishing or flickering.

That "strange suddenness" is the narrator's experience, not an objective description. Gas lamps do diminish and flicker before they go out. But the narrator experiences the darkness as instantaneous, a curtain falling. The cell becomes absolute darkness, "this dense mass of gloom that had no bottom," and the narrator's thoughts begin to spiral.

The darkness had taken possession of my thoughts and left me not a moment in peace. Supposing I were myself to be absorbed in darkness; made one with it?

The fear here is not of the dark but of dissolution, of losing the boundary between self and environment. "Supposing I were myself to be absorbed in darkness; made one with it?" The narrator is afraid of ceasing to exist as a separate entity, of merging with the nothingness that surrounds him. It is a metaphysical terror, not a physical one, and it drives him to a frantic search for something solid to hold onto.

He finds the nail hole:

A little hole in the wall at the head of my bed occupies me greatly--a nail hole. I find the marks in the wall--I feel it, blow into it, and try to guess its depth. That was no innocent hole--not at all. It was a downright intricate and mysterious hole, which I must guard against!

The nail hole becomes an obsession. The narrator feels it, blows into it, gauges it with his penknife. He must know its depth. He must determine whether it goes through to the next wall. The hole, tiny and meaningless, has become "intricate and mysterious," a portal, a threat, an object of intense paranoid fascination. This is the hunger working. The mind, deprived of sensory input (the cell is pitch dark) and of nourishment (three days without food), fastens on the smallest available stimulus and inflates it to cosmic proportions. The nail hole is the paper cornet's dark twin:

another empty space that the narrator fills with imagination, but this time the imagination produces not comedy but dread.

Then comes the invented word:

"It is not in the language; I have discovered it. 'Kuboa.' It has letters as a word has. By the benign God, man, you have discovered a word!... 'Kuboa' ... a word of profound import."

The narrator has created something out of nothing. Again. First the paper cornet, then the name Andreas Tangen, now a word that does not exist. "Kuboa." He is ecstatic about this discovery, as ecstatic as he was about tricking the policeman. The joy of creation, any creation, however absurd, is the one reliable pleasure available to him. But the invented word quickly becomes a source of torment. What does it mean? The narrator insists it cannot mean "God or the Tivoli" or "cattle show" or "padlock" or "sunrise." He eliminates possibility after possibility, growing more agitated with each elimination:

"No! it is just this, it is impossible to let it signify emigration or tobacco factory. If it could have meant anything like that I would have decided upon it long since and taken the consequences."

The comedy of this passage is excruciating. The narrator is engaged in a furious philosophical debate about the meaning of a word that has no meaning, because it has no existence outside his own mind. He has created something and now cannot control it. The word "Kuboa" has become autonomous, demanding a definition that the narrator cannot supply. This is the writer's predicament writ in miniature: the words you create take on a life of their own, and they will not obey you.

The sequence escalates into genuine terror:

All at once the thought darted through my brain that I was insane. Seized with terror, I spring out of bed again, I stagger to the door, which I try to open, fling myself against it a couple of times to burst it, strike my head against the wall, bewail loudly, bite my fingers, cry and curse....

The verb list, "spring," "stagger," "try," "fling," "strike," "bewail," "bite," "cry," "curse," tumbles forward without pause, each action more desperate than the last, the syntax itself convulsing. The narrator has lost control of his body as well as his mind. He is not performing now. This is not the deliberate self-punishment of the Pyle Street run (which

comes later). This is genuine panic, the moment when the narrator confronts the possibility that he has crossed a line from eccentricity into madness.

And then, dawn:

Lying there I catch a glimpse, high up, straight before my eyes, of a greyish square in the wall, a suggestion of white, a presage--it must be of daylight. I felt it must be daylight, felt it through every pore in my body.

The grey square in the wall is a window, and the narrator responds to it as a prisoner responds to reprieve. He flings himself flat on the floor, cries "for very joy," blows a kiss to the window. The relief is total, physical, almost religious. The darkness that threatened to absorb him is retreating. The world exists. He exists. He has survived the night.

What a night this had been!

That single exclamation, standing alone as its own paragraph, is the narrator's summary of the entire experience: the darkness, the nail hole, the invented word, the panic, the dawn. It is both understated and comprehensive. What a night indeed.

Morning: The Breakfast Ticket Not Given

In the morning the narrator descends to the large room where the homeless are processed. Here the consequences of his lie become concrete and devastating:

The officer on duty repeated constantly to the policeman at his side, "Did he get a ticket? Don't forget to give them tickets; they look as if they wanted a meal!"

And I stood and looked at these tickets, and wished I had one.

The heartbreak of this passage is in its simplicity. Breakfast tickets are being distributed. The narrator, who has not eaten in three days, watches them being handed out and wishes for one. But he cannot ask. He is Andreas Tangen, journalist, a man who was merely out too late at a cafe. A journalist does not need a breakfast ticket. A journalist has money, a home, food waiting for him. The fiction that saved him last night, that won him the reserved cell, now prevents him from receiving the one thing he needs most: a meal.

"Like a Cabinet Minister--like a Cabinet Minister!"

He even doubles down on the performance, answering the officer's question about his sleep with this jaunty phrase. The narrator cannot stop performing. Even as his stomach

contracts with hunger, he is polishing his role, adding flourishes, enjoying the absurdity of a homeless man playing a cabinet minister. The performance has become a trap. He is too good at it to escape it.

A ticket! a ticket for me too! I have not eaten for more than three long days and nights. A loaf! But no one offered me a ticket, and I dared not demand one.

The internal cry, "A ticket! a ticket for me too!" is wrenching. It exists only inside the narrator's head. On the outside, he is all composure:

With elevated head, the carriage of a millionaire, and hands thrust under my coat-tails, I stride out of the guard-house.

The gap between interior and exterior here is the widest it has been in Part II. Inside: "A ticket! A loaf!" Outside: the carriage of a millionaire. The narrator's body performs one reality while his mind screams another. This split is the essential condition of educated poverty, and Hamsun renders it with a precision that is almost unbearable.

The Fruitless Circuit: Hans Pauli, the Editor, the Pastor, Cisler

The long middle section of Part II, after the narrator leaves the guard-house, is structured as a series of failed errands, a circuit of the city that brings the narrator to one closed door after another. The pattern is relentless:

He goes to the newspaper office. The editor has not come yet. "Scissors," the sub-editor, will not even look at him.

He walks to Homandsbyen to find Hans Pauli Pettersen. Pettersen has moved.

He walks to Tolbodgaden to get the new address. He is told Bernt Akers Street.

He trudges to Bernt Akers Street. Pettersen has "gone home" for the holidays.

He sits on the bare floor outside Pettersen's door, stunned. Twenty minutes pass. He does not move.

He goes back to the editor's office. It is shut. It is past four.

He tries the pastor. The pastor is out. The pastor's wife has gout.

He goes to Cisler the music-seller. Cisler says no.

He tries a yarn shop. The owner is on a mountain tour.

Each of these encounters is a small drama of approach and refusal, hope and foreclosure. And each one is worse than the last, because each one takes more energy to reach, energy the narrator does not have. By the time he sits outside Pettersen's locked door, he has been walking for hours on an empty stomach, and the prose registers his exhaustion with devastating precision:

I sat down without more ado--sat down on the bare floor, dulled with fatigue, fairly beaten with exhaustion. I mechanically mutter, a couple of times, "Gone home--gone home!" then I keep perfectly quiet. There was not a tear in my eyes; I had not a thought, not a feeling of any kind. I sat and stared, with wide-open eyes, at the letters, without coming to any conclusion. Ten minutes went over--perhaps twenty or more. I sat stolidly on the one spot, and did not move a finger.

This is the opposite of the Ylajali hallucination, the opposite of the paper cornet mischief. It is the void. The narrator has arrived at a point beyond feeling, beyond thought, beyond even despair. He sits and stares at the letters in his hand and cannot process them. The prose mirrors his blankness: short

sentences, simple words, no metaphor, no elaboration. For twenty minutes, the narrator is nothing. He has been emptied not into bliss (as on the harbor bench) but into nullity.

Then the rage, when he reaches the street:

"I will tell you one thing, my good Lord God, you are a bungler!" and I nod furiously, with set teeth, up to the clouds; "I will be hanged if you are not a bungler."

This is the narrator's only direct address to God in Part II, and it is spectacular in its impudence. He does not plead. He does not pray. He accuses. God is a "bungler," an incompetent, a craftsman who has botched the job. The word "bungler" is perfect: it is the insult of a professional, one maker criticizing another's workmanship. The narrator, who has just failed to sell a newspaper article, is telling the creator of the universe that He lacks skill.

The passage that follows immediately is one of the strangest in the chapter, a self-directed acting exercise in hypocrisy:

"Hast thou appealed also to him, my child?" It did not sound right!

With a large H, I say, with an H as big as a cathedral! once again, "Hast thou invoked Him, my child?" and I incline my head, and I make my voice whine, and answer, No!

The narrator is rehearsing a scene he intends to play at the pastor's house, drilling himself in the performance of piety. He coaches himself on tone, on capitalization (the H must be "as big as a cathedral"), on the proper degree of whining. The passage is savagely funny, but it is also a window into the narrator's fractured relationship with sincerity. He cannot ask for help without performing. He cannot perform without directing himself. He is simultaneously the actor, the director, and the critic, and none of the three is satisfied with the others' work.

The Editor's Office: Kindness That Cannot Be Asked

The visit to the newspaper editor is one of the quietest and most painful scenes in Part II. The narrator arrives with his manuscript. The editor receives him kindly:

"Good-day! Is it you?" he asked kindly; "sit down."

"Everything you write is certain to cost you effort, but you are far too impetuous; if you could only be a little more sober. There's too much fever. In the meantime, I will read it."

The editor's criticism, "too much fever," is devastatingly apt. The narrator's writing, like his behavior, like his inner life, is indeed feverish: too intense, too extreme, too uncontrolled. And the fever comes from hunger. The editor does not know this. He sees a stylistic flaw. The narrator knows it is a symptom. This is the cruelest irony in the scene: the fever the editor wants the narrator to suppress is the direct product of the starvation that only a shilling from the editor could alleviate.

There I sat. Dared I ask for a shilling? explain to him why there was always fever? He would be sure to aid me; it was not the first time.

The narrator cannot ask. He approaches the request, circles it, considers it from every angle, and then retreats. The editor has been kind before, has sent a messenger to scrape together money for him. But the narrator's pride, that maddening, self-destructive, magnificent pride, will not allow him to ask again.

"Was there otherwise anything?" he inquired.

"No," I answered, and I compelled my voice to sound steady.

"I compelled my voice to sound steady." The effort is physical. The narrator is forcing his body to collaborate in the lie that he is fine, that he needs nothing, that he is an artist who has come to discuss his work and not a starving man who needs a shilling to buy bread. The compulsion, the effort of will required to say "no" when every cell in his body is screaming "yes," is the most precise description of dignified poverty I know.

The Run Up Pyle Street: Self-Punishment as Ritual

After leaving the editor's office, the narrator turns his anger inward:

"You ought to be ashamed of yourself," I said aloud.
"Could it really have entered your head to ask the man for a shilling and put him to inconvenience again?"

The narrator berates himself not for failing to ask but for almost asking. The near-request is treated as a moral failing, a lapse in honor. And the punishment he devises is extraordinary:

"So--o, march! quicker! quicker! you big thumping lout; I'll teach you." I commenced to run to punish myself, left one street after the other behind me at a bound, goaded myself on with suppressed cries, and shrieked dumbly and furiously at myself whenever I was about to halt.

He runs up Pyle Street in a frenzy of self-punishment, screaming at himself silently, refusing to stop even when his body gives out. Then, having arrived at the point of collapse, he stands and refuses to sit down:

"No; stop!" I said, and, in order to torture myself rightly, I arose again, and forced myself to keep standing. I jeered at myself and hugged myself with pleasure at the spectacle of my own exhaustion.

"Hugged myself with pleasure at the spectacle of my own exhaustion." This is masochism, but it is also something more specific. The narrator is taking pleasure not in pain but in control. He is the one who decides when he runs and when he stops, when he stands and when he sits. In a life where he controls nothing, food, shelter, the editor's response, the availability of friends, the hours of the pastor's office, this one small domain of self-inflicted suffering is entirely his. He is both torturer and victim, and the pleasure he takes is the pleasure of authorship: he is writing this scene, and the protagonist does what he says.

At length, after the lapse of a few moments, I gave myself, with a nod, permission to be seated, though, even then, I chose the most uncomfortable place on the steps.

Even the permission to sit comes with a condition: the most uncomfortable spot available. The narrator negotiates with himself the way a stern parent negotiates with a child. You may sit, but not comfortably. You have not earned comfort. The internal drama of authority and submission is played out entirely within one person, and it is both absurd and utterly serious.

The Organ-Girl and the Missing Waistcoat

The narrator drifts to the harbor area again, where a street organ is playing Weber and a little girl is singing:

The flute-like sorrowfulness of the organ thrills through my blood; my nerves vibrate in responsive echo.

The music overwhelms him. His weakened state makes him permeable to every stimulus, and the organ's melody enters him like a physical substance. He is "dissolved in tones," "lifted," "floating." It is a minor version of the Ylajali hallucination: sensory input overpowering a mind too depleted to resist it.

Then the organ-girl asks for a halfpenny. The narrator says yes, reaches into his pockets, and finds nothing. The girl, accustomed to being mocked, turns away without a word:

This dumb forbearance was too much for me. If she had abused me, it would have been more endurable.

Again, kindness or patience is harder to bear than hostility. The girl's silent withdrawal is worse than an insult because it confirms the narrator's worst fear about himself: that he is the kind of person from whom nothing can be expected. She does not even bother to be angry. She simply leaves, and her leaving is a judgment more devastating than any words.

The narrator calls her back and, in a frantic attempt to make amends, tries to give her his waistcoat:

"I will make up to you for it," said I; "wait only a moment" ... and lo! I had no waistcoat.

"And lo! I had no waistcoat." The biblical cadence of "lo!" makes the discovery simultaneously comic and tragic. The narrator has forgotten that he pawned his waistcoat weeks ago. His body's inventory of its own clothing is as unreliable as his memory. He is unraveling, and the proof is that he no longer knows what he is wearing.

A crowd gathers. A policeman arrives. The narrator explains that he was trying to give the girl his waistcoat "for her father" and insists he has another one at home. The explanation is patently absurd, and the policeman shoves him along. But the narrator's manuscript has fallen to the ground, and he snatches it up in a panic:

"Yes, by Jove! my newspaper leader; many important papers! However could I be so careless?"

The manuscript is the one thing that cannot be lost. It is the narrator's single remaining connection to his identity as a writer, his ticket back into the world of the employed. He guards it the way a drowning man guards a piece of wreckage, not because it will certainly save him but because it is all there is to hold onto.

The Cake-Seller and the Stranger: Hunger Making Itself Known

At the harbor area, the narrator sits near an old cake-seller, and the proximity of food nearly destroys his composure:

An old woman, a vendor of cakes, sits near me, and bends her brown nose down over her wares. The little table before her is sinfully full of nice things, and I turn away with distaste. She is filling the whole quay with her smell of cakes--phew! up with the windows!

"Sinfully full." The word "sinfully" is doing enormous work here. It is not the narrator who is sinning by wanting the cakes; it is the cakes that are sinning by existing so abundantly in his presence. The narrator's revulsion is a defense mechanism. He cannot afford to want food, because wanting food he cannot have is more painful than pretending to be disgusted by it. The exclamation "up with the windows!" treats the harbor quay as if it were an enclosed room whose ventilation he can control, a small delusion that reveals how far his grip on the distinction between indoors and outdoors has slipped.

He accosts a stranger sitting nearby, complaining about the cake-seller's presence on sanitary grounds. The stranger flees. The narrator offers to show him around the city. The stranger flees faster. The scene is excruciating in its social awkwardness, a starving man trying to start a conversation about public hygiene because he cannot bring himself to say what he actually wants: a halfpenny for a cake.

"You Are a Bungler": The Long Descent

The middle section of Part II records what might be the longest single day in nineteenth-century fiction. The narrator has been walking since morning, and the catalogue of his sufferings is cumulative and methodical. Hamsun does not let us forget the body. The narrator chews wood shavings. He picks up a chip of wood in the street. He pockets satiny shavings from a joiners' work site, putting one in his mouth and saving the other "for by-and-by." He finds a pebble and sucks on it. He tries an orange peel and vomits. The physical details accumulate with the grim specificity of a medical case study, each improvised remedy more desperate than the last.

And through it all, the narrator keeps walking, keeps talking to himself, keeps performing. The self-addresses become increasingly elaborate:

Accompany me down to the bridge, said I to myself--that is to say, if you have spare time!--and I made a bow to myself, and turned towards the railway bridge near the wharf.

He bows to himself. He addresses himself with formal courtesy, as if he were two acquaintances meeting in the street. The self-splitting has become a habit, a way of

generating company when no company is available. By talking to himself, the narrator creates a social world, however attenuated. He is never entirely alone, because he is always at least two people: the one who speaks and the one who listens, the one who commands and the one who obeys.

The Stable-Boy and the Five Shillings

One of the most perfectly constructed comic scenes in Part II occurs when the narrator returns to his lodging. He is about to ask the stable-boy, Jens Olaj, for a shilling. But before he can speak:

"Fine weather! Ahem! I ought to pay my landlady today; you wouldn't be so kind as to lend me five shillings, would you? Only for a few days, sir. You did me a service once before, so you did."

The stable-boy asks the narrator for money. The timing is exquisite. Two men, both broke, both needing to ask the other for help, and the one who speaks first wins, or rather loses, because by asking first he prevents the other from asking at all. The narrator's response is a masterpiece of self-preservation:

"No; I really can't do it, Jens Olaj," I answered. "Not now--perhaps later on, maybe in the afternoon."

"Maybe in the afternoon." The promise is empty, and both men probably know it. But the narrator has been saved from the humiliation of begging by the humiliation of being begged from. He retreats to his room and laughs:

I flung myself on my bed, and laughed. How confoundedly lucky it was that he had forestalled me; my self-respect was saved. Five shillings! God bless you, man, you might just as well have asked me for five shares in the Dampkokken, or an estate out in Aker.

The laughter is the laughter of the paper cornet scene, laughter born of absurdity, of the sheer improbability of the narrator's situation. He has been saved from shame by coincidence, and the relief is so intense that it produces hilarity.

The Tinker's Workshop: Ylajali Returns

In his room, the narrator begins to slip again. The smell of cooking from somewhere nearby, "a downright disgustingly strong smell of chops for dinner," torments him, and his thoughts begin to run "without rein":

"Come in! Yes, only come right in! As you see everything is of ruby-- Ylajali, Ylajali! that swelling crimson silken divan! Ah, how passionately she breathes. Kiss me--loved one--more--more! Your arms are like pale amber, your mouth blushes.... Waiter I asked for a plate of beef!"

The Ylajali fantasy and the hunger fantasy merge. Ruby rooms and plates of beef. A princess's arms and a waiter's service. The two desires, erotic and alimentary, are tangled beyond separation. The narrator knows he is raving. He says so explicitly: "I was continually conscious that I talked at random, and yet I gave utterance to no word without hearing and understanding it." This double consciousness, the ability to observe his own madness while being unable to stop it, is one of the defining features of the narrator's psychology. He is never simply mad. He is always watching himself be mad, and that watching is itself a kind of sanity, a refusal to surrender the last outpost of rational self-awareness.

The Blanket

As the narrator contemplates the end, his thoughts turn to preparation for death. He will wash himself. He will tidy his bed. He will lay his head on the clean white paper, the only clean thing he owns. And then:

I would lay my head upon the sheets of white paper, the cleanest things I had left, and the green blanket. I ... The green blanket! Like a shot I was wide awake.

The green blanket, borrowed from Hans Pauli Pettersen months ago, suddenly becomes not a comfort for the dying but a resource for the living. The narrator can pawn it. The idea arrives "like a shot," interrupting his reverie of death with a burst of survival instinct. It is a moment of dark comedy: the narrator has been composing his own deathbed scene, arranging the props, and one of the props turns out to be worth money.

I rose infinitely superior to the stupid scruples which sprang up in me--half inward cries about a certain stain on my honour. I bade good-bye to the whole of them. I was no hero--no virtuous idiot. I had my senses left.

The moral argument is compressed into a single sentence: "I was no hero--no virtuous idiot." The narrator is pawning a borrowed blanket, a blanket that belongs to his friend, and he knows this is dishonorable. But he also knows he is starving. The phrase "virtuous idiot" captures his contempt for the kind of morality that would let a man die rather than pawn a blanket. Virtue, in this context, is a luxury. It is something you can afford only when you are not starving.

But the pawnshop will not take it:

"Ay, ay; it's no good. I won't own it; and you wouldn't raise a penny on it anywhere."

Even the blanket, the last resource, is worthless. The narrator's one remaining asset has no value in the marketplace. He takes it home, smooths it out on the bed, and tells himself that he must have been temporarily insane to consider pawning it. The moral argument that he had so decisively dismissed now returns in full force:

I could not possibly have been in my right mind at the moment when I came to the conclusion to commit this rascally trick.

The oscillation is dizzying. Five minutes ago, virtue was for idiots. Now, the attempt to pawn the blanket was a "rascally trick" committed while not in his right mind. The narrator's moral framework is as unstable as his mood, shifting with his hunger, his energy, his proximity to other people. When he is starving and alone, pragmatism wins. When the crisis has passed (or rather, when the attempt has failed), principle returns. He is both the man who pawns the blanket and the man who is horrified at having tried.

The Buttons: A Last Comedy

The narrator's final scheme is to pawn the five buttons he has cut from his coat. The soliloquy he holds while cutting them is another of Part II's small theatrical masterpieces:

Yes, you see one has become a little impoverished; a momentary embarrassment ... worn out, do you say? You must not make slips when you speak? I would like to see the person who wears out less buttons than I do, I can tell you!

He is rehearsing the conversation he will have with the pawnbroker, playing both roles, anticipating objections and composing rebuttals. The imaginary dialogue is fluent, confident, persuasive. The narrator could sell anything, in theory. In practice, he cannot sell five buttons.

At the pawnshop, the scene is devastating in its brevity:

Upon this, the old pawnbroker burst out laughing, and returned to his desk without saying a word.

The laughter is the pawnbroker's, not the narrator's, and it is the cruelest sound in Part II. The paper cornet scene produced silent, ecstatic laughter. This laughter is loud,

dismissive, and directed at the narrator himself. He is the joke now. His buttons are the empty cornet. Someone else is laughing.

The narrator tries his eyeglasses. The pawnbroker refuses those too. The narrator asks for enough money for a stamp. The pawnbroker waves him away: "Oh, God help you, go your way!"

Rescue: The Acquaintance at the Pawn-Shop

What comes last is the one thing the narrator could not have planned, could not have rehearsed, could not have earned: grace.

Whilst I stood, lost in thought, a man passed by and entered the office. He had given me a little shove in his hurry. We both made excuses, and I turned round and looked after him.

"What! is that you?" he said, suddenly, when half-way up the steps. He came back, and I recognized him. "God bless me, man, what on earth do you look like? What were you doing in there?"

The acquaintance, unnamed, recognizes the narrator. He sees the buttons in the narrator's hand and understands immediately. His response is direct, almost gruff:

"What the deuce!" he cried. "No; this is really going too far."

"This is really going too far." The phrase is wonderfully ambiguous. It could be addressed to the narrator (you have gone too far in your pride, letting yourself starve rather than ask for help). It could be addressed to the situation (this is too much, this is unbearable, this cannot stand). Either way, it is the voice of someone who refuses to be a bystander. The acquaintance is himself going to the pawnshop. He is himself in need. And yet he acts:

"Of course," he broke in, seizing hold of my arm; "but I may as well tell you I don't believe you. You are such an idiot, that it's better you come in along with me."

The narrator, true to form, tries to refuse. He claims he has an appointment in Bernt Akers Street at half-past seven. Another lie. Another fiction. Another performance. The acquaintance sees through it:

"Half-past seven, quite so; but it's eight now. Here I am, standing with the watch in my hand that I'm going to pawn. So, in with you, you hungry sinner! I'll get you five shillings anyhow."

"You hungry sinner." The phrase is affectionate, exasperated, and accurate. The narrator is hungry. The narrator is a sinner, if sinning means lying about your condition and refusing the

help you need. And the word "sinner" carries a faint echo of the religious register that the narrator has been playing with all day, from his accusation of God as a bungler to his rehearsal of pious phrases for the pastor. Here, at the end, the religious language is stripped of performance. The acquaintance is not performing charity. He is simply doing it, pawning his own watch to get five shillings for a man who cannot feed himself.

| And he pushed me in.

Part II ends with a push. Not a gentle one, but an insistent one, the physical gesture of someone who knows that the narrator's pride will reassert itself at any moment and that the only way to help him is to act before he can refuse. It is the opposite of all the closed doors, the absent friends, the gone-home signs, the laughing pawnbrokers, the indifferent shopkeepers. It is a door opening, a body being moved not away from help but toward it.

The Architecture of Part II

Read as a whole, Part II has the structure of a single enormous day, preceded by a prologue (the evening on the harbor bench and the night in the guard-house cell) and concluded by an epilogue (the rescue at the pawnshop). The day itself, from the morning at the guard-house to the

evening outside the pawnshop, is a marathon of walking, seeking, failing, and walking again. The narrator traverses the city in a great irregular circuit: from the guard-house to Young's Market, to his lodging, to the newspaper office, to Homandsbyen, to Tolbodgaden, back to Bernt Akers Street, back to the newspaper office, to the pastor's house, to Cisler, to the yarn shop, to the pawnshop, to the harbor, to the pawnshop again. Each destination is a station of the cross, a place where hope is kindled and extinguished.

The chapter's emotional shape is not a simple descent. It oscillates wildly: euphoria on the harbor bench, manic comedy with the paper cornet, terror in the dark cell, brittle composure at the guard-house, hope on the way to Pettersen's, blankness on Pettersen's landing, fury in the street, self-punishment on Pyle Street, quiet despair on the church bench, and finally the unearned, unrequested rescue that saves the narrator's life for another few days. The oscillation is the point. Hunger does not produce a steady decline. It produces chaos, a wild and unpredictable swinging between states that would normally be incompatible: laughter and tears, pride and abjection, artistic ecstasy and animal desperation.

Throughout Part II, the narrator never stops creating. He makes a paper cornet. He invents a name. He improvises a life story for the guard. He discovers a word. He rehearses

conversations. He composes a deathbed scene. He performs for policemen, editors, shopkeepers, and strangers. The creative impulse is not weakened by hunger; if anything, it is intensified, driven to wilder and stranger expressions. The narrator cannot stop making things because making things is the only way he knows to assert that he exists. Every lie, every fantasy, every invented word is a small proof of life: I am still here, I am still capable of this, I have not yet been absorbed by the darkness.

Part II is, among other things, a study of what happens to artistic consciousness under extreme physical duress. The answer Hamsun gives is not reassuring. The artist does not become nobler through suffering. He does not gain wisdom or spiritual depth. What he gains is a feverish, uncontrolled inventiveness that produces both brilliant improvisations (the paper cornet, the guard-house performance) and terrifying breakdowns (the nail hole, the invented word, the run up Pyle Street). The fever that the editor complains about in the narrator's writing is the fever of the novel itself, a book written so close to the nerve of its subject that it cannot maintain the sobriety that good craft demands. The fever is the art. Remove it, and you have nothing.

The Theater of Starvation

Part III of *Hunger* opens with a line so disarming it functions almost as a joke: "A week passed in glory and gladness." We know this narrator. We know what his glory looks like and how long his gladness lasts. Sure enough, within a few paragraphs, the week has collapsed. The money is gone. The hair is falling out. The hands must be wrapped in rags because the touch of his own breath on them is unbearable. And yet the narrator is not primarily concerned with survival. He is concerned with something far more volatile, far more dangerous: his dignity.

This is the key to Part III, and perhaps to the novel as a whole. Hamsun's narrator does not merely starve. He performs. Every interaction becomes a scene in a private theater where the audience is himself, where the stakes are not food or shelter but the preservation of an image--the image of a man who does not need help, who refuses charity, who turns aside just so, angling his body to hide the absence of a waistcoat. The comedy, and it is comedy, is that the performance is both magnificent and completely pointless. No one is watching. No one cares whether he has a

waistcoat. But the narrator cares, and his caring is the engine that drives Part III toward its strange, devastating conclusion.

The Commandor's Office

The visit to the editor--whom Hamsun calls "the commandor," a word that carries overtones of military authority, of command and submission--is one of the finest scenes in nineteenth-century fiction. It is also one of the most painfully recognizable. Any writer who has ever submitted work to a gatekeeper, any person who has ever entered an office knowing they will be judged, will feel the peculiar electricity of this encounter.

The narrator arrives with a piece on Correggio. He has worked on it for days, with hands wrapped in rags, through the cold, through the headaches, through the hair falling in tufts onto his pillow. He enters the editor's office and immediately his attention fixes on the paper basket:

I looked about the little office--busts, prints, cuttings, and an enormous paper-basket, that looked as if it might swallow a man, bones and all. I felt sad at heart at the sight of this monstrous chasm, this dragon's mouth, that always stood open, always ready to receive rejected work, newly crushed hopes.

That "monstrous chasm" is one of Hamsun's great images--the wastebasket as abyss, as the mouth of some indifferent beast that devours manuscripts the way the narrator's hunger devours his body. Every writer knows this basket. It sits in every editorial office, every slush pile, every automated rejection email. The technology changes; the chasm remains.

What follows is a masterpiece of social choreography. The narrator turns aside so the editor will not see that he has no waistcoat. He introduces his manuscript with an apology already built into the sentence: "It is only a little character sketch of Correggio, but perhaps it is, worse luck, not written in such a way that...." The self-deprecation is a shield, but it is also a trap. By lowering expectations, he hopes the work will surprise. By declaring it inadequate, he protects himself from the humiliation of having someone else declare it inadequate.

And then Hamsun does something unexpected. He pauses the narrative to let the narrator actually look at this man:

And so it is thus he looks at close quarters, this man, whose name I had already heard in my earliest youth, and whose paper had exercised the greatest influence upon me as the years advanced. His hair is curly, and his beautiful brown eyes are a little restless. He has a habit of tweaking his

nose now and then. No Scotch minister could look milder than this truculent writer, whose pen always left bleeding scars wherever it attacked.

The narrator is overcome. The tears come. He wants to tell this man how much he has meant to him, to confess his admiration, to beg him not to hurt him. But he does none of this. Instead, when the rejection comes--gently, kindly, with a suggestion to write "something a little more commonplace"--the narrator plays a scene of easy acceptance: "Ah, well, of course, it is not of any use to you," he says, and smiles "to give him the impression that I take it easily."

Then the editor offers him an advance. Money for nothing, a gift from one professional to another. And the narrator, who has not eaten in days, who is losing his hair and wrapping his hands in rags, refuses.

Now, as he had just seen that I was not capable of writing, this offer humiliated me somewhat, and I answered: "No, thanks; I can pull through yet a while, thanking you very much, all the same. Good-day!"

This is devastating precisely because the editor is not cruel. The system, in this moment, is not indifferent. A kind man is offering a reasonable kindness, and the narrator's pride--his need to perform self-sufficiency, even as he starves--turns it

away. The tragedy of Part III is not that the world is hostile. It is that the world occasionally extends a hand, and the narrator cannot bring himself to take it.

The Costume of Poverty

The sociologist Erving Goffman spent his career studying what he called "impression management"--the idea that all social life is performance, that we are constantly presenting a self to others, adjusting our behavior based on the audience, the setting, the stakes. Goffman's insight was that this is not dishonesty. It is the basic mechanism of social existence. We all perform. The question is what happens when the costume fails.

For Hamsun's narrator, poverty is not merely a material condition. It is a theatrical catastrophe. The props are gone--the waistcoat, the overcoat, the clean hands, the proper address. Without these things, every social interaction becomes what Goffman would call a "scene"--a moment where the performance breaks down and the backstage reality becomes visible. The narrator knows this. He turns his body to hide the missing waistcoat. He lies about why he has no overcoat. He invents names and addresses. He pretends to be a pastor to a prostitute. He claims the woman he

walked with is his fiancée. He constructs, out of nothing, an elaborate social identity that will survive each encounter for precisely as long as the encounter lasts.

The genius of Hamsun's treatment is that these performances are not strategic deceptions. They are reflexive, almost biological. The narrator lies the way a wounded animal drags itself to cover. He is not trying to gain advantage. He is trying to exist in public without the armor that money provides. When he meets the woman in black--Ylajali, as he names her--his first thought is not desire but exposure:

Badly dressed, as I unfortunately was, I might protect her through the dark streets; but I had an undefined fear that it perhaps might cost me something; a glass of wine, or a drive, and I had no money left at all.

And later, walking beside her, feeling the warmth of her body, smelling her perfume, the narrator's mind circles back to the same terror:

Suppose she were to take it into her head to wish to go there? Into that blaze of light, with the crowd of people. Why, she would be filled with shame; I would drive her out again, with my shabby clothes, and lean face; perhaps she might even notice that I had no waistcoat on....

The missing waistcoat haunts Part III like a recurring nightmare. It is such a small absence--a single garment--but it represents everything. Without it, the narrator cannot enter lit spaces. Without it, he cannot open his coat. Without it, he is not a writer visiting an editor, or a young man courting a woman, but a visible pauper, a man whose body betrays what his words try to conceal.

The Comedy of the Losing Proposition

There is a long tradition, in Western literature, of the starving writer. But most versions of this story are either sentimental--the garret as romantic staging ground--or moralistic, designed to illustrate the cruelty of an indifferent society. Hamsun does something different. He makes starvation funny. Not funny in spite of being terrible, but funny because it is terrible, because the narrator's responses to his situation are so wildly disproportionate, so theatrically elaborate, that they become a kind of dark vaudeville.

Consider the scene with the prostitute. The narrator, penniless and starving, accosts a woman on Carl Johann Street, walks with her a few paces, then announces he has no money. She searches his pockets. She asks if his eyeglasses are gold. They are not. "Then go to blazes with you!" she says. She then calls him back--"You can come with me all the

same!"--and the narrator, mortified, invents an entire persona on the spot: he is a pastor, he has only been testing her virtue, and his parting words are "Depart, and sin no more!" He then walks away congratulating himself:

I rubbed my hands with delight over my happy notion, and soliloquized aloud, "What a joy there is in going about doing good actions." Perhaps I had given this fallen creature an upward impulse for her whole life.

This is comedy of the highest order--not because the narrator is a fool, but because his need to salvage dignity from every encounter is so fierce that it produces absurdity. He cannot even be rejected by a prostitute without constructing a moral victory. The performance must go on, even when the audience is a bewildered stranger and the theater is a dark street at midnight.

Roberto Bolano understood this comedy. His novels are populated by writers who maintain absurd dignity in the face of indifference--the visceral realists of *The Savage Detectives*, those young poets wandering the Mexican desert, broke and brilliant, convinced that literature matters even as the world demonstrates, with mechanical regularity, that it does not. Arturo Belano and Ulises Lima are Hamsun's narrator's grandchildren. They share his conviction that the literary life is worth the suffering, and they share his gift for

turning that suffering into performance. In 2666, Bolano sends his literary scholars on a quest across continents, and the joke--the deep, structural joke--is that their scholarly obsession is a form of the same compulsive meaning-making that drives Hamsun's narrator to write about Correggio while his body eats itself alive. The literary life, in both Hamsun and Bolano, is a fundamentally losing proposition pursued with the intensity of a calling.

What Remains When Everything Is Stripped Away

Part III asks a question that would haunt twentieth-century literature: what is left of a person when status, comfort, and social standing are removed? The narrator has lost nearly everything. His hair. His waistcoat. His ability to keep food down. His capacity for sustained thought. And yet something persists--something fierce and self-destructive and, in its way, admirable. He refuses the editor's advance. He gives stolen money to a cake vendor. He confesses his crime to the bewildered shopkeeper. He curses God in a back alley with an eloquence that suggests the thing consuming him has not yet touched the part that makes sentences.

J.M. Coetzee explored this question with surgical precision in *Disgrace*. David Lurie, stripped of his university position, his reputation, his daughter's safety, his very sense of himself as a civilized man, refuses at every turn to perform the contrition that would restore him. He will not apologize to the disciplinary committee. He will not explain himself. He will not pretend to be reformed. Like Hamsun's narrator, he maintains an elaborate performance of dignity while his life collapses around him--but Lurie's performance is one of refusal, of withholding, where Hamsun's narrator's performance is one of desperate invention.

The connection between the two characters is this: both discover that dignity, once stripped of its material supports, becomes something volatile and strange. It does not disappear. It mutates. Lurie's dignity becomes a kind of cold stubbornness. Hamsun's narrator's dignity becomes a kind of manic theater. Both men would rather suffer than admit to suffering. Both novels suggest that this refusal is simultaneously the most human and the most self-defeating impulse we possess.

When the narrator finally encounters the commandor again, by accident, at the railway wharf, he is at the very bottom:

I was standing face to face with the "Commandor." I get devil-may-care--brazen. I take yet a step farther from the wall in order to make him notice me. I do not do it to awake his compassion, but to mortify myself, place myself, as it were, on the pillory.

This is a remarkable psychological reversal. Having spent the entire novel hiding his poverty, the narrator now displays it. The performance has flipped: instead of pretending to be well, he performs his wretchedness. He steps forward so the editor can see what he has become. And the editor, that kind man with the curly hair and restless brown eyes, simply gives him money: "The Lord preserve you, man, it will never do for you to go and starve yourself to death."

The narrator takes it this time. He is too broken not to. But he cannot thank the man--his legs fail him, his voice is too weak, and the editor walks away. The narrator is left standing on the pavement, weeping, inspecting the coin on both sides as if it might not be real.

The Confessional Impulse

Karl Ove Knausgaard has spoken often of Hamsun as his primary literary ancestor, and nowhere is the inheritance more visible than in Part III of *Hunger*. Knausgaard's six-volume *My Struggle* is built on the same confessional engine:

the relentless, almost compulsive transformation of daily experience--much of it humiliating, much of it banal--into prose. Both writers weaponize the mundane. A trip to a shop, a conversation with a stranger, the act of brushing loose hairs from a coat collar: in both Hamsun and Knausgaard, these small moments are rendered with such intensity that they become unbearable.

The difference--and it is a crucial one--is the safety net. Knausgaard writes from the security of middle-class Norway. His shame is real, but it is the shame of a man who has a home, a family, food in the refrigerator. He is ashamed of his drinking, his failed first marriage, his treatment of his children, his feelings about his dead father. These are serious matters. But they are not existential in the way Hamsun's shame is existential. When Hamsun's narrator wraps his hands in rags and sits down to write, the failure to produce a good sentence is not merely a professional disappointment. It is a death sentence. The essay on Correggio is not an intellectual exercise. It is the thing that stands between the narrator and the bone he will gnaw in a dark alley, weeping and vomiting, cursing God.

Knausgaard understood this. In the first volume of *My Struggle*, he describes the act of writing as a stripping away, a deliberate removal of the social masks that protect us. Hamsun's narrator has the masks stripped away by

circumstance--by poverty, by hunger, by the slow erosion of the body. The result, in both cases, is a prose of terrifying intimacy. We are not reading about a character. We are reading the inside of a mind that has nowhere left to hide.

But where Knausgaard's confession is ultimately an act of control--he shapes the narrative, he decides what to reveal, he publishes from a position of literary celebrity--Hamsun's narrator is confessing under duress. The confession is involuntary, like the vomiting. The truth comes up because it cannot be kept down.

The Scene on the Carpet

The evening with Ylajali is the novel's most agonizing performance. The narrator has money now, the commandor's half-sovereign. He has shaved. He arrives at her apartment. She teases him, chases him around a table, criticizes his reticence. And then she asks why his hair is falling out, and the narrator, instead of lying--instead of performing the role of the dissolute young rake she seems to expect--tells the truth. He tells her everything. The starvation, the stolen money, the bone in the alley.

She sat and listened, with open mouth, pale, frightened, her shining eyes completely bewildered.

The confession destroys the evening. Ylajali retreats. She murmurs "the Lord preserve me" at intervals. And then she says the words that cut deepest: "I can't be sure that you are not insane."

What follows is one of the most extraordinary passages in the novel. The narrator, standing at her door, delivers a monologue that is simultaneously a love speech, a self-defense, and a breakdown. He asks to kneel before her. He points to a specific rose in the carpet pattern where he would kneel. He insists he is not insane. He insists he is not moving. He describes his own stillness with the precision of a stage direction:

I stood just as immovable as I stand now when I point out the place to you where I would have knelt before you, over there on the crimson rose in the carpet. I don't even point with my finger. I don't point at all; I let it be, not to frighten you.

This is a man performing sanity. Every word is calibrated to prove that he is calm, rational, in control--and the very intensity of the performance proves the opposite. He is a man standing in a woman's apartment, describing the specific floor tile on which he would prostrate himself, insisting that the act of not kneeling demonstrates his reasonableness. The scene is funny and terrible in equal

measure, and it contains the entire novel in miniature: a man using language to construct an identity that his body and circumstances are systematically dismantling.

The Audience of One

What makes Part III so strange, so modern, is that the narrator's performances are not really for other people. The editor does not care about the waistcoat. The prostitute does not care about his moral lecture. Ylajali, in the end, seems to embrace him despite everything. The performances are for the narrator himself. He is his own audience, his own critic, his own judge. When he gives the stolen money to the cake vendor, he does not do it because the cake vendor needs it. He does it because he needs to feel honest again. When he confesses to the shopkeeper, he does not do it for justice. He does it for the performance of confession, the theater of moral rectitude.

This is what separates Hamsun from Dostoevsky, with whom he is often compared. Dostoevsky's underground man performs for the reader, for posterity, for God. Hamsun's narrator performs for an audience of one--himself--and the performance is never adequate. He can never quite convince himself. The role shifts too quickly: he is a dignified writer, then a thief, then a penitent, then a pastor, then a lover, then

a madman, then a man who is not a madman. Each identity lasts only as long as the scene requires, and then the curtain falls and he is back in the cold room, with the hair on the pillow and the hands in rags.

Part III ends with the narrator backing out of Ylajali's apartment. "I crushed her in my arms, stepped back, rushed to the door, and went out backwards." It is the exit of a man who cannot turn his back on beauty even as he retreats from it. Even in departure, the performance continues. Even in loss, the gesture must be right.

This is the theater of starvation: a one-man show, performed for an empty house, in which the actor is slowly being consumed by the role. The audience does not arrive. The reviews never come. And the actor, magnificent and doomed, keeps performing, because the alternative--to stop, to sit down, to admit that the show is over--is the one thing he cannot do.

Close Reading: Part III

The False Dawn

Part III begins with seven words that function as a trap:

| A week passed in glory and gladness.

By this point in the novel we have learned to distrust the narrator's optimism. We know its rhythm. Every upswing in his fortunes arrives with a little burst of expansiveness, a moment where the prose loosens and the sentences grow short and declarative, as though certainty itself were a kind of wealth. This opening sentence has the quality of a fairy-tale beginning -- "once upon a time" translated into the language of a man who measures his life in weeks rather than years. A week is his unit of prosperity. Seven days of eating. Seven days without the kind of crisis that has defined Parts I and II. For the narrator, this constitutes glory.

The second sentence confirms the pattern and begins to undercut it:

I had got over the worst this time, too. I had had food every day, and my courage rose, and I thrust one iron after the other into the fire.

Notice "this time, too." The little qualifier acknowledges that there have been other crises, other recoveries. The narrator has survived before and frames this survival as a repeatable event, a cycle he has mastered. But the phrasing also betrays what he will not quite say: "the worst" has come more than once, and the distance between each recovery and the next collapse is shrinking. The idiom "thrust one iron after the other into the fire" suggests industriousness, but it also carries a note of desperation -- too many irons, too much fire, a man working on three or four articles simultaneously because he cannot afford for any single one to fail.

The next paragraph introduces the Correggio article obliquely. The narrator has already had a piece rejected and "destroyed it immediately, without even re-reading it again." This is a small but crucial detail. In Part I and Part II the narrator clung to his manuscripts, revised them obsessively, carried them about the city. Now he destroys without re-reading. The gesture is meant to look decisive -- a man cutting his losses -- but it reads as fragile. He cannot bear to re-read because re-reading would force him to confront the gap between what he imagined the piece to be and what it actually was.

Then Hamsun introduces the ship:

Supposing that writing were to fail, and the worst were to come to the worst, I still had the ships to take to. The Nun lay alongside the wharf, ready to sail, and I might, perhaps, work my way out to Archangel, or wherever else she might be bound.

The Nun will not appear again until much later, when the narrator asks a lame man at the railway wharf whether she has sailed. By then, it will be too late -- the ship is gone. But here, in the opening paragraph, she sits at anchor as a kind of psychological insurance policy. The narrator names the ship the way a person names the exit in a crowded room: not because he intends to use it, but because knowing it exists allows him to stay. The Nun's destination -- Archangel, a real Russian port city whose name carries overtones of the angelic, the celestial -- is characteristically Hamsun: a factual detail that resonates metaphorically without ever being pushed toward explicit symbolism. The narrator might escape to the city of archangels. He might work passage on a ship called "the Nun," a vessel of renunciation. But he does not. He stays in Christiania and writes.

The Body at the Writing Table

What follows is one of Hamsun's most concentrated passages on the physical toll of literary production:

The last crisis had dealt rather roughly with me. My hair fell out in masses, and I was much troubled with headaches, particularly in the morning, and my nervousness died a hard death. I sat and wrote during the day with my hands bound up in rags, simply because I could not endure the touch of my own breath upon them.

The sentence about the hands has an almost clinical precision. He does not say the hands are injured, or infected, or cold. He says he cannot endure "the touch of my own breath upon them." The sensitivity is so extreme that the body has become intolerable to itself -- even its own exhalations are an assault. This is starvation rendered not as an absence (of food, of nourishment) but as a surplus of sensation. The starving body does not go numb. It becomes hyperaware. The nervous system, deprived of fuel, fires indiscriminately. Every stimulus -- a dog's bark, a slamming door, the feel of one's own breath -- penetrates "like icy stabs piercing me from every side."

Hamsun understood, decades before the clinical literature would confirm it, that severe malnutrition produces neurological hypersensitivity. The Minnesota Starvation Experiment of 1944-45, conducted by Ancel Keys at the University of Minnesota, would document precisely this phenomenon: subjects who had been semi-starved reported extreme sensitivity to noise, light, and touch, along with difficulty concentrating and a persistent, obsessive preoccupation with food. Hamsun needed no laboratory. He had lived it.

The hair falling out "in masses" is another clinically accurate detail. Severe protein deficiency causes telogen effluvium -- hair follicles shift prematurely into their resting phase and the hair falls in clumps. Later in Part III, when the narrator lies on his bed and strokes his hair, "small loose tufts came away, flakes that got between my fingers, and scattered over the pillow." The detail is handled with extraordinary restraint. He does not cry out or lament. He notes it, almost indifferently: "I did not think anything about it just then; it was as if it did not concern me. I had hair enough left, anyway." That last clause -- "I had hair enough left, anyway" -- is one of the most devastating understatements in the novel. It is the language of a man who has learned to measure his losses by what remains rather than by what is gone.

The Commandor's Office

The visit to the editor is dealt with at length in the companion essay "The Theater of Starvation," which examines the scene's social choreography and what it reveals about the narrator's compulsion to perform self-sufficiency. Here I want to attend to something the essay does not linger on: the quality of the prose itself during this scene, and what it tells us about Hamsun's narrative technique.

The narrator enters the editor's office and Hamsun shifts tense. We have been in the past tense -- "I thrust it, contented and happy, into my pocket, and betook myself to the 'commandor.'" Now, as the narrator sits in the office, the prose slips into present:

"The 28th," I reply, pleased that I can be of service to him, "the 28th," and he continues writing.

This is Hamsun's characteristic tense-drift. When the narrator is recounting events at a safe distance, the past tense holds. When anxiety floods in, the present tense surfaces. The shift is not systematic -- it does not follow a rule -- and that is precisely what makes it effective. It mimics the way memory works: most of the past is past, but certain moments remain stubbornly present, replaying as though they are still

happening. The office visit is one of these moments. The narrator is still there, still sitting across from this man, still hoping and dreading in the same breath.

The description of the editor is worth pausing over:

His hair is curly, and his beautiful brown eyes are a little restless. He has a habit of tweaking his nose now and then. No Scotch minister could look milder than this truculent writer, whose pen always left bleeding scars wherever it attacked.

The word "beautiful" catches the eye. This is how a lover describes a face, not how a suppliant describes a gatekeeper. The narrator's relationship to this man is not merely professional. It is filial, erotic, devotional -- all tangled together. "Whose name I had already heard in my earliest youth, and whose paper had exercised the greatest influence upon me as the years advanced." The commandor is a father figure, a literary model, the audience the narrator has always been writing for. And the tears that nearly come -- "I advanced a step to tell him how heartily I appreciated him" -- are the tears of a son before a father who holds the power to approve or destroy.

The rejection itself is a masterclass in misdirection. The editor says the piece is too sophisticated for his public -- "you know the kind of public we have" -- and the narrator pre-emptively reaches for his manuscript: "I stretch out my hand a little." This tiny gesture is loaded with meaning. He is taking back the work before it can be fully refused. He is saving the editor the discomfort of a direct no. He is, above all, preserving the fiction that the piece might have been accepted under different circumstances, by a different publication, for a different readership. The rejection is displaced from the quality of the work to the nature of the audience, and the narrator colludes in this displacement because the alternative -- that his writing is simply not good enough -- is unbearable.

When the editor offers an advance, and the narrator refuses it, Hamsun gives us the internal logic with merciless clarity:

Now, as he had just seen that I was not capable of writing, this offer humiliated me somewhat.

The word "somewhat" does enormous work. It underplays the humiliation, which is in fact total. If the editor has just judged his writing inadequate, then an advance is not a professional

courtesy -- it is charity. And charity from the man whose approval he craves most is worse than rejection. The narrator walks away with nothing.

The Paper Basket

Before leaving the editor's office, the narrator's eye has already lingered on the paper basket:

an enormous paper-basket, that looked as if it might swallow a man, bones and all. I felt sad at heart at the sight of this monstrous chasm, this dragon's mouth, that always stood open, always ready to receive rejected work, newly crushed hopes.

The image is extraordinary in its violence. "Swallow a man, bones and all." The paper basket is not a receptacle but a predator. It consumes manuscripts the way the narrator's hunger consumes his body. And the phrase "newly crushed hopes" has a temporal specificity that is easy to miss: not old hopes, not forgotten hopes, but newly crushed ones -- hopes that were alive minutes ago, that walked into this room inside a coat pocket, that were handed across this desk with trembling hands.

The basket is also the narrator's double. Both are hungry. Both consume. The basket takes in manuscripts; the narrator cannot keep food down. The basket's mouth is "always open, always ready"; the narrator's stomach is always empty, always craving. In a novel obsessed with consumption and its failure, the paper basket stands as a monument to the appetite of indifference -- the world's vast, mechanical capacity to receive what we produce and do nothing with it.

The Woman in Black

After the rejection, the narrative shifts. The narrator resolves to write something that will "astonish the 'commandor' a bit" and goes home. Then Hamsun introduces a new element with the quiet precision of a stage direction:

During the following evenings, as soon as it got near eight o'clock and the gas was lit, the following thing happened regularly to me. As I come out of my room to take a walk in the streets after the labour and troubles of the day, a lady, dressed in black, stands under the lamp-post exactly opposite my door.

The tense shifts to present again. The regularity is important: "the following thing happened regularly to me." She is there every evening, in the same place, in the same dress, with the same thick veil and the same small umbrella "with an ivory

ring in the handle." The details accumulate like items in an inventory -- the veil, the umbrella, the ivory ring. The narrator notices everything and understands nothing. He is "possessed by the unreasonable feeling that I was the object of her visit" but cannot act because he has no money to offer if the encounter should require a glass of wine or a drive.

There is a heartbreaking sentence buried in this passage that is easy to read past:

I had not even the courage to scrutinize her sharply as I passed her by.

Poverty has stolen his ability to look. Looking is an act of social parity -- you look closely at people you consider your equals, people you might approach, people whose scrutiny you can withstand. The narrator cannot look because looking implies a capacity to follow through, and he has no capacity. His "distressingly empty pockets" have drained not just his courage but his right to attention, his license to see.

Between the woman's introduction and the narrator's approach to her, Hamsun inserts a long paragraph about his physical deterioration. The timing is significant. The woman stands at the lamppost, waiting; the narrator's body fails. The

juxtaposition says what the narrator will not: that desire and dissolution are running on parallel tracks, and Part III is the stretch of road where they converge.

The Search for a Candle

The candle becomes Part III's most persistent material obsession. The narrator needs one to work through the night and finish his article. A candle costs almost nothing. And yet it proves nearly impossible to obtain.

First he tries to find his acquaintance at the Opland Cafe, to borrow a penny. He fails. Then he rages against his luck -- "Wasn't it now the very hottest eternal devil existing to think that my hardships never would come to an end!" -- and walks to the Palace. There is a magnificent passage here in which the narrator's fury turns inward and then outward, oscillating between self-pity and contempt:

Were I to find at this moment a schoolgirl's savings or a poor widow's only penny, I would snatch it up and pocket it; steal it deliberately, and sleep the whole night through like a top. I had not suffered so unspeakably much for nothing--my patience was gone--I was prepared to do anything.

He is not actually prepared to do anything. He will not steal from a schoolgirl or a widow. He knows this, and we know this. The declaration is a performance of desperation, an attempt to convince himself that he has crossed a moral threshold. The real threshold -- the one he will cross -- is still ahead: the scene in the provision shop where he takes money that is not his. But first, the candle.

After the encounter with the prostitute (which we will come to), the narrator retrieves his papers and tries to write under a streetlamp:

All around was quiet; I heard the heavy clanking footstep of a constable down in Taergade, and far away in the direction of St. Han's Hill a dog barked. There was nothing to disturb me.

The irony is beautiful. "There was nothing to disturb me" -- except that he is standing outside in the cold, in the dark, with no desk and no candle, writing under a lamp-post while a constable patrols nearby. The absence of disturbance is itself the disturbance. The setting is absurd, and the narrator's refusal to acknowledge the absurdity -- his sincere attempt to work under these conditions -- is both comic and terrible.

He describes what he needs for his essay: "a quite imperceptible transition to something fresh, then a subdued gliding finale, a prolonged murmur, ending at last in a climax as bold and as startling as a shot, or the sound of a mountain avalanche--full stop." The language is precise and musical, a miniature theory of composition. The narrator knows exactly what good prose sounds like. He can describe it with luminous clarity. He simply cannot produce it -- not here, not now, not standing under a lamppost with a constable watching and the cold seeping into his bones.

Karl Johann at Night

Before the streetlamp scene, the narrator walks the city's main street at the "great hour." The passage is one of Hamsun's most sustained renderings of urban night-life as experienced by someone locked outside its economy:

The great hour had commenced, the pairing time when the mystic traffic is in full swing--and the hour of merry adventures sets in. Rustling petticoats, one or two still short, sensual laughter, heaving bosoms, passionate, panting breaths, and far down near the Grand Hotel, a voice calling "Emma!"

The final detail -- "a voice calling 'Emma!'" -- is a stroke of genius. After the generalized catalog of sensual sounds (petticoats, laughter, breath), a single, specific voice calls a single, specific name. The name "Emma" grounds the passage in a particular human encounter -- someone is looking for someone -- and the distance from which the narrator hears it ("far down near the Grand Hotel") measures his exclusion. He is not near the Grand Hotel. He is somewhere farther away, listening to other people's lives.

The narrator reaches into his pockets and finds nothing. The street becomes "a swamp, from which hot vapours exuded." The metaphor is sexual and infernal simultaneously -- the swamp as a place of generation and decay, of desire pooling in the gutters. He cannot participate, and his exclusion generates contempt:

These easily-pleased, confectionery-eating students, who fancy they are sowing their wild oats in truly Continental style if they tickle a sempstress under the ribs!

The catalog of contempt that follows -- the students, the bank clerks, the "blowsy Molls" -- is delivered with an energy that is itself a form of desire. The narrator despises these people because he wants what they have: not merely sex but the casual, unthinking ease with which they move through the night. They have money for drinks. They have clothes that do

not shame them. They have the right to look, to approach, to be approached. The contempt is a mirror image of the longing. Each insult measures the distance between the narrator and the thing he wants.

The Prostitute

Then, at Stortingsplads, Hamsun gives us one of Part III's comic set-pieces. The narrator feels his empty pockets and is consumed by the injustice of desire without means:

What humiliation, too; what disgrace! I began again to think about the poor widow's last mite, that I would have stolen a schoolboy's cap or handkerchief, or a beggar's wallet.

Then comes the contempt -- for the students, the bank clerks, the "blowsy Molls." The contempt is protective. If he cannot participate in the sexual economy of the night street, he will position himself above it. The narrator lifts his head and feels "the blessing of being able to keep my own sty clean." There is an ugly, self-righteous energy here that Hamsun captures without flinching. The narrator's poverty has not made him virtuous. It has made him mean.

At Stortingsplads he meets the girl. The exchange is swift, brutal, and funny. He says good-night. She says good-night. He questions her about walking late, about being accosted, about being asked "to go along home with any one." She takes his arm: "Yes, and we went too!" They walk a few paces. Then:

"Listen, my dear, I don't own a farthing!" and with that I went on.

She searches his pockets. She finds nothing. She asks if his eyeglasses are gold. They are not. "Then go to blazes with you!" The transaction fails because the narrator has nothing to transact with. He cannot even be a customer.

Then she calls him back: "You can come with me all the same!" This offer -- genuine, generous, a gift of human contact without payment -- is the one thing the narrator cannot accept. It would mean being the object of pity from someone he considers beneath him. And so he invents: he becomes "Pastor So-and-so," delivering a moral lecture, telling her to "depart, and sin no more." The Biblical language is a shield. The pastoral identity is an improvisation so complete that the narrator immediately begins to believe in it:

I rubbed my hands with delight over my happy notion, and soliloquized aloud, "What a joy there is in going about doing good actions."

There is a word for what the narrator does here, and it is not quite "lying." It is something more complicated: a spontaneous construction of a self that can survive the encounter. He has been rejected -- twice, once by the editor and now by the economics of the night street -- and each time he builds a compensatory identity that allows him to walk away with something intact. The pastor is that identity's most absurd incarnation. But listen to the sentence that follows the self-congratulation: "Perhaps I had given this fallen creature an upward impulse for her whole life; save her, once for all, from destruction." The narrator is not merely deluded. He is narrating himself into goodness. The lie, having been told, must be made true, and the only way to make it true is to build a story around it in which the lie becomes a moral act.

The Provision Shop

The narrator eventually goes to the provision shop for a candle. What happens there is one of the most psychologically intricate passages in the novel.

The shopman knows him. He automatically wraps a loaf and pushes it across the counter. The narrator asks for a candle instead -- "I say it very quietly and humbly, in order not to vex him and spoil my chance of getting what I want." This line is important because it reveals the narrator's awareness that his credit depends on goodwill, and goodwill depends on predictability. He has always bought bread. Asking for a candle is a deviation, and the shopman is "quite cross at my unexpected words."

A woman is making purchases. She pays with a florin and receives change. Then she leaves, and the shop-boy turns back to the narrator. He tears open a package and takes out a candle. The narrator looks at him. He cannot bring himself to ask for credit.

Then the shop-boy says something extraordinary: "Oh yes, that's true; you paid, though!"

He simply asserts that I had paid. I heard every word, and he begins to count some silver out of the till, coin after coin, shining stout pieces. He gives me back change for a crown.

The boy has confused the narrator's visit with the woman's payment. The change he counts out is the woman's change, attributed to the narrator. And the narrator -- "I do not

reflect; do not think about anything at all" -- takes the money. He gathers it up "mechanically." He stands "stupid with amazement, dumb, paralyzed."

What Hamsun captures here, with extraordinary fidelity, is the experience of moral failure as it happens in real time. The narrator does not decide to steal. There is no moment of deliberation, no weighing of options. The money appears, he takes it, and only afterward does the machinery of consciousness engage. He stares at a bell hanging from a leather collar. He discusses the weather with the shop-boy. He hears his own voice as if it belongs to someone else: "each word I uttered struck my ear as if it were coming from another person." The dissociation is total. The self that speaks and the self that listens are no longer the same self.

When the shop-boy calls after him -- the narrator prepares to hand the money back, feeling no surprise, no fear -- it is only to remind him that he has forgotten his candle. The anticlimax is devastating. The moment of reckoning does not arrive. The theft succeeds by accident, by the shop-boy's failure to notice, and the narrator walks away with both the candle and the money, into a moral wilderness he has entered without ever choosing to.

His first thought is pragmatic: "I was helped--extraordinarily, grandly, incredibly helped--helped for a long, long time." The repetition of "helped" has a manic quality. He is trying to convince himself that something good has happened. The money is real, it is in his pocket, it will buy food. But even as he counts the coins under the lamppost, the word "helped" carries its own undermining resonance -- to be helped is to be helpless, and the help he has received is stolen.

The Restaurant and the Waitress

With stolen money in his pocket, the narrator enters an eating-house and orders beef. The scene is brief but dense with significance. He sits "by myself at a little table next to the door" -- near the exit, in the dark, hidden. His first conscious moral reckoning begins here: "My first downright dishonesty was accomplished--my first theft."

He eats like an animal: "swallowed whole pieces without chewing them, enjoyed myself in an animal-like way at every mouthful, and tore at the meat like a cannibal." The language deliberately strips the narrator of his humanity. For dozens of pages he has been constructing elaborate verbal identities --

writer, pastor, gentleman -- and now, with food in front of him, the construction collapses. He is a body, an appetite, a mouth.

Then the waitress offers him a drink -- "from me ... without ... that is, if you will...." The halting syntax is Hamsun at his most delicate. She cannot finish the sentence because the offer is a kindness she is not supposed to extend. She sees something in this man that troubles her. Her dropped eyes, her bending down, her ellipses -- these are the gestures of someone who recognizes suffering and is moved by it but does not know the protocol for responding.

The narrator refuses the drink, pays for the beef, and gives the waitress the remaining change -- "There, you're to have the balance to buy yourself a farm." The joke is extravagant, almost lordly. He is tipping with stolen money, performing generosity he cannot afford, and the tears are "near my ears" -- Hamsun's odd, beautiful phrasing, as though the tears have migrated from their proper place and are hovering at the edges of his hearing.

He leaves quickly, afraid of the light, afraid the waitress will see him clearly: "I was afraid to go near the light--afraid to show myself too plainly to the young girl, who never for a moment suspected the depth of my misery." The waitress, of course, has already seen. Her offer of a free drink was proof

that she saw. But the narrator cannot accept being seen, just as he could not accept the prostitute's generosity or the editor's advance. To be seen is to be known, and to be known in his current state is intolerable.

Then the food comes back up. The nausea is immediate and violent. He vomits at every dark corner, "blinded with the water which gushed from my eyes." The body rejects what the stomach craves. It is one of the novel's central physical facts: starvation, prolonged enough, makes eating itself impossible. The stomach shrinks. The digestive enzymes diminish. The very mechanism of survival atrophies from disuse.

The narrator asks a stranger what to give "a man who had been starving for a long time." The indirection is both comic and desperate -- he is asking for medical advice about himself, in the third person, on a street corner. "Hot milk," says the man. The narrator gets the milk, drinks it, and keeps it down. He has found, by accident, the one thing his ruined stomach can process. The detail is so small and so practical that it cuts through the novel's accumulating atmosphere of extremity. Milk. Hot milk. It is almost nothing. And yet it is enough.

First Meeting with Ylajali

The woman in black returns for the fourth time. "She is standing perfectly motionless." The narrator's nerves are irritated from the meal, his thoughts "in good working order." He approaches her. The conversation that follows is one of the most carefully constructed dialogues in the novel -- a duet between two people who are each concealing something, each testing the other.

She says she is only standing there "for a whim." He offers her wine. She declines but asks him to walk with her -- "it was rather dark to go home now." They move off together, and the narrator's senses fill with her: "the scent of her hair; the warmth that irradiated from her body; the perfume of woman that accompanied her; the sweet breath every time she turned her face towards me." The catalog of sensations is lush, almost overwhelming, and it is set against the narrator's physical reality -- no overcoat, no waistcoat, no money, his body a thing of rags and bones. The woman's body is warmth and perfume; his is cold and hunger. They walk side by side, and the gap between them is immense.

He touches her shoulder and says, "How queer you are." She answers, "Am I, really; in what way?" The exchange has the rhythm of flirtation, but the narrator's next move is a lie. He tells her that when he followed her before -- the incident

from an earlier part of the novel -- it was actually her sister he was following. The lie is transparent, and she sees through it immediately: "Oh, how sly you are; you only said that just to get me to raise my veil, didn't you?" Her response is delighted rather than offended. She understands the game. She is playing it too.

The name "Ylajali" surfaces three times in this scene -- the narrator's private word for her, first used in an earlier part of the novel. When he says it aloud, she does not understand: "I beg pardon?" He says, "I only said 'Ylajali' ... it's all right. Continue...." The name is a kind of incantation, a word from his private language that he cannot help speaking aloud. It belongs to the same order of involuntary utterance as the nonsense words he invented in Part I -- "Kuboaq," the made-up language of madness and creativity. Ylajali is a name that comes from nowhere, means nothing in any language, and yet names the thing the narrator desires most. It is a word for what cannot be named: beauty, connection, the possibility of being loved by someone who does not know what you have become.

She tells him she lives in St. Olav's Place with her deaf mother and that she has a sister who has gone to Hamburg. She asks about his overcoat -- "Gracious! don't you freeze without an overcoat?" -- and he lies. "No, not at all." He

changes the subject to the menagerie in the Tivoli, then immediately panics at the thought that she might want to go inside, into the light, where his clothes would be visible.

There follows a passage in which the narrator improvises a little discourse on animals -- he prefers wild creatures, unseen in their lairs, "shy creatures that nestle in their lair, and lie with sluggish green eyes, and lick their claws, and muse." The speech is charming and strange, a miniature of the narrator's sensibility at its best: precise, unexpected, vaguely poetic. It is also a confession disguised as an aesthetic preference. The narrator identifies with the hidden animal. He, too, is a creature of the dark, observed and ashamed. He would rather be the unseen watcher than the watched.

Then comes the internal revolt. In the middle of their walk, the narrator turns on himself and on the situation with sudden fury:

And why was I walking there, giving myself airs, and smiling idiotically at nothing? Had I perhaps said anything rude to her from the beginning? ... Did I not feel the ice of death go right into my heart at even the gentlest puff of wind that blew against us? Was not madness running riot in my brain, just for lack of food for many months at a stretch?

The passage is characteristic of Hamsun's method in Part III: the narrator's consciousness oscillates between enchantment and despair with no transitional ground between them. One moment he is charmed by his own eloquence about wild animals. The next he is asking why this woman does not "turn her back on me, and let me go to the deuce." The oscillation is not dramatic irony. It is the real texture of consciousness under extreme stress -- the mind lurching between what it wants and what it knows, between the fantasy of connection and the fact of ruin.

He says to her, out loud: "Considering all things, you ought not to walk with me. I disgrace you right under every one's eyes, if only with my clothes. Yes, it is positively true; I mean it." The line is both confession and test. He is telling her the truth about his condition and watching to see what she does with it. If she leaves, he will have his answer. If she stays, she stays knowing -- or at least suspecting -- what he is.

She is startled. She says "Indeed, though!" -- a response so compressed it is almost unreadable. Does she mean "indeed, you do disgrace me"? Or "indeed, you think I care about your clothes"? Or simply "indeed, stop talking like that"? The ambiguity is deliberate. The narrator does not know, and neither do we. When he presses -- "What do you mean by that?" -- she retreats into deflection: "Ugh, no; you make me feel ashamed.... We have not got very far now." She walks

faster. The shame she expresses is ambiguous too: ashamed of what? Of being seen with him? Of having made him feel he needed to apologize? Of the whole situation, the darkness, the cold, the strange young man with no overcoat? Hamsun leaves the shame unspecified because shame, in this novel, is never simple. It radiates in all directions at once, touching everyone in the scene.

They reach St. Olav's Place. She stops. He asks if he may see her again. He asks her to lift her veil. She deflects both requests and instead gives him a date: "You can meet me outside here on Tuesday evening. Will you?" The naming of a specific day is more intimate than any gesture. It means she has been thinking ahead. It means she has imagined a future in which he appears.

Then the veil comes up. She lifts it "with a resolute movement." He cries "Ylajali!" -- the third time, now face to face. And she kisses him.

She stretched herself up, flung her arms round my neck and kissed me right on the mouth--only once, swiftly, bewilderingly swiftly, right on the mouth.

The repetition of "right on the mouth" is remarkable. The narrator cannot believe it happened there, on the mouth, not on the cheek or the forehead but the mouth, the place of

speech and hunger, the place where words come out and food goes in. The kiss connects the novel's two great hungers -- for nourishment and for love -- in a single, bewildering gesture.

"The hall door shut." And Part III's first section ends.

The Morning After

A horizontal rule marks the break. The next section opens with weather and weather as emotional projection:

It snowed still more the next day, a heavy snow mingled with rain; great wet flakes that fell to earth and were turned to mud.

Snow turning to mud: a perfect image for the morning after enchantment. The narrator wakes with his "heart intoxicated from the foregone evening" and embraces the air, "kissed the air." But the intoxication is literal -- he is feverish, delirious, running on the fumes of a single kiss. He buys milk and beef with the stolen money, then goes to a clothes-shop in the bazaar to look for a waistcoat.

There he meets an acquaintance -- a designer -- who asks about the woman he was seen walking with. The narrator lies instantly and fluently: she is his fiancée. "It was all settled yesterday evening." Notice the speed of the fabrication. He

does not hesitate, does not weigh options. The lie arrives fully formed, complete with the temporal detail -- "yesterday evening" -- that gives it the texture of truth. Hamsun captures something precise about the psychology of lying under pressure: the best lies are not planned but spontaneous, produced by a mind that operates faster than its own moral supervision. The narrator's first instinct, when exposed, is to invent. He does not choose to lie. He lies the way he breathes -- automatically, as a condition of social survival.

The designer is "completely nonplussed." He believes it. "I lied in the most accomplished manner to get rid of him." The phrase "to get rid of him" is revealing. The lie is not expansive -- the narrator does not want to elaborate, to build a story, to enjoy the fiction. He wants the conversation over. The fiancée-lie is a door-closer, a way of making the question disappear. But it also reveals something about what the narrator wants to believe. He calls her his fiancée because, for a moment, in the grammar of the sentence, it feels true. The lie is a rehearsal for a reality he craves.

They have a beer, and the designer mentions that he owes the narrator a few shillings. "Yes, thanks," the narrator says, "but I knew that he would never pay me back the few shillings." The aside is quietly devastating. The narrator knows the economy of small debts among the poor: money owed is money lost. The shillings will not come. They never do. But the

narrator does not press the matter, does not remind the man, does not insist. To insist would be to admit that the shillings matter, and to admit that they matter would be to reveal the depth of his need. Even with an acquaintance, the performance of indifference must be maintained.

The beer goes to his head. The thought of the stolen money returns with sudden force:

The theft rushed in upon me in all its details. I saw the little shop, the counter, my lean hands as I seized the money, and I pictured to myself the line of action the police would adopt when they would come to arrest me.

The vision is cinematic -- irons on his hands, the dock, the clerk's pen scratching, "his threatening look." The narrator imagines his own trial with the specificity of someone directing a film. He is simultaneously the criminal and the audience for his own prosecution. And then, characteristically, he pulls himself out of the fantasy: "How in the wide world could any one prove that I had stolen?" The mind that imagined the dock now imagines the defense. The oscillation between guilt and self-justification runs through the rest of the day like a fever.

The Cake Vendor and the Giving Away of the Money

What follows is a passage of moral recklessness disguised as moral purity. The narrator, tormented by the stolen money, walks to the market-place and gives every farthing of it to a cake vendor -- "clapped the money without further ado into her hands." He speaks not a word. He turns and walks away.

What a wonderful savour there was in feeling oneself an honest man once more! My empty pockets troubled me no longer; it was simply a delightful feeling to me to be cleaned out.

The passage is one of the most complex moral moments in the novel. On the surface, the narrator has done a good thing: he has surrendered stolen money to someone who needs it. But the gesture is also wildly self-serving. He has not returned the money to the shopkeeper. He has not made the victim whole. He has given it to a random stranger because the act of giving restores his self-image. The moral equation balances not in the world but in the narrator's internal theater: he feels honest, therefore he is honest.

The joy that follows is almost alarming. "I felt inclined to play the wildest pranks, to do something astounding, to set the whole town in a ferment." He tells his age to a

commissionaire for no reason. He studies paving-stones. He hops on a cab and orders it to "Ullevoldsveien, No. 37" -- an address he has invented, to visit a man named Kierulf who does not exist.

The Cab Ride and Kierulf

Before the cab ride, notice what triggers it. The narrator has just given away the stolen money and is now penniless again. He feels "inclined to play the wildest pranks." He tells his age to a commissionaire. He studies paving-stones. And then: "I arrive at length at Parliament Place. I stand all at once stock-still, and look at the droskes." The sudden stillness in the middle of manic motion is characteristic. The narrator's consciousness does not decelerate gradually. It stops, fixes on something -- the line of cabs, the drivers chatting -- and then lurches into action: "'Go ahead!' I say, giving myself a dig with my elbow."

The self-addressed command and the self-administered dig are remarkable. He is both the man who gives the order and the man who receives it. The splitting of self into commander and commanded has been happening all through Part III -- he talks to himself, congratulates himself,

punishes himself -- but here it becomes physical. He digs his own elbow. He propels himself forward as if he were a reluctant horse.

The Kierulf episode is one of the strangest passages in Part III, and perhaps in the entire novel. The narrator hails a cab -- though he has just given away all his money -- and directs it to an address where he asks for "Joachim Kierulf, a wool-dealer." No such person exists. The maid at the door has never heard of him. The narrator runs back to the cab: "He wasn't there." And they drive on, to another address -- Tomtegaden, No. 11.

The driver becomes complicit in the fantasy. He asks about the man's appearance. The narrator agrees with every suggestion: yes, a light morning-coat. Yes, red hair. Yes, a knobbed stick. Kierulf accrues detail like a character in a story being written in real time, assembled from the driver's guesses and the narrator's enthusiastic confirmations. The passage has the logic of a dream or an improvised fiction -- each new detail breeds the next, and the character solidifies even as his non-existence is confirmed by every locked door and bewildered servant.

Throughout the ride, the narrator is aware that he is losing control: "Madness rages through my brain, and I let it rage. I am fully conscious that I am succumbing to influences over

which I have no control." This is a crucial formulation. The narrator is not unconscious. He watches himself go mad the way a person watches a fire: fascinated, unable to intervene, aware that the thing he is observing is also the thing that is destroying him.

He notes, with preternatural clarity, a policeman's badge number: "69. This number struck me with such vivid clearness that it penetrated like a splint into my brain--69--accurately 69." The detail is absurd and precise and true to the psychology of dissociation. In states of extreme stress, the mind often fixes on arbitrary details with hallucinatory intensity while losing track of larger contexts. The badge number burns itself into memory. The cab ride, the invented Kierulf, the maid at the door -- these dissolve into confusion. But 69 remains, like a splinter.

At Tomtegaden, No. 11, the narrator alights, walks through a building, and emerges on the other side -- into Vognmansgaden. The passage is described with the calm, almost hypnotic detail of a person moving through a dream: "I find myself in a lobby, a sort of anteroom, with two windows. There are two boxes in it, one on top of the other, in one corner, and against the wall an old, painted sofa-bed over which a rug is spread." He crosses the building and looks up at the sign: "Refreshment and lodgings for travellers."

He has abandoned the cab. He has stiffed the driver. And yet Hamsun insists: "It is not my intention to escape, to steal away from the driver who is waiting for me. I go very coolly down Vognmangsgaden, without fear of being conscious of doing any wrong." The narrator does not experience his actions as flight. He simply walks through a building and out the other side, and the cab, the driver, and the invented Kierulf fall away like details from a story he has stopped writing. The phrase "Kierulf, this dealer in wool, who has spooked in my brain so long -- this creature in whose existence I believe, and whom it was of vital importance that I should meet -- had vanished from my memory; was wiped out with many other mad whims which came and went in turns."

The word "spooked" is perfect. Kierulf is a ghost -- a phantom generated by the narrator's starving brain, given a name, a trade, a red beard, a knobbed stick, and then dismissed. He joins the novel's population of half-real figures: the woman in black before she became Ylajali, the pastor the narrator pretended to be, the fiancée who does not exist. Part III is crowded with people who are both real and invented, present and absent, and the narrator moves among them like a man who can no longer reliably distinguish between the world and his narration of it.

The Body Cataloged

The narrator reaches Gronland and sits on a seat near the church. What follows is the novel's most sustained act of physical self-inspection:

I had become so strangely poverty-stricken and broken, a mere shadow of what I once had been; my shoulders were sunken right down on one side, and I had contracted a habit of stooping forward fearfully as I walked, in order to spare my chest what little I could.

The asymmetry of the shoulders is a striking detail. Starvation is not symmetrical. It erodes the body unevenly, following the contours of individual physiology. One shoulder drops. The gait becomes lopsided. The body lists to one side like a building whose foundation has shifted.

Then the shirt:

I had worn the same shirt for many weeks, and it was quite stiff with stale sweat, and had chafed my skin. A little blood and water ran out of the sore place; it did not hurt much, but it was very tiresome to have this tender place in the middle of my stomach.

The understatement of "very tiresome" in reference to an open wound on his stomach is characteristic. The narrator has calibrated his language to match his diminished expectations. What would be alarming to a healthy person is merely tiresome to him. The wound does not hurt much. The blood and water are minor. He washes it, dries it, puts the same shirt back on. "There was no help for it." The phrase recurs throughout Part III like a refrain, each repetition lowering the bar for what counts as acceptable misery.

And then the self-loathing reaches its nadir:

My very hands seem distasteful to me; the loose, almost coarse, expression of the backs of them pains me, disgusts me. I feel myself rudely affected by the sight of my lean fingers. I hate the whole of my gaunt, shrunken body, and shrink from bearing it, from feeling it envelop me.

The word "expression" applied to the backs of his hands is extraordinary. Hands have expressions the way faces do -- they communicate age, labor, health, character. The narrator reads his own hands the way one reads a stranger's face, and what he reads there disgusts him. His body has become a foreign object, something that "envelops" him rather than something he inhabits. The alienation from the self is

complete. He is a consciousness trapped inside a deteriorating casing, and he wants out: "Lord, if the whole thing would come to an end now, I would heartily, gladly die!"

The Confession to the Shop-Boy

The narrator, having given away the stolen money and examined his ruined body, decides to confess. He approaches the provision shop "with the half-conscious feeling of approaching a danger." He enters. He and the shop-boy stand face to face.

The boy says, "Fearfully bad weather now, isn't it?" The narrator explodes: "Oh, I haven't come to prate about the weather."

What follows is one of the most perverse scenes in the novel. The narrator confesses to a crime the victim has not noticed. The shop-boy has no suspicion, no misgiving. The narrator has to explain the theft to him -- "I abuse him, explain to him every detail" -- and even then, the boy's response is mild: "It was a mean enough thing of you to do!" The narrator contradicts even this: it was not so mean, he says, because he gave the money to a poor old woman. The boy suggests he should have returned the money to the shop. The narrator is outraged by the suggestion.

The scene is a confession that produces no absolution because the confessor -- the shop-boy -- does not have the authority or the interest to absolve. The narrator wants to be caught, punished, judged. He wants the external structure of moral accountability that would relieve him of the burden of self-judgment. But the boy just wants him to leave. The master is in the next room. Voices carry. The shop-boy's terror is not moral but professional: he fears for his job.

The narrator leaves "slamming the door behind me" and goes home, where he instantly collapses: "I regretted my attack upon the poor shop-boy, wept, clutched myself by the throat to punish myself for my miserable trick, and behaved like a lunatic." The self-punishment is literal. He clutches his own throat. The gesture recapitulates the novel's central action: the self turning on the self, the body attacking the body. He has bullied a frightened boy, made a spectacle of his own guilt, and achieved nothing. The confession has not restored his honor. It has only demonstrated that his need for moral theater is stronger than his capacity for moral action.

Then comes one of the novel's most quietly devastating passages of remorse:

He had naturally been in the most deadly terror for the sake of his situation; he had not dared to make any fuss about the five shillings that were lost to the business, and I had taken advantage of his fear.

The narrator, for the first time, sees the encounter from the other person's perspective. The shop-boy was not morally apathetic. He was afraid -- afraid of his employer, afraid of the scene, afraid of what would happen if the master came out from the inner room. The narrator's confession, far from being an act of honesty, was an act of cruelty: it forced a frightened employee to participate in a drama that served only the narrator's need for self-punishment. The recognition is genuine and useless. He sees what he has done, and seeing changes nothing.

The Writing That Will Not Come

Interspersed through Part III are scenes of the narrator trying to write, and in each one, the writing moves further away from him. The morning after the confession, he sits up in bed "as soon as it got light, and set to work at the essay once more. I sat thus till noon; I had succeeded by then in getting ten, perhaps twenty lines down, and still I had not found an ending."

Then comes a passage of disintegration rendered with terrifying precision:

I hustled about the room, took aimless turns to and fro, scratched the wall with my nail, leant my head carefully against the door for a while, tapped with my forefinger on the floor, and then listened attentively, all without any object, but quietly and pensively as if it were some matter of importance in which I was engaged.

The actions are minute, purposeless, and described as though they matter. He scratches the wall. He taps the floor. He leans his head against the door. Each action is performed "quietly and pensively," with the seriousness of ritual. The narrator has lost the ability to distinguish between purposeful action and random movement. Everything feels like work; nothing is work.

"But, great God, surely this is madness!" he says -- and then keeps doing it. The recognition does not produce change. It coexists with the behavior it identifies. He knows he is going mad and cannot stop. This is one of the novel's deepest insights into the experience of mental extremity: awareness and helplessness are not opposites. You can watch yourself disintegrate and be unable to intervene.

He finds "a splinter to chew" and forces himself back to the page. A few more sentences come, "a score of poor words which I tortured forth with might and main." Then nothing. He stares at the letters on the page until they become alien:

I set myself to gaze with wide open eyes at these last words, this unfinished sheet of paper; I stared at these strange, shaky letters that bristled up from the paper like small hairy creeping things, till at last I could neither make head nor tail of any of it.

The letters have become insects -- "small hairy creeping things." The defamiliarization is complete. Writing, the activity that defines the narrator, that gives him his identity and his only means of survival, has become a collection of meaningless marks on a page. He can no longer read his own hand. Language has failed from the inside out.

The Bitten Finger

In the extremity of his paralysis, the narrator makes one of the novel's most startling gestures:

At length I stuck my forefinger in my mouth, and took to sucking it. Something stirred in my brain, a thought that bored its way in there--a stark-mad notion. Supposing I were to take a bite? And without a moment's reflection, I shut my eyes, and clenched my teeth on it.

He bites his own finger hard enough to draw blood. "I sprang up. At last I was thoroughly awake." The act is one of self-inflicted pain as a means of returning to consciousness. The body, which has been failing him, which has become a source of disgust and alienation, is suddenly useful again: it can produce sensation, and sensation can wake him from the stupor that starvation and despair have induced.

There is a savage logic here. The narrator's body cannot be fed. His writing cannot be finished. His mind drifts into madness. But he can bite his own finger. He can produce pain. And pain, unlike food or art, is still within his power to generate. The bite is an act of authorship -- the only kind he can still accomplish. He writes on his own body with his own teeth.

The aftermath is tender: "This poor thin finger looked so utterly pitiable. God in Heaven! what a pass it had come to now with me!" He cries, but the tears are gentle -- not the racking sobs of earlier scenes. He wraps the finger in a rag, and the practical act of self-care seems to steady him. The

blood and the tears and the bandage form a small domestic ritual, a moment of self-kindness in the midst of self-destruction.

The Woman in the Shop and the Candle at Last

Still needing a candle, the narrator goes to the provision shop again -- a different visit this time, without the confusion of the earlier theft. He resolves to ask for credit. He brushes his clothes, removes loose hairs from his collar, and descends the stairs. "When I got outside in the street it occurred to me that I might perhaps rather ask for a loaf." But he overrules himself: "I was unfortunately not in a condition to bear food." The stomach that cannot hold food does not want food. It wants a candle -- the tool of production, the means of finishing the essay that will earn the money that will buy the food. The calculus is clear and deranged: art before bread, always.

In the shop, the familiar scene plays out again. The shopman wraps a loaf automatically. The narrator corrects him: "No, thank you, it was really a candle I wanted this evening." This time the exchange is clean, without theft. But it echoes the earlier visit, and the echo is painful. The same shop, the same counter, the same boy -- but the narrator is changed. He has been a thief in this room. He has confessed

in this room. Now he is simply a man asking for a candle, and the ordinariness of the transaction carries all the weight of what has happened before.

Ylajali Returns: The Fourth Appearance

After buying the candle and milk, the narrator approaches his door and sees the woman in black again for the fourth time. This is the scene of their first real conversation, covered above. But it is worth noting the structural function of her appearances. She has been standing at the lamppost four times before the narrator speaks to her. Each appearance is identical -- same dress, same veil, same position. The repetition has the quality of a motif in music, a figure that recurs until it finally resolves. And the resolution, when it comes, is swift: he approaches her, they walk, they talk, she kisses him, the door shuts.

The four appearances also mark the narrator's changing relationship to desire. The first time, he notices her but is too poor to act. The second time, he is "possessed by the unreasonable feeling" that she has come for him. The third time, he is "almost on the point of addressing her." The fourth time, he does. The approach is gradual, and each stage is linked to a corresponding stage of physical decline. By the

time he speaks to her, he has been through the rejection by the editor, the theft, the vomiting, the hot milk. He approaches love from the far side of ruin.

The Delirium

After the kiss, the narrator lies in bed and thinks of Ylajali. The thought produces a vision that escalates from tenderness to apocalypse:

And light forces its way ever so faintly into my spirit again--a little ray of sunshine that makes me so blessedly warm; and gradually more sun comes, a rare, silken, balmy light that caresses me with soothing loveliness. And the sun grows stronger and stronger, burns sharply in my temples, seethes fiercely and glowingly in my emaciated brain.

The passage begins as a love-lyric -- sunshine, warmth, silk, caresses -- and then the temperature rises beyond endurance. The sun that was "blessedly warm" becomes a fire that "burns sharply in my temples." The imagery shifts from romantic to infernal: "a maddening pyre of rays flames up before my eyes; a heaven and earth in conflagration men and beasts of fire, mountains of fire, devils of fire, an abyss, a wilderness, a hurricane, a universe in brazen ignition."

This is the narrator's most extreme hallucination, triggered not by despair but by joy. The thought of Ylajali -- of love, of human connection -- overloads a system that has been running on nothing. The brain that cannot produce an ending for an essay on Correggio can produce a vision of cosmic destruction. The imagination, starved of fuel, does not weaken. It goes haywire. It produces too much, not too little, and the excess is indistinguishable from madness.

"And I saw and heard no more...." The section ends in ellipsis, in the silence after the conflagration. The narrator has blacked out. Whether this is fever, hallucination, or a petit mal seizure is unclear. Hamsun does not diagnose. He describes.

After the Fever

The second horizontal rule. A new section opens with the narrator waking in sweat:

I woke in a sweat the next morning, moist all over, my whole body bathed in dampness. The fever had laid violent hands on me.

Everything is reversed. He looks at his arms, his legs, and does not recognize them. The window seems to be in the wrong wall. Sounds come from the wrong direction. "I could hear the tramp of the horses' feet in the yard below as if it

came from above me." The spatial disorientation is classic post-febrile confusion, rendered with Hamsun's usual specificity. The narrator is not vaguely confused. He is confused about precise things -- the location of the window, the direction of sound. The specificity makes the disorientation more disturbing, not less.

His feet have swollen in his shoes overnight. "I could not move my toes much, they were too stiff." He gets up in the afternoon and moves carefully about the room, "taking care to keep my balance and spare my feet as much as possible." And then this sentence, which carries an enormous tonal surprise: "On the contrary, I was blissfully content."

The contentment is not ironic. The narrator has passed through the worst of the fever and emerged into a state of strange calm, the physiological peace that follows extreme crisis. The body, having convulsed, is briefly quiet. The mind, having hallucinated, is briefly clear. "It did not strike me just then that anything could be otherwise than it was." This is acceptance, of a kind -- not the acceptance of wisdom but the acceptance of exhaustion, the moment after the storm when the air is empty and still.

The Bread Van

He goes out. The hunger returns -- "a shameless appetite" that "gnawed unmercifully in my breast." Hamsun gives it a strange, beautiful description: "It was as if a score of diminutive gnome-like insects set their heads on one side and gnawed for a little, then laid their heads on the other side and gnawed a little more, then lay quite still for a moment's space, and then began afresh." The image is almost playful -- tiny gnomes with tilting heads -- and its playfulness makes the pain more vivid than anguished language would. The narrator is describing hunger as if it were a curiosity, an interesting phenomenon happening inside him.

At the corner of the market, a bread-van nearly runs him down. "A monster of a bread-van brushes past me, and the wheel grazes my coat." His toes are crushed. His shoe is torn. The incident is described with the narrator's characteristic mixture of precision and deflection: "it might have been worse, far worse"; "it was perhaps not so dangerous"; "I didn't think any bones were broken." Each reassurance diminishes the injury, normalizes it, absorbs it into the general background of suffering that has become the narrator's constant state.

There is a significant detail: the van carries bread. Of all the vehicles in Christiania, the one that strikes the narrator is loaded with the one thing he needs and cannot get. The irony is not heavy-handed -- Hamsun does not pause to underline it -- but it is there, structural and quiet. The narrator forgives the driver instantly: "It was quite certain that if I had begged him for a piece of bread out of his cart he would have given it to me." Bread was available. He did not ask. The willingness to forgive the driver is also, implicitly, a refusal to ask for what the driver could have given.

The Bone

Desperate, the narrator goes to a meat bazaar beneath the Town Hall. He calls up the archway "as if I were talking to a dog up there" -- an invented dog, a prop in a little performance -- and asks a butcher for a bone "for my dog." He receives it, hides it under his coat, thanks the man too heartily, and retreats to a dark passage near the forges.

There was no light to be seen anywhere, only blessed darkness all around me; and I began to gnaw at the bone.

The word "blessed" arrests the reading. Darkness is blessed because it hides him. In a novel where the narrator is constantly managing his visibility -- turning aside to hide the missing waistcoat, sitting in the dark corner of the restaurant,

avoiding the Tivoli's lights -- this moment of hidden gnawing is the logical extreme. He is an animal in a den, invisible, eating a bone. Every pretension of writerly identity, of pastoral authority, of romantic worthiness, is stripped away. He is hunger itself, crouched in the dark.

The bone makes him vomit. He tries again. He vomits again. He bites into the meat, forces it down, and it comes back up:

I grew wild, bit angrily into the meat, tore off a morsel, and gulped it down by sheer strength of will; and yet it was of no use. Just as soon as the little fragments of meat became warm in my stomach up they came again, worse luck.

The phrase "by sheer strength of will" is significant. The narrator approaches eating the way he approaches writing -- as an act of will, a contest between intention and material resistance. The essay will not be finished because the words will not come. The bone will not be digested because the stomach will not hold. In both cases, will is insufficient. The body has its own logic, and that logic is refusal.

"I cried, so that the bone got wet and dirty with my tears, vomited, cursed and groaned again, cried as if my heart would break, and vomited anew." The sentence is almost

unbearable in its inventory of simultaneous actions -- crying, vomiting, cursing, groaning -- all happening at once, the body in total revolt against itself. The bone gets "wet and dirty" with tears, which is a detail of such object specificity that it can only come from lived experience or from an imagination so fierce that it amounts to the same thing. Finally he throws the bone at the door. The gesture is violent, final -- not a discarding but an act of rage. He throws it the way a man throws a gauntlet. The bone clatters against the wood and lies still, and the narrator is left with nothing.

The Curse Against God

What follows is the novel's most sustained rhetorical set-piece -- a curse against God that runs for nearly a full page. It begins: "I tell you, you Heaven's Holy Baal, you don't exist; but that, if you did, I would curse you so that your Heaven would quiver with the fire of hell!"

The logical structure of the curse is worth attending to. The narrator begins by denying God's existence, then immediately proceeds to address God directly. If God does not exist, there is no one to curse. But the narrator curses anyway, and the cursing implies the existence it denies. The

passage is not an atheist's manifesto. It is a believer's rage -- the fury of someone who feels abandoned by a power he cannot stop believing in.

The language draws on biblical cadence -- "your time of visitation," "a bondsman in hell," "a freedman in your mansions" -- and on the rhetoric of prophetic denunciation. "I tell you" repeats like a hammer blow, twelve times in rapid succession. The repetition has the quality of incantation, of prayer inverted. Each "I tell you" begins a new charge against God: that he has filled heaven with idiots, that he has used force against the narrator, that every cell in the narrator's body "gasps to mock you."

The curse ends with a formal farewell: "I bid you farewell, for all time and eternity--I bid you farewell with heart and reins. I bid you the last irrevocable farewell, and I am silent, and turn my back on you and go my way.... Quiet."

The word "Quiet" lands like a door closing. After the rhetorical storm, silence. The narrator stands in the passage, "still whispering oaths and abusive epithets, hiccoughing after the violent crying fit, broken down and apathetic." The hiccoughs are a devastatingly physical detail. The body reduces cosmic fury to a spasm of the diaphragm. The narrator has cursed the Almighty, and what remains is a hiccough.

It is worth noting that this curse is delivered not in a church, not on a mountaintop, not in any setting that would dignify its rhetoric. It is delivered in a dark passage near a butcher's stall, beside a bone smeared with tears and vomit. The grandeur of the language and the squalor of the setting are in deliberate tension, and the tension produces the scene's peculiar power. The narrator's eloquence has not failed him -- even now, at the absolute bottom, his sentences are magnificent. What has failed is everything else.

After the Curse: Urban Planning and Pocket Money

In one of Hamsun's most audacious tonal shifts, the narrator emerges from his curse against God and begins thinking about urban planning:

It occurs to me that the wretched hovels down at the corner of the market-place, the stores for loose materials, the old booths for second-hand clothes, were really a disgrace to the place--they spoilt the whole appearance of the market, and were a blot on the town.

He calculates the cost of moving the Geographical Survey building: "two or three hundred pounds. A pretty sum -- three hundred pounds! One must admit, a tidy enough little sum for pocket-money!" The absurdity is total. A man who has just

cursed God over a bone he could not keep down is now speculating about municipal budgets. But the absurdity is also deeply true to the experience of extremity. The mind, having exhausted one register, does not fall silent. It jumps to another, often a wildly inappropriate one. Grief becomes arithmetic. Rage becomes civic planning. The non sequitur is the brain's way of surviving itself.

The narrator knows he is dying: "I had a feeling that there was not much life left in me -- that I was really singing my last verse." And yet the thought does not produce despair. "It was almost a matter of indifference to me; it did not trouble me in the least." He has reached a plateau beyond both hope and despair, a place where the question of survival has become, temporarily, abstract. He wanders toward the railway wharf.

The Nun Has Sailed

At the wharf, the narrator asks a lame man about the Nun. She has sailed. The escape route named in the opening paragraph is gone. The ship that was supposed to be his backup plan, his insurance against the failure of writing, has left without him.

The conversation with the lame man is a little gem of Hamsun's comic method. The narrator asks about the ship, then interrupts himself to ask how far it is to Holmestrand, then interrupts again to ask about Voeblungsnaess, then interrupts a third time to ask for tobacco. The lame man cannot finish a sentence. The narrator's mind is racing from subject to subject, unable to settle, and the conversation becomes a catalog of abandoned questions.

Then the word "Binder." The narrator says it to the man for no apparent reason: "Binder" -- "only this one word." He stares at the man. He walks away. He stops and says it again: "Binder!" He has remembered that this is the pawnbroker he visited earlier in the novel, "one bright morning up in Graendsen, when I pawned my waistcoat." The connection surfaces involuntarily, a memory that arrives not as a thought but as a word, spoken aloud before it is understood. The lame man is a landmark in the narrator's geography of humiliation -- a face associated with the loss of the waistcoat, the garment whose absence has haunted all of Part III.

The Commandor at the Wharf

Then, by accident, the narrator encounters the editor again. The scene is handled briefly in the companion essay's discussion of the narrator's reversal from concealment to display. Here I want to focus on what happens after the money changes hands.

The editor gives him half-a-sovereign and says, "I know you can write for it." The line is crucial. It is not charity. It is an advance -- money given in exchange for future work. The editor is restoring the narrator to a professional relationship, offering him the dignity of obligation rather than the humiliation of a gift. And the narrator, this time, takes it.

But he cannot thank the man. His legs fail. His voice is too weak. The editor walks away toward the train. The narrator tries to follow, cannot keep up, tries to call out, cannot be heard:

I was left standing on the pavement, gazing after him. I wept quietly and silently. "I never saw the like!" I said to myself. "He gave me half-a-sovereign."

The repetition of the fact -- "he gave me half-a-sovereign" -- has the quality of a person repeating something they cannot believe. He walks back to where the editor stood. He imitates

"all his movements." He holds the coin up to his "moistened eyes" and inspects it "on both sides." He swears "at the top of my voice" that it is real.

The scene is one of the most quietly devastating in the novel. A man who has cursed God cannot find words to thank another man. A man who has delivered rhetorical set-pieces of extraordinary power is too weak to call out across a platform. The distance between what the narrator can compose in his head and what he can accomplish in the world has never been wider.

He ends up, singularly enough, at Tomtegaden, No. 11 -- the same building he walked through during the Kierulf episode. This time he enters and asks for a bed. "Refreshment and lodgings for travellers." The building that was a passageway during his madness becomes a shelter during his recovery. The same space serves different functions depending on the narrator's state of mind, which is Hamsun's way of showing that the city itself is not fixed. It changes as the perceiver changes.

Tuesday: The Bright Day

The third section of Part III opens with a change in weather and spirit that is almost violent in its optimism:

Tuesday. Sunshine and quiet--a strangely bright day. The snow had disappeared. There was life and joy, and glad faces, smiles, and laughter everywhere. The fountains threw up sprays of water in jets, golden-tinted from the sun-light, azure from the sky....

The prose is effervescent. The sentences are short. The colors are warm. After dozens of pages of cold, darkness, vomiting, and despair, the sun comes out, and the narrator rises to meet it. He leaves his lodgings at noon, wanders the streets "in the merriest humour," and before seven o'clock is already circling St. Olav's Place, looking up at the windows of No. 2.

The anticipation is rendered with a precision that borders on the obsessive. He plans his greeting: should he say "Good-evening" or only smile? He decides on the smile. He calculates his timing: the clocks strike eight, he walks toward the square, he worries about arriving late, he quickens his pace. His foot is sore but "otherwise nothing ailed me." The qualification is almost funny -- a man who has been starving, feverish, and nearly run over qualifies his condition as "nothing ailed me" because his foot hurts.

He waits at the fountain. She does not come from the direction he expects. She comes from behind him. "'Hem!' came from behind me." The single syllable is perfectly placed. He hears her before he sees her, and the sound -- that small,

throat-clearing "Hem!" -- is her announcement of presence, a sound so slight that only a man who has been listening for it would hear.

In the Apartment

They walk together. She has accompanied her mother somewhere; the servant has the evening off. She is alone. He suggests going up to her apartment -- "I shall sit down at the door the whole time if you like" -- and immediately regrets the suggestion: "I trembled with emotion, and regretted greatly that I had perhaps been too forward." The offer to sit by the door is an attempt to make himself as small as possible, to minimize the imposition of his presence. It is also, of course, an invitation to be corrected, and she corrects it beautifully: "You shall certainly not sit down by the door." Hamsun then adds: "She says it right down tenderly, and says accurately these words." The narrator transcribes her tenderness with the precision of a court reporter. He wants to record not only what she said but how she said it, as though the tenderness itself were evidence that must be preserved.

"We went up." Two words, a new paragraph. They go up the stairs, into the dark lobby, where she takes his hand and leads him. There is "no necessity for my being so quiet," she tells him. The instruction is both practical (she wants

conversation) and emotional (his silence frightens her). The narrator's quietness is not shyness. It is the stillness of a man so overwhelmed by the gap between what is happening and what he deserves that speech itself seems presumptuous.

The apartment scene is the longest sustained interaction between two characters in the novel, and it is Hamsun's most complex rendering of intimacy. The initial moments are playful: she lights a candle -- "it was not a lamp she lit, but a candle" -- and Hamsun specifies the light source because it matters. A candle is intimate, flickering, partial. It does not illuminate a room; it illuminates a face. It can be extinguished with a breath. She laughs about having kissed him, says she will never do it again. He reaches for her; she slips away. They chase each other around a table. He trips on the carpet -- his sore foot gives way -- and falls. She laughs. He gets up. They chase again.

The playfulness has a nervous edge. Both of them are performing lightness to avoid the weight of what is actually happening: a starving, half-mad writer is alone with a young woman in a darkened apartment, and the distance between their situations is enormous. She does not know what he is. He is terrified she will find out.

She notices his limp. "Last time you had a sore finger, now you have got a sore foot; it is awful the number of afflictions you have." The observation is both tender and diagnostic -- she is cataloging his injuries, building a picture of a man who is perpetually damaged. She assumes he was tipsy -- "Run over! Tipsy again? Why, good heavens! what a life you lead, young man!" The word "young man" is significant. She sees youth in him, vitality, possibility. She does not see what we see: a body that is failing, a mind at the edge of its endurance. Her assumption -- drunkenness -- is her way of making sense of him: he is a young man who drinks too much, a familiar type, manageable. The truth -- that he was hit by a bread-van while staggering from hunger and malnutrition in the middle of a market -- is not a type at all. It is something she has no framework for.

She orders him into a chair, tells him to put his arm over the back of hers, scolds his reticence. Her monologue is a tour de force -- rapid, teasing, commanding. "One has to say and do everything oneself; one gets no help to do anything." She is directing the scene, assigning him his role, trying to coax from him the boldness she sensed when he followed her through the streets. She does not yet know that the boldness was hunger-madness, not confidence.

He tells her she is a darling. He says he is "desperately in love." The word "desperately" carries its full weight -- this is not the hyperbole of courtship but the literal desperation of a man who has nothing else. He asks her name. She asks his. He offers "Ylajali" as the name he gave her. "Is that a foreign language?" she asks. "Humph -- no, it isn't that either!" The exchange is delicate and funny, and underneath it is the narrator's awareness that the name he invented for her is more real to him than whatever name she actually bears. Ylajali is the name of his desire, not of her person, and the gap between the two -- between what he wants her to be and what she is -- will widen as the evening continues.

They tell each other their real names -- or rather, Hamsun tells us they do, without revealing what those names are. "After a long discussion we told one another our names." The withholding is significant. Throughout the novel, the narrator's name is never given. (We learn only his surname -- Tangen -- in a passing legal fantasy.) Ylajali's real name is likewise withheld from the reader. We are kept at the same distance from both of them that they are, at this moment, trying to close with each other. The exchange of names is the most intimate thing two strangers can do -- the giving of one's actual identity, the name one's mother used -- and Hamsun declines to let us hear it. The privacy of the moment is preserved. Some things belong only to the characters.

The Confession

The moment of crisis arrives through an intimate physical detail. They are close together on the sofa. She strokes his shoulders and says, "What a lot of loose hair there is." The sentence is the most dangerous one in Part III. She has touched him, and her touch has discovered the evidence of what he is. The loose hair -- the same hair that fell in clumps on his pillow, that he brushed from his collar before going out -- now clings to her hand. She asks why it falls out. She assumes dissipation -- "because you drink too much." He could let her believe this. The story of a dissolute young man is one she can handle; the story of a starving one is not. But he tells the truth. He tells her everything.

I related--related all--and I only related truth. I made out nothing any worse than it was; it was not my intention to rouse her compassion. I told her also that I had stolen five shillings one evening.

The passage is extraordinary for what it does not contain: the actual content of his confession. Hamsun skips over the telling entirely. We do not hear what words the narrator uses, how he describes the starvation, the bone, the theft. We see only its effect on Ylajali: "She sat and listened, with open mouth, pale, frightened, her shining eyes completely bewildered."

The omission is deliberate. We have lived through the events. We do not need to hear them retold. What we need is to see the impact of the retelling on someone who has not lived through them -- someone for whom these are new facts, shocking facts, facts that rewrite the person she thought she was sitting beside. Her repeated "the Lord preserve me" is the sound of comprehension arriving, each repetition marking a new layer of understanding, a new depth of horror.

The narrator tries to recover the situation: "Well, it is all over now! ... I am saved now...." But the damage is done. She says the words that will haunt the rest of the evening: "I can't be sure that you are not insane."

The Extinguished Candle

The word "insane" detonates inside the narrator. He protests. She presses: the morning he followed her, he was not tipsy. "No; but I wasn't hungry then, either; I had just eaten...." The logic is desperate: he was not drunk, but he had just eaten, so his behavior must have been normal. She replies, devastatingly: "Yes; but that made it so much the worse."

The narrator, "as if inadvertently," knocks over the candle. The room goes dark. She struggles. She whispers: "No, not that! If you like, you may rather kiss me, oh, dear, kind...."

The passage is the most morally fraught moment in Part III. The narrator has extinguished the light. The woman is frightened. She offers a kiss as a substitute for what she fears he wants. "She meant to offer me a compensation by giving me leave to kiss her," the narrator realizes. "How charming, how charmingly naive." He stops immediately. He is "struck to the heart."

Hamsun handles this scene with extraordinary care. The narrator's aggression is real. His retreat is equally real. He is capable of frightening this woman, and he is capable of being ashamed of having frightened her. The two capacities coexist. He is not a predator who performs decency, nor a decent man who momentarily lapses. He is both things simultaneously, and Part III's great achievement is its refusal to resolve the contradiction.

She relights the candle "with trembling hands." He leans back on the sofa. She looks at the clock and says the servant will be home soon. The evening is over.

The Monologue at the Door

What follows is one of the most remarkable passages in nineteenth-century fiction. The narrator stands at the door, preparing to leave, and delivers a monologue that is simultaneously a plea, a defense, a confession, and a

breakdown. The companion essay "The Theater of Starvation" discusses the passage's theatrical quality -- the narrator performing sanity by describing his own stillness. Here I want to attend to its rhythm and its rhetorical structure.

The monologue begins with a question: "Was your father in the army?" -- a transparently deflectionary gambit, an attempt to prolong the conversation. Then it modulates into a lecture on sensitivity: "There were natures that fed on trifles, and died just for one hard word's sake." The narrator is defending himself by constructing a theory of temperament: he is not mad, he is sensitive. Poverty has "sharpened certain powers in me." The poor man is "a far nicer observer than the rich intelligent man." The argument is cogent, even persuasive -- and its very cogency is a form of desperation. A man standing at a door, arguing for his sanity, is not in a strong position.

Ylajali grows more troubled. She murmurs "My God!" and wrings her hands. The narrator sees that he is tormenting her and cannot stop. The monologue accelerates:

"Now I am going, now I am going. Can't you see that I already have my hand on the handle of the door?"

He announces his departure without departing. He reaches for the door without opening it. The monologue continues for another full page from this position -- hand on the handle, body half-turned -- in a state of suspended exit that mirrors the novel's larger structure: the narrator is always about to leave, about to escape, about to take passage on the Nun, and he never does.

He asks to kneel before her. He specifies the spot: "over there on the crimson rose in the carpet." The specificity is haunting. In the middle of an emotional crisis, the narrator identifies a particular flower in a carpet pattern. The detail is both mad and deeply sane -- it is the precision of a man who notices everything, who cannot stop observing even when observation is beside the point. The crimson rose is both a real piece of carpet and a symbol of everything he wants and cannot reach: beauty, warmth, a place to kneel, a place to be accepted.

He insists he does not point: "I don't even point with my finger. I don't point at all; I let it be, not to frighten you. I only nod and look over at it, like this." The narrator is describing his own restraint with the precision of stage directions. He is directing a scene in which his stillness is the action. The passage reads like a text by Beckett -- a monologue about not moving, delivered by a man who cannot leave.

He veers into explanation: "It was once in the summer, a long time ago, I was mad; I worked too hard, and forgot to go to dine at the right hour." The madness he concedes is safely in the past, attributed to overwork, which is a respectable cause. He insists he can get credit at good restaurants. He had money and simply forgot to eat. The excuses are transparent, and their transparency is part of their power. We can see through them, and so can Ylajali, and so, at some level, can the narrator. But he cannot stop making them.

The Embrace and the Exit

She comes to him. She stretches out her hand. He looks at her with mistrust. She puts her arms around his neck. "She had tears in her eyes; I only stood and looked at her." The verb "stood" carries enormous weight. He does not embrace her. He does not move. He stands and is embraced, passive, mistrustful, unable to believe in the gesture.

She said something; it sounded to me like, "I am fond of you, in spite of all." She said it very lowly and indistinctly; maybe I did not hear aright.

"In spite of all." The phrase contains the entire evening -- the confession, the fear, the extinguished candle, the monologue, the accusation of insanity. She is fond of him in spite of

everything she has learned, which means her fondness is not based on what she knows about him but on something prior to knowledge, something that persists despite the evidence. Whether this is love or pity or mere impulse, the narrator cannot tell. "She may not have said just those words." He is not sure he heard her. The most important sentence of the evening may or may not have been spoken.

She presses against him, stretches up on tiptoe "to get a good hold," and stays for "perhaps a whole minute." The narrator, "afraid that she was forcing herself to show me this tenderness," says only: "What a darling you are now!"

Then the exit:

More I didn't say. I crushed her in my arms, stepped back, rushed to the door, and went out backwards.

"Went out backwards." Part III ends with this image: a man leaving a room without turning away, facing the woman he is leaving, retreating rather than departing. The gesture is the physical embodiment of the narrator's entire predicament in Part III. He cannot stay. He cannot cleanly go. He exits facing what he is losing, his eyes on her as the distance between them widens, unable to turn his back on the one thing -- the one person -- who has offered him something he cannot accept.

There is a theatrical tradition behind this exit. In courtly protocol, one does not turn one's back on a sovereign. One retreats backwards, maintaining the face-to-face orientation that respect demands. The narrator's backward exit is, in this sense, an act of reverence -- Ylajali as queen, the apartment as throne room, the departure as an obeisance so deep that it includes the refusal to turn away. But it is also an act of fear. Turning one's back means trusting that the person behind you will still be there when you turn around. The narrator does not trust this. He keeps his eyes on her because he believes -- perhaps correctly -- that the moment he looks away, she will be gone. The backward exit is love and terror in a single gesture.

She remains behind. The door closes. And Part III, the longest and most complex section of the novel, ends not with the narrator alone in the cold, not with hunger or madness or God-cursing, but with an act of love that may also be an act of farewell -- an embrace so compressed and intense that it contains, in a single minute, everything the narrator wants and everything he knows he cannot have.

The Architecture of Part III

Looking back over Part III as a whole, its structure becomes visible. It is organized around three encounters with the commandor (the editor) and four encounters with Ylajali (the woman in black), with the narrator's physical and moral decline providing the connective tissue between them.

The first encounter with the commandor is professional: the narrator submits work, is rejected, refuses an advance. The second encounter is accidental: the narrator meets him at the railway wharf and receives the half-sovereign. In each case, the commandor offers help, and the narrator's response is determined by his current state of desperation. When he still has the energy to perform self-sufficiency, he refuses. When he is too broken to perform, he accepts.

The four encounters with Ylajali follow a different arc. The first three are sightings -- the woman at the lamppost, observed but not approached. The fourth is the conversation, the walk, the kiss. Then comes the apartment scene on Tuesday evening. The arc is one of increasing intimacy and increasing exposure. Each meeting strips away another layer of the narrator's disguise until, in the apartment, he is fully revealed: a starving man with falling hair and stolen money and a sore foot, standing before a woman who may or may not love him, asking to kneel on a crimson rose in the carpet.

Between these encounters, the narrator cycles through the novel's recurring motifs: the search for a candle, the attempt to write, the theft and its confession, the vomiting, the encounter with the prostitute, the cab ride to a fictional address, the bone in the dark passage, the curse against God. Each motif is a variation on the same theme: the narrator's need to act in the world exceeds his capacity to act, and the gap between need and capacity is filled by language -- lies, fantasies, prayers, curses, monologues, invented names.

Part III is the novel's longest section, and it earns its length. The narrative does not merely continue the trajectory of Parts I and II. It deepens it. The hunger that was primarily physical in Part I and increasingly psychological in Part II becomes, in Part III, a total condition -- physical, psychological, moral, spiritual. The narrator is hungry for food, for love, for recognition, for meaning, for God, for a candle, for a waistcoat, for the right words to end his essay. Every desire is a form of hunger, and every hunger produces the same cycle of craving, grasping, failing, and performing the failure as something else.

The narrative voice that sustains all of this is one of the great achievements of nineteenth-century fiction. It is not confessional in the Dostoevskian sense -- there is no reader being addressed, no underground audience. It is not stream-

of-consciousness in the Joycean sense -- the syntax remains coherent, the sentences hold their shape. It is something in between: a voice that thinks aloud, that observes itself thinking, that comments on its own observations, and that maintains, even at its most desperate, a precision of language that is the narrator's last remaining possession. He has lost his waistcoat, his hair, his ability to digest food, and his capacity for sustained work. But he has not lost his sentences. They remain beautiful, shapely, exact. And the contrast between the beauty of the sentences and the squalor of the life they describe is Part III's deepest source of power.

Part III ends, and the narrator has not resolved anything. He has not finished his essay. He has not established a relationship with Ylajali. He has not secured his livelihood. He has survived, barely, by the accidental kindness of an editor at a railway station. The Nun has sailed without him. His body is worse than it was. His mind is intact but strained. And the novel has one part left to go -- Part IV, in which everything the narrator has been holding together will finally come apart, or finally let go. The exit from Ylajali's apartment, backwards, facing what he is losing, is the posture in which Part III leaves him: retreating into whatever comes next, unable to turn away from what he has already lost.

After Hunger

A novel can end in triumph or defeat, in marriage or death, in revelation or collapse. *Hunger* ends in none of these. It ends in departure. The narrator signs aboard a ship bound for England, a man with no experience claiming he can do anything. He is bluffing, of course, as he has bluffed his way through the entire book. But this time the bluff works. The captain says he can have a try. And then, in the novel's final paragraph, we get one of the most quietly devastating sentences in modern fiction:

Out in the fjord I dragged myself up once, wet with fever and exhaustion, and gazed landwards, and bade farewell for the present to the town--to Christiania, where the windows gleamed so brightly in all the homes.

That is the whole of the ending. There is no resolution, no lesson, no earned wisdom. There is a sick man on a ship looking back at a city full of lighted windows. The windows gleam in all the homes--all the homes that were never his, all the warmth he stood outside of for the length of the novel. It is an image of belonging seen from the position of

permanent exclusion. The narrator does not overcome hunger. He flees it. He does not find his place in the world. He sails away from the only place he knows.

Compare this to the endings of the other great novels of dislocation. The Great Gatsby closes with boats borne back ceaselessly into the past--a gorgeous, oratorical sweep that turns one man's failure into the condition of American longing itself. The last paragraph of Dubliners finds Gabriel Conroy watching the snow fall "upon all the living and the dead," dissolving boundaries in a universal white silence. Even Beckett's Molloy, for all its radical indeterminacy, ends with the strange calm of a man who has stopped struggling: "I don't know. I don't know." Each of these endings achieves a kind of formal grandeur, a sense that the sentence itself has become large enough to contain more than one life.

Hamsun's ending does something different. It stays small. It stays with the particular. Those gleaming windows are not a metaphor for the human condition. They are windows, in a specific city, seen by a specific man who is running a fever. The power of the sentence lies in its plainness, and in what it does not say. The narrator does not tell us he is heartbroken. He does not tell us he is relieved. He bids farewell "for the present," as if he might come back, as if this were a temporary arrangement. It is the kind of lie people tell themselves when they are leaving forever.

The Mind Betrays Itself

Before the departure, though, comes the scene that might be the true climax of the novel--if a novel this formless can be said to have a climax. It is not a dramatic confrontation or a romantic catastrophe. It is a grocery bill.

The landlady asks the narrator to check her accounts. A simple column of figures: loaves at two and a half pence, a lamp chimney at three, soap, butter. He adds the numbers, finds the total correct, and she asks him to check each line individually. And then he hits it:

Finally, I came to a dead stop at the following entry--"3. 5/16ths of a pound of cheese at 9d." My brain failed me completely; I stared stupidly down at the cheese, and got no farther.

Five-sixteenths of a pound of cheese. Five ounces, the landlady explains--it is simply how Dutch cheese is sold. The narrator claims to understand, tries once more, and cannot do it. The arithmetic is elementary. A child could manage it. But hunger has colonized the last territory he believed secure. His mind, the one instrument he possesses, the faculty on which his identity as a writer depends, has buckled.

What makes the scene so devastating is the narrator's response. He does not weep or rage. He performs. He moves his lips, mutters numbers aloud, slides his finger down the column of figures as though steadily approaching a result. He is acting the part of a man who can think. And the landlady--this practical, pregnant, overworked woman--sees through him at once.

She remarked that perhaps I was not accustomed to reckon in sixteenths; she mentioned also that she must only apply to some one who had a knowledge of sixteenths, to get the account properly revised.

Her tact is more lacerating than cruelty would be. She speaks "not in any hurtful way to make me feel ashamed, but thoughtfully and seriously." She has simply reclassified him. He is no longer a lodger with prospects. He is a man who cannot add. And then, on her way out, the small devastating sentence: "Excuse me for taking up your time then."

The narrator's attempt to recover from this scene is one of the great passages of self-deception in literature. He reassures himself furiously: he noticed the landlady was pregnant, didn't he? He can hear a song from the kitchen and identify whether it is sung in tune. He can observe children quarreling in the street and follow every detail. Therefore his mind must be sound. The cheese was an anomaly. It was the

cheese's fault, really--Dutch cheese with cloves and pepper, the smell alone enough to finish a man. "Set me, if you like, at five-sixteenths of good dairy butter," he tells himself. "That is another matter."

The comedy here is savage because the narrator's logic is not wrong, exactly. He can observe, he can notice, he can perceive with hallucinatory sharpness. What he can no longer do is the plodding, sequential, unglamorous work of thought. He can see the world but he cannot operate within it. Hunger has separated perception from function, the artist's eye from the citizen's competence. He is becoming a creature of pure consciousness with no practical capacity whatsoever--a condition that looks, from one angle, like madness, and from another, like the logical endpoint of the literary vocation pushed past all sustainable limits.

The Boy Who Became Hamsun

Knut Hamsun was born Knud Pedersen in 1859, in the village of Lom in the Gudbrandsdal valley, the fourth of seven children. His father was a tailor and smallholder. The family was poor. At nine, Hamsun was sent to live with an uncle who beat him and worked him relentlessly. His formal education was negligible. He left home as a teenager and worked as a

peddler, a shoemaker's apprentice, a schoolteacher, a road laborer, and a sheriff's assistant before emigrating to America in 1882.

The American years are crucial. Hamsun crossed the Atlantic twice, spending roughly four years in the upper Midwest and the East Coast. He was a farmhand in North Dakota, a streetcar conductor in Chicago, a clerk, a lecturer, a journalist in Minneapolis. He was nobody. He was a Norwegian immigrant working menial jobs in a country that had no use for his ambitions, and the experience marked him permanently. When he returned to Scandinavia and settled in Copenhagen in 1888, he was twenty-nine years old, had published nothing of consequence, and was furious--at America, at the literary establishment, at the nineteenth-century realism of Ibsen and Zola that he considered exhausted and dishonest.

Hunger was published in 1890, when Hamsun was thirty-one. It drew directly on his experience of near-starvation in Christiania in the mid-1880s, between his two American sojourns. The novel made him famous immediately. It was recognized, even by hostile reviewers, as something unprecedented--a work that had dispensed with plot, social context, and moral instruction in favor of the pure, terrifying intimacy of a single consciousness under siege. Over the next

decade Hamsun produced *Mysteries*, *Pan*, and *Victoria*, consolidating a body of work that would reshape European fiction.

In 1920, he was awarded the Nobel Prize in Literature for *Growth of the Soil*, his pastoral epic about a pioneer farming the Norwegian wilderness. The prize honored a different Hamsun than the one who wrote *Hunger*--an older man who had turned from the city to the land, from psychology to agrarianism, from the restless modernist to the conservative sage. But the Nobel made him the most celebrated Scandinavian writer of his age, and it is the Nobel that makes what followed so impossible to look away from.

The Catastrophe

Hamsun's affinity for Germany was longstanding. He had been a Germanophile and Anglophobe since the First World War. He admired what he saw as the discipline and depth of German culture, and he despised the British Empire with an intensity that bordered on obsession. When the Nazis rose to power, Hamsun did not merely tolerate them. He embraced them. He saw in National Socialism a kinship with his own agrarian ideals, his contempt for urban modernity, his belief in the primacy of blood and soil.

When Germany invaded Norway on April 9, 1940, Hamsun supported the occupation. He wrote articles and gave interviews urging his countrymen to lay down their arms. He praised Vidkun Quisling's collaborationist government. He donated his Nobel medal to Joseph Goebbels as a gesture of admiration. On June 26, 1943, he traveled to Berchtesgaden and met Adolf Hitler in person. The meeting, by most accounts, went badly: Hamsun was eighty-three, nearly deaf, and used the audience to harangue Hitler about the brutality of the German administrator in Norway, Josef Terboven. Hitler was reportedly enraged. But Hamsun left the meeting unshaken in his convictions.

The most damning document came last. On May 7, 1945--one week after Hitler's death, the same day Germany surrendered--Hamsun published an obituary in the newspaper *Aftenposten*. He called Hitler "a warrior for humankind and a preacher of the gospel of justice for all nations." He called him "a reformer of the highest order." This was not a private delusion confided to a diary. It was a public eulogy for a man whose regime had murdered six million Jews, published in a Norwegian newspaper on the day the war in Europe ended. Hamsun was eighty-five years old. He knew exactly what he was doing.

After the liberation, Hamsun was arrested and held in a hospital. A psychiatric examination lasting 119 days concluded that he suffered from "permanently impaired mental faculties"--a diagnosis that enraged him and that many later scholars have questioned. The finding allowed the Norwegian authorities to avoid a full treason trial. Instead, a civil case was brought, and in 1948 Hamsun was ordered to pay 325,000 kroner in restitution. He was financially ruined. He spent his last years on his farm at Norholm, nearly deaf, increasingly isolated, writing one final book: *On Overgrown Paths*, published in 1949, a lucid and combative memoir that many readers took as evidence his mental faculties had never been impaired at all. He died on February 19, 1952, at the age of ninety-two.

The Problem That Will Not Resolve

So here is the case. The man who wrote the most empathetic portrait of poverty and psychological suffering in modern fiction--a book that enters the consciousness of a starving man with such fidelity that the reader can feel the walls of the stomach contracting--became a public advocate for a regime that starved millions to death in camps and ghettos and occupied cities. The author of the cheese scene, who understood better than anyone what it means to have your mind dismantled by deprivation, praised the architects of

industrialized deprivation. This is not a matter of youthful indiscretion or political naivety. Hamsun supported the Nazis throughout the war, into his eighties, and never fully recanted.

The conversation about art and the moral failures of artists is by now well-worn. We have had it about Ezra Pound, who broadcast fascist propaganda from Rome. About Louis-Ferdinand Celine, whose antisemitic pamphlets remain so vile they were kept out of print in France for decades. About Martin Heidegger, whose philosophical language was entangled with Nazi ideology in ways scholars are still parsing. About Richard Wagner, whose operas Hitler adored and whose antisemitism was programmatic and vicious.

Hamsun's case is in some ways worse, because the gap between the art and the politics is so vertiginous. Pound's poetry is authoritarian in its aesthetics--its drive to master all of culture, to compel fragments into order. You can see a line, however crooked, from the *Cantos* to the radio broadcasts. Celine's novels are powered by the same raging contempt that fueled his pamphlets. But *Hunger*? *Hunger* is a book about powerlessness. About the dissolution of the self under pressure. About what it feels like to be nobody, to have nothing, to be at the mercy of a body you cannot feed and a city that does not care. There is nothing in the novel--not one sentence, not one image--that points toward fascism. And yet the man who wrote it became a fascist.

There are explanations, of course. Hamsun's Anglophobia, his agrarian romanticism, his belief that modern democracy was decadent, his lifelong hostility to the urban and the cosmopolitan. His increasing deafness, which isolated him from the world and may have made him more susceptible to ideology. His vanity, which was immense, and which the Nazis flattered expertly--Goebbels ordered a hundred thousand copies of his works printed after their meeting. But explanations are not resolutions. You cannot read the cheese scene and then read the Hitler obituary and make the two cohere. The incoherence is the point. It is the permanent scandal of Hamsun's life, and no amount of biographical context will dissolve it.

Isaac Bashevis Singer, a Nobel laureate himself and a Yiddish writer whose family was destroyed in the Holocaust, wrote that "the whole modern school of fiction in the twentieth century stems from Hamsun." He did not say this lightly. He did not say it in ignorance of Hamsun's politics. He said it because it was true, and because Singer understood that the history of literature is not a rewards ceremony for the virtuous.

The Enormous Shadow

The influence of *Hunger* on twentieth-century fiction is so pervasive that it has become invisible, like a river that has been diverted into so many channels that the original source is forgotten.

Franz Kafka read Hamsun early, and the mark is unmistakable. *The Metamorphosis*, published in 1915, takes the condition of Hamsun's narrator--a man trapped in a body that is failing him, increasingly alien to the world around him, dependent on the grudging charity of others--and literalizes it as insect transformation. Gregor Samsa wakes as a beetle; Hamsun's narrator wakes as something almost as monstrous, a thinking being who can no longer think. Kafka's 1922 story "A Hunger Artist" is an even more direct descendant: a man who makes a profession of starving, who discovers that his art consists precisely of deprivation, and who confesses at the end that he fasted only because he never found any food he liked. The hunger artist is Hamsun's narrator translated into parable--the writer whose medium is his own emptiness.

Samuel Beckett's tramps arrive from the same lineage. Vladimir and Estragon in *Waiting for Godot* are Hamsun's narrator stripped even of the city--placed on a bare road with a single tree, waiting for something that will not come. They bicker, they clown, they contemplate suicide, they eat a

carrot. The structure of their days is the structure of Hunger: expectation, disappointment, the irrational persistence of hope, the comedy of desperation. Beckett takes Hamsun's single man and splits him into two, because even solitude, pushed far enough, becomes a kind of dialogue with oneself.

Henry Miller called Hamsun "the Dickens of my generation"--a remark that sounds paradoxical until you consider what Miller meant by it. Not the Dickens of social panorama and moral feeling, but the Dickens of sheer narrative energy, of prose so alive to physical experience that it makes the reader hungry, cold, footsore, euphoric. Miller's *Tropic of Cancer*, written in Paris in the early 1930s, is a book about a writer who has nothing and wants everything, who scrounges meals and sleeps in borrowed beds and talks incessantly about art and sex and the magnificent failure of his own ambitions. It is Hunger transplanted to Montparnasse, with the Protestantism removed and the libido turned up.

Charles Bukowski acknowledged the debt more bluntly. A character in his novel *Women* calls Hamsun the greatest writer who ever lived. Bukowski's *Factotum*, published in 1975, takes Hamsun's wandering narrator and sets him loose in wartime and postwar America, drifting from one miserable job to the next, writing in cheap rooms, drinking everything in sight. Where Hamsun's narrator starves with a kind of

metaphysical grandeur, Bukowski's Henry Chinaski starves with a hangover. But the architecture is the same: the episodic, picaresque structure of failure, the comedy of a man who cannot quite be destroyed.

Paul Auster wrote an essay called "The Art of Hunger" in 1970, and the title became a kind of mission statement. In it, Auster argued that Hamsun "walks straight into the twentieth century" by translating the world of art into the world of the body. Auster's *Moon Palace*, published in 1989, follows a young man in 1960s New York through a process of self-starvation and dispossession that mirrors Hamsun's narrator almost scene for scene. The difference is that Auster's protagonist knows he is reenacting a literary tradition. He has read the books. He is starving in the library, surrounded by all the other stories of starvation. This self-consciousness is itself a measure of Hamsun's influence: by 1989, you could not write a novel about a starving writer without writing, in some sense, about *Hunger*.

The Starving Writer in the Age of Precarity

There is a temptation, with any classic, to declare it "more relevant than ever." Usually the claim is lazy. But with *Hunger* there is something to it that goes beyond the perennial appeal of a good novel.

Hamsun's narrator is a freelance writer. He has no employer, no safety net, no institutional affiliation. He produces work on speculation and submits it to editors who may or may not buy it. His income is irregular. His housing is precarious. He is one rejected article away from the street. He performs competence and well-being for the people around him while privately coming apart. He is, in the language of the twenty-first century, a gig worker. He is a content creator *avant la lettre*--producing words no one has commissioned, pitching stories no one has asked for, maintaining the fiction of professional viability while his shoes fall apart and his hair falls out.

The particular shame Hamsun captures--the shame of educated poverty, of downward mobility, of being intelligent enough to understand precisely how badly things are going--has not diminished. If anything, it has spread. The narrator's experience, once exotic enough to shock Scandinavian readers, is now recognizable to millions of people in the developed world who hold advanced degrees and cannot pay their rent. The journalist writing for publications that fold. The adjunct professor teaching four courses at three institutions for less than a living wage. The novelist with an MFA and a novel that does not sell. The distance between Hamsun's Christiania and the contemporary economy has not widened. It has collapsed.

What remains most modern about *Hunger* is not the social condition it describes but the psychology it renders. The narrator does not simply suffer. He suffers and watches himself suffer. He narrates his own degradation with a mixture of horror, fascination, and perverse amusement. He lies to others about his circumstances and then lies to himself about why he lied. He performs generosity he cannot afford. He rejects help he desperately needs. He oscillates between grandiosity and self-loathing so rapidly that the reader can barely keep up. This is not nineteenth-century realism. It is the texture of a mind under unbearable pressure, and it sounds remarkably like the interior monologue of anyone who has ever refreshed their bank balance at three in the morning, knowing what they would find.

The Ship

The novel's last movement is swift and strange. After the landlady throws him out, after the drama is torn to shreds, after the half-sovereign from Ylajali is thrown in the landlady's face in a gesture of suicidal pride, after the hallucinatory scene with the potatoes he insists are cabbages--swearing by the Father, Son, and Holy Ghost that they are cabbages--after all of this, the narrator simply walks to the harbor and asks if a ship needs a man.

He has no sailing experience. He is feverish, emaciated, half-blind without the glasses he furtively pockets to appear younger. But the captain of the *Copegoro*, a Russian barque bound for Leith and then Cadiz, takes him on. "Have a try at it," the captain says. "If it doesn't work, well, we can part in England."

There is no catharsis in this ending. No recognition scene, no reconciliation. The narrator does not learn anything. He does not grow. He escapes, and even the escape is provisional--the captain's conditional phrasing ("if it doesn't work") echoing all the conditional arrangements that have collapsed throughout the book. The ship is not salvation. It is another temporary arrangement, another bluff, another room that might be taken away.

And yet the ending is not hopeless. Or rather, it is not only hopeless. The narrator, who has lost everything--his lodging, his manuscript, his shoes, his ability to do arithmetic, the woman he thinks he loves--still has the capacity to act. He walks to the harbor. He asks a question. He boards a ship. These are small gestures, almost negligible, but they are not nothing. Hamsun understood that survival is not a grand narrative. It is a series of small, improbable decisions made by people who have every reason to stop making them.

The gleaming windows of Christiania, seen from the fjord, are the last image the novel gives us. They are beautiful and they are cruel. They represent everything the narrator wanted and could not have: warmth, shelter, belonging, a desk, a lamp, a room of his own where the spirit might move him and the allegory might be finished. The windows gleam "in all the homes"--that phrase, "all the homes," carrying the weight of everything the narrator's homelessness has meant. He is not looking back at a city. He is looking back at the idea of a life he was never granted.

Hamsun was thirty-one when he published this ending. He would live another sixty-two years, win the Nobel Prize, write a dozen more books, buy a grand estate, meet Adolf Hitler, eulogize him in print, be tried for treason, be declared mentally impaired, write a final book proving he was nothing of the kind, and die in his bed at ninety-two. The young man on the ship became one of the most celebrated and most reviled writers of the twentieth century. The novel he left behind--this small, ferocious, funny, agonizing book about a man who could not feed himself--became the headwater of modern fiction's deepest stream: the literature of the self at the end of its resources, the mind turning on itself in the dark.

The windows still gleam. The ship sails on. The hunger does not end.

Close Reading: Part IV

Every novel must end. Most end badly -- not in the sense of unhappily, but in the sense of inadequately, the final pages straining to contain what the preceding hundreds have set loose. The ending of a novel is the point at which form must assert itself over the chaos of narration, and this assertion almost always feels like a betrayal. We read for the chaos. We finish for the form. The gap between the two is the space in which most endings fail.

Hunger does not fail. It ends with one of the most quietly devastating paragraphs in modern fiction, a single sentence of farewell that carries the weight of everything the novel has refused to resolve. But before we reach that sentence, we must walk through the final part of the narrator's ordeal -- his longest sustained period of degradation, his most humiliating failures, his last encounter with the woman he calls Ylajali, and his strange, swift, almost offhand decision to abandon everything he has been and board a ship for England. Part IV is where the novel closes its fist.

"Winter Had Set In"

The opening paragraph of Part IV is one of the great mood-setting passages in the novel, and it operates by a technique Hamsun has been refining across the previous three parts: the fusion of weather and consciousness, of external atmosphere and internal condition, so total that the reader cannot say where the city ends and the narrator begins.

Winter had set in--a raw, wet winter, almost without snow. A foggy, dark, and everlasting night, without a single blast of fresh wind the whole week through. The gas was lighted almost all the day in the streets, and yet people jostled one another in the fog. Every sound, the clang of the church bells, the jingling of the harness of the droske horses, the people's voices, the beat of the hoofs, everything, sounded choked and jangling through the close air, that penetrated and muffled everything.

Notice the acoustic saturation. The passage is built on sound: clang, jingling, voices, hoofs. But every one of these sounds is smothered, arriving through the fog as if through a blanket. The air "penetrated and muffled everything" -- a paradox, because what penetrates should clarify, and what muffles should be kept at a distance. But Hamsun's fog does both. It gets inside things and deadens them from within. This is exactly what hunger has done to the narrator across the

preceding three parts. It has penetrated him -- colonized his body, his thoughts, his perceptions -- and it has muffled him, dampening his capacity to act, to think sequentially, to function as a citizen of the world he inhabits.

The sentence "Week followed week, and the weather was, and remained, still the same" lands with the flatness of exhaustion. It is a sentence that has given up on variation. It imitates the experience it describes: the monotony of protracted suffering, the way time ceases to articulate itself into distinct days when every day brings the same fog, the same hunger, the same failing effort.

And then, crucially, three sentences into Part IV, the narrator tells us something new. He has a lodging. He is staying at an inn in Vaterland, a lodging-house for travelers, and his landlady has been feeding him -- "a little food every day, some bread and butter, mornings and evenings." After the wild oscillations of Parts I through III, the park benches and the nights in the woods, the narrator has achieved something almost like stability. He has a room on the second floor, the best guest-room. He has a desk. His nervousness has "almost flown." He no longer wraps cloths around his hands when he writes. He can look down from the window without getting giddy.

This is the most dangerous position the narrator has occupied in the entire novel. He has just enough to lose.

The Allegory of Fire

The narrator is working on a piece he calls "an allegory about a fire -- a profound thought upon which I intended to expend all my energy." Later we learn more: it is an "Allegory of a Conflagration in a Bookshop," and the central conceit is that what burns is not books but brains, "human brains," and the narrator intends to "make a perfect Bartholomew's night of these burning brains."

The allegory is never completed. It is never even substantially begun. And this is the point. Throughout *Hunger*, the narrator's literary ambitions have functioned as a kind of promissory note -- evidence, always deferred, that he is not merely a starving vagrant but an artist waiting for his moment. In Part I, he writes a feuilleton and sells it. In Part II, he struggles with a piece about Correggio. In Part III, we see mostly the afterglow and wreckage of composition. Now, in Part IV, the writing becomes almost entirely phantasmal. The narrator describes what the allegory will be, what it will contain, what effect it will have on the editor he calls "the Commandor." He plans, projects, and promises. What he does not do is write it.

The allegory's subject is itself a kind of confession. A bookshop on fire, brains burning, a "Bartholomew's night" of intellectual destruction -- this is the narrator describing his own condition and calling it art. The mind that cannot add up a grocery bill is writing about minds on fire. The writer whose brain has failed him at five-sixteenths of a pound of cheese dreams of a literature in which brains are the fuel. There is a terrible grandeur in this, and a terrible comedy. The narrator has only one subject left: the destruction of the very faculty he needs to write about it.

Note, too, the specificity of "Bartholomew's night." The St. Bartholomew's Day massacre of 1572, in which thousands of Huguenots were slaughtered in Paris, is not an idle allusion. It imports into the narrator's literary fantasy the language of organized, religious violence -- of zealotry, of purification by slaughter. The narrator does not merely want to write about burning brains. He wants to stage a massacre. His imagination, starved of everything else, has turned apocalyptic. This is what happens to ambition when it has no material to work with: it becomes grandiose, abstract, violent, a plan for destruction dressed up as a plan for creation.

Five-Sixteenths of a Pound of Cheese

And now we arrive at the scene that might be the true climax of the novel -- the passage the thematic essay rightly identifies as the moment where hunger achieves its final victory. It is worth reading slowly, because Hamsun has constructed it with the precision of a dramatist, and every beat matters.

The landlady comes to the narrator's room with a reckoning she cannot reconcile. She asks him to look it over. This is, in itself, a small gesture of respect -- she assumes he is capable of checking accounts, that he is the kind of educated man who can find an error in a column of figures. The narrator adds up the figures once, finds the total correct, adds them up again, and arrives at the same result. So far, so good. He is functioning. He notices, parenthetically, that the landlady is pregnant, and this observation becomes important later, but for now it simply registers: his perceptual apparatus is working.

She asks him to check each line individually. And the narrator begins: "2 loaves at 2 1/2d., 1 lamp chimney, 3d., soap, 4d., butter, 5d." These are the simplest possible calculations. Multiplication of small numbers. Addition of the results. A child could do it. The narrator could have done it, in another life, without pausing.

Finally, I came to a dead stop at the following entry--"3. 5/16ths of a pound of cheese at 9d." My brain failed me completely; I stared stupidly down at the cheese, and got no farther.

Five-sixteenths of a pound of cheese at ninepence per pound. The arithmetic is not difficult. Five-sixteenths of nine is approximately 2.8 pence. But the narrator cannot do it. The fractions defeat him. Not the concept of fractions -- the landlady explains that five-sixteenths means five ounces, and he claims to understand -- but the operation itself, the sequential work of calculation, the holding of one number in the mind while performing an operation on another. This is the cognitive function that hunger has dismantled. Not perception -- he can still see, still hear, still notice with hallucinatory acuity. But computation, the plodding, unglamorous, step-by-step work of rational thought, has collapsed.

What follows is one of the most precisely observed passages of self-deception in literature. The narrator performs competence. He moves his lips. He mutters numbers aloud. He slides his finger down the column of figures "as if I were steadily coming to a result." He is acting the part of a man who can think. And the landlady, this practical, pregnant, overworked woman, sees through him at once. Her tact is devastating:

She remarked that perhaps I was not accustomed to reckon in sixteenths; she mentioned also that she must only apply to some one who had a knowledge of sixteenths, to get the account properly revised.

Hamsun tells us she said this "not in any hurtful way to make me feel ashamed, but thoughtfully and seriously." She is not cruel. She is simply accurate. She has reclassified the narrator. He is no longer a man of letters temporarily short of funds. He is a man who cannot add. And then, on her way out, the sentence that lands like a closing door: "Excuse me for taking up your time then."

That "then" is masterful. It carries the weight of a revised judgment. She had come to him because she thought he could help. She is leaving because she has discovered he cannot. The apology is genuine -- she is a decent woman -- but it is also a verdict. His time, she now understands, is not the time of a busy professional interrupted at his work. It is the time of a man who has nothing but time, and cannot use even that.

She returns a moment later, having barely reached the stairs. And now she asks about the money. Three weeks of lodging, unpaid. She is gentle about it, but firm: "I can't give lodging on credit." The narrator promises his article is nearly

finished. She replies with the most cutting sentence she has spoken: "Yes; but you'll never get that article finished, though."

He has no answer for this, because she is right. She has seen what he cannot admit to himself: that the article will never be finished, that the spirit will not move him, that the allegory of fire exists only as a title and a vague intention. Her confidence in him, we are told, is "evidently much shaken." This is Hamsun's gift for understatement at its most lethal. Her confidence is not shaken. It is gone.

The Narrator Reassures Himself

Left alone, the narrator does what he has done throughout the novel: he argues with himself, and the argument is both ferocious and heartbreaking.

No, in spite of all, there was really no salvation for me--no salvation! My brain was bankrupt! Had I then really turned into a complete dolt since I could not even add up the price of a piece of Dutch cheese? But could it be possible I had lost my senses when I could stand and put such questions to myself?

This is the logic of a man drowning. He cannot add. But he can ask whether he can add. Therefore he must be sane. And then the evidence accumulates: he noticed the landlady was pregnant. He did not stare at her. He observed children in the street, a load of furniture, a little girl holding on to stained mattresses. He heard the servant singing in the kitchen and listened for whether she sang in tune. An idiot, he tells himself, could not have done all this.

He is right, in a way that makes his wrongness more devastating. His perceptions are intact. His senses are almost preternaturally sharp. What has failed is not the instrument of perception but the instrument of operation -- the capacity to take what he perceives and do something useful with it. He can see the world but he cannot act within it. He has become, in a phrase that resonates far beyond this novel, a creature of pure consciousness with no practical capacity whatsoever.

The passage where he talks himself out of despair is one of Hamsun's great comic set-pieces, and like all the comedy in this novel, it is comedy that makes you flinch:

As far as that huckster account is concerned, that paltry five-sixteenths of beggar-man's cheese, I can happily dub it so. Ha, ha!-- a cheese with cloves and pepper in it; upon my word, a cheese in which, to put the matter plainly, one could breed maggots. As far as that ridiculous cheese is

concerned, it might happen to the cleverest fellow in the world to be puzzled over it! Why, the smell of the cheese was enough to finish a man; ... No; set me to reckon up something really eatable, said I--set me, if you like, at five-sixteenths of good dairy butter. That is another matter.

The cheese is to blame. Not his starving brain but the cheese itself -- its cloves, its pepper, its maggots, its smell. Set him any other problem and he would solve it instantly. Give him butter instead of cheese and the sixteenths would fall into place. The logic is absurd, and the narrator knows it is absurd, and the reader knows it is absurd, and yet the passage has a desperate, lunging energy that makes it something more than absurdity. This is a man fighting for his sanity with the only weapon he has left: language. If he can talk himself out of despair, if he can make the cheese funny, if he can laugh at Dutch cheese and its maggots, then perhaps the laughter will be proof enough that the laughing mind is sound.

And for a moment, it works. He sits down to his allegory and writes for an hour, "swimmingly, better than it had done for a long time." The manic reassurance has generated a brief, fragile momentum. But we know -- and the reader of Part IV feels this in the bones -- that it will not last. Momentum in this novel is always borrowed, always about to be repaid with interest.

The Scene in the Street

The passage between the cheese scene and the narrator's expulsion from his room deserves attention for what it reveals about Hamsun's method of close observation -- the way the novel inserts patches of vivid, almost journalistic detail into the fabric of the narrator's dissolution.

The narrator looks out the window onto Vognmandsgade and sees a load of furniture rolling by -- "some dislodged family, forced to change residence between 'flitting time.'" This is a mirror. A family being evicted, their possessions piled on a cart, a little girl riding on top of the stained mattresses, holding on with "her poor little blue hands." The narrator does not remark on the parallel to his own situation. He does not need to. The image does the work: another household coming apart, another set of lives tipped into the street, and a child at the center of it, cold-handed, holding on.

Then the children quarreling below, his landlady's son and another boy, and the language that erupts from them -- "Words like great buzzing noxious insects swarm out of their childish mouths; frightful nicknames, thieves' slang, sailors' oaths." The narrator, watching from above, intervenes. He calls down to the boy, trying to change the scene, to distract. The mother turns, looks up at him, "insolently, nay, downright maliciously," and goes inside scolding her child for letting

"people" see how naughty he is. The narrator has been reduced to "people" -- a stranger peering from a window, an observer with no authority and no stake in the life below him.

All of this the narrator marshals as evidence of his sanity. "Not one thing, not even one little accessory detail, was lost on me; my attention was acutely keen." He is right. His attention is acutely keen. He is the most perceptive failing man in literature. But the keenness of his attention is itself a symptom. A healthy mind does not need to catalogue every passing stimulus as proof that it is working. The very desperation of his self-monitoring -- this frantic inventorying of what he can still perceive -- is the sign of a mind that has lost confidence in itself and is testing, testing, endlessly testing its own faculties.

Dispossession

The narrator is working at the allegory again, having reached what he considers its crucial point -- the moment when the fire in the bookshop becomes a fire of brains, a "Bartholomew's night." And then his door is flung open and his landlady enters. She does not pause on the threshold. She comes "straight over to the middle of the room." A new lodger has arrived and needs the room. The narrator will sleep downstairs tonight.

Before he can answer, she begins bundling his papers together. This is the detail that stings. Not the loss of the room -- he has lost rooms before -- but the handling of his manuscript, the only thing in the world he has made, picked up and shuffled and disordered by indifferent hands. He says nothing. He lets her tidy the table. She thrusts the papers into his hand. The scene is over in moments.

On the stairs he passes the new lodger, a young man "with great blue anchors tattooed on the backs of his hands." A sailor, a casual traveler. A man who has money enough to pay for a room and who occupies, in the economy of the lodging-house, the position the narrator once occupied: a paying guest. The tattooed anchors are a small, precise detail -- the marks of a man who works with his body, who has a trade, who belongs to the physical world in a way the narrator, with his manuscripts and his allegories, does not.

The narrator is moved to the family room downstairs, and what he finds there is a complete portrait of the lodging-house's actual life, rendered in a few devastating strokes. The husband sits playing cards -- not for money, "only just to kill time, and have something in hand." The wife bustles, draws customers, pays bribes to quay-porters for referrals. An old man, the landlady's father, sits doubled over on a settle-bed, "his hair almost white," looking "like a poke-necked reptile that sat cocking its ears at something." Two little girls with

"thin, freckled, gutter-snipe faces." A servant who sleeps in the kitchen. This is the household the narrator has been sheltering within -- not a hotel but a struggling family enterprise, held together by the landlady's labor and the margins are thin.

His status in this household degrades rapidly. The servant mocks him. "I thought I saw you come out of the palace a while ago; were you at a dinner party?" She picks up his discarded manuscript pages and reads them aloud to the family. She laughs at his shoes -- "as wide as a dog's house." His hair is falling out, and she makes merry over that too. The children torment the paralyzed grandfather with straws in his ears. The narrator watches, wants to intervene, but does not, "out of fear to be shown the door for the night." He lets the old man be tormented because he cannot afford the moral cost of protest. This is the deepest indignity hunger has imposed: not just the loss of comfort, not just the loss of capacity, but the loss of moral agency. He cannot do what he knows is right because doing what is right might cost him his bed on the floor.

When the old man, unable to use his arms, spits at his tormentors, the landlord leaps up in fury: "Will you sit and spit right into people's eyes, you old boar?" The narrator protests -- "But, good Lord, he got no peace from them!" -- and is immediately silenced. He has spoken out of turn. He has no

standing here. He is a guest who does not pay, and guests who do not pay have no voice in how the household treats its own.

The landlady's tirade that follows is one of the novel's great speeches, not because it is eloquent but because it is so completely, brutally practical:

Here they walk in out of the street, without even a penny to buy flea-powder, and begin to kick up rows in the middle of the night and quarrel with the people who own the house.

She is right. The narrator has no standing. He has walked in out of the street, he has no money, and he is now presuming to tell the household how to behave. The husband, unexpectedly, intervenes on the narrator's behalf -- "it won't do to turn folk out at night; do you know one can be punished for doing that?" -- and the wife relents, placing bread and butter before the narrator that he refuses to eat "just out of gratitude to the man." Even his gestures of dignity are borrowed from someone else's kindness.

That night, in the anteroom, as he prepares to sleep, the landlady delivers her final sentence: "But this is the last night you sleep here, so now you know it." The narrator agrees. "Yes, yes." He will be gone in the morning. He slips out at five, before anyone wakes, "afraid to face my landlady again."

The One-Act Drama

Expelled from his room, his allegory in ruins, the narrator does what the narrator always does: he begins another work. This time it is a one-act drama called *The Sign of the Cross*, set in the Middle Ages. The protagonist is a woman -- "a magnificently fanatical harlot who had sinned in the temple, not from weakness or desire, but for hate against heaven." She has "sinned right at the foot of the altar, with the altar-cloth under her head, just out of delicious contempt for heaven."

This creation is extraordinary, and revealing. The narrator, at his lowest point, imagines a character whose defining quality is not desperation but defiance -- a woman who sins not because she is driven to it but because she chooses it, as an act of contempt. She is everything the narrator is not. She acts. She chooses. She defies heaven itself. Her body, he decides, should be "deformed and repulsive, tall, very lean, and rather dark" -- a body marked by suffering but wielding that suffering as a weapon rather than enduring it as a fate.

He writes ten or twelve pages of this drama, works at it for two hours, and is at last interrupted by the crying of the children inside. He goes out, walks up *Drammensveien*, and the drama begins to fade like all his other works -- present as a plan, dissolving as a reality. Later, when he tries to continue

it in the anteroom, and then in his old room upstairs where the sailor is not home, the writing comes in brief ecstatic bursts followed by collapse. He fills pages "in ecstasy over my happy vein" and then, moments later, discovers that the monk's speeches contain no trace of the Middle Ages, that "conscience was first invented by Dancing-master Shakespeare," and that the whole thing is rubbish.

The destruction of the drama -- he tears the manuscript in two, tears each page in two, flings his hat in the street and tramples it -- is the narrator's final act as a writer. After this, he will not write again. The drama joins the allegory, joins the Correggio essay, joins every other fragment the narrator has produced across the novel: another piece of wreckage in the wake of a talent that could conceive but not sustain, that could begin but not finish, that could imagine a defiant woman sinning at the altar but could not give her enough words to fill a stage.

Ylajali's Last Appearance

Before the drama is destroyed, Hamsun stages the narrator's final encounter with the woman he has called Ylajali -- though the encounter is indirect, glimpsed rather than enacted, and all the more devastating for its indirectness.

The narrator is standing outside a shoemaker's shop on Carl Johann Street when "Missy" greets him. They exchange pleasantries, lies. The narrator claims to have left his bookkeeping position at Christie's because of "a mis-entry" -- and then must defend himself when Missy interprets this as a "false entry," a deliberate fraud. The narrator is insulted. His honor is the one thing he still possesses, and he defends it with a pride that is, at this point in the novel, almost reflexive, almost mechanical: "It is simply my sense of honour that keeps me afloat now."

And then, in the act of turning away from Missy in offended dignity, his eyes fall on a red dress coming toward them. The prose tightens:

I stood the whole time and stared at the red dress that was coming nearer up the street, and a stir thrilled through my breast, a gliding delicate dart. I whispered in thought without moving my lips: "Ylajali!"

She is with a man -- "the Duke," a figure the narrator and Missy both recognize as disreputable. The red dress glides up Carl Johann and disappears. Missy mentions, casually, that she looked only at the narrator the whole time. And then he tells the story of how he came to know her: a night in autumn, three jovial souls out late, a man who "dubbed himself Waldemar Atterdag and represented himself as a

photographer" who talked his way into walking her home. The narrator asks what came of it, holds his breath -- and Missy interrupts himself. There is the lady. There is the Duke.

Missy's final remark: "Well, if she is in contact with that fellow; well, then, I wouldn't like to answer for her."

The narrator's response to all this is a masterpiece of self-protective fury. He consigns her. He drags her "through the mire." He tells himself he does not care, that she has "fallen off," that she is "soiled." He imagines passing her haughtily by, even if she were to look straight into his eyes "and have a blood-red gown on into the bargain." The language of sexuality and violence -- blood-red, mire, soiled -- betrays an intensity of feeling that the narrator is desperate to convert into contempt. He cannot afford to want her. He has nothing to offer. And so he must make her unworthy of wanting.

But notice the detail Hamsun slips in without emphasis: Missy's report of a man who approached Ylajali late at night, talked incessantly, refused to be rebuffed, and "represented himself as a photographer." The narrator, earlier in the novel, represented himself as a reporter, as a bookkeeper, as various things he was not. The man who walked Ylajali home is the narrator's double -- another talker, another performer, another man who invents an identity for the occasion. The difference is that the double succeeds. He makes her laugh.

He walks her to her door. The narrator, who could never manage to be both charming and honest, who oscillated between grandiosity and abjection but could never find the middle register of ordinary human warmth, is displaced by a man who does exactly what he could not.

The Half-Sovereign

The next day brings the novel's most concentrated sequence of crisis. The narrator, having slept on the floor of the anteroom, slips out before dawn, wanders the cold streets, and reaches a bench near the fortress where he sits, "very hungry," and falls asleep. When he wakes it is full daylight, the sun is out, and a beautiful morning produces in him one of those swoops of emotion that have characterized his hunger throughout the book: "I clapped myself on the chest and sang a little snatch for myself. My voice sounded so wretched, downright exhausted it sounded, and I moved myself to tears with it."

He weeps. He reaches the bridge. And there, for the first time, he sees the ship that will take him away from everything: the Copegoro, a Russian barque with nine feet of hull visible above the waterline, discharging coal. He watches for a while, takes out his papers, tries to write a speech for the monk in his drama, and cannot. The bustle of the harbor,

the shanties and gangways and rattling chains, will not resolve into the "musty air of the dim Middle Ages." He puts his papers away.

Meanwhile, back at the lodging-house, the final indignity is playing out. He returns, driven by the need for shelter, and creeps into the family room. The landlord ignores him. The servant mocks him. He tries to write his drama on his knees while children torment a hairless cat, card players occupy the table, and the landlady sews and smiles at his humiliation. He retreats to the anteroom, to the room upstairs where the sailor is out, and for a few ecstatic minutes the writing comes -- "Retort upon retort stood ready in my head" -- before the landlady and her husband burst in and he is expelled for good.

On the stairs, a commissionaire meets him with an envelope. Inside: half a sovereign. No note. No name. A lady gave it to him, the messenger says.

The narrator's response is one of the great gestures in the novel. He puts the coin back in the envelope, crumples the whole thing, turns on his heel, and throws it in the landlady's face. He walks away.

Ha! that is what one might call comporting oneself with dignity. Not to say a word, not to mention the contents, but crumple together, with perfect calmness, a large piece of money, and fling it straight in the face of one's persecutor!

He is exultant. He has behaved magnificently. He has thrown away the only money he possesses -- money sent, he will shortly realize, by Ylajali -- in a gesture of pride so pure and so self-destructive that it transcends sense entirely. This is the narrator's pathology at its most crystalline: the compulsion to give, to refuse, to perform dignity even when dignity costs him everything. He would rather starve than accept her money. He would rather collapse in the street than be the object of her compassion.

And collapse he does. At the corner of Tomtegaden, "the street commenced suddenly to swim around before my eyes." He staggers against a wall, cannot straighten himself, begins to lose his senses. He stamps his foot, clenches his teeth, rolls his eyes. And then comes the passage with the potatoes:

A dray rolls slowly by, and I notice there are potatoes in it; but out of sheer fury and stubbornness, I take it into my head to assert that they are not potatoes, but cabbages, and I swore frightful oaths that they were cabbages. I heard quite well what I was saying, and I swore this lie wittingly; repeating time after time, just to have the vicious

satisfaction of perjuring myself. I got intoxicated with the thought of this matchless sin of mine. I raised three fingers in the air, and swore, with trembling lips, in the name of the Father, Son, and Holy Ghost, that they were cabbages.

This is one of the strangest and most revealing moments in the novel. The narrator, on the verge of physical collapse, chooses to lie -- not to anyone else, but to reality itself. He knows the potatoes are potatoes. He says they are cabbages. He swears a sacred oath to sustain the lie. And the pleasure he takes in it -- "the vicious satisfaction of perjuring myself" -- is the pleasure of a man who has lost control of everything except his capacity to defy. He cannot control his hunger, his lodging, his literary output, his relationships. But he can still assert, against all evidence, that potatoes are cabbages. He can still perform an act of will, even if the only act of will available to him is a meaningless, solitary, blasphemous lie sworn to no one.

The invocation of the Trinity is not accidental. Throughout *Hunger*, the narrator has maintained a complicated, half-ironic, half-desperate relationship with God -- thanking God when things go well, raging at God when they do not, invoking divine names with a freedom that suggests both piety and its exhaustion. Here, in the potatoes-as-cabbages scene, the sacred formula becomes the instrument of deliberate falsehood. The narrator is not blaspheming out of

despair. He is blaspheming for fun, for the sheer delight of violating something, because violation is the last form of agency left to him. The harlot of his unfinished drama -- the woman who sinned at the altar out of "delicious contempt for heaven" -- has become the narrator himself, swearing false oaths in the street while the dray rolls past and the city ignores him.

The Realization

When the narrator's fury subsides and he sits on a step to recover, the practical consequences of his grand gesture begin to register. He has thrown away half a sovereign. He is penniless. He is homeless. And then, belatedly, he understands who sent the money.

I grew sick with pain and shame. I whispered "Ylajali" a few times, with hoarse voice, and flung back my head.

The sickness is not merely regret at having thrown away the money. It is the recognition that his relationship with Ylajali has been reduced, finally and irreversibly, to charity. She has seen him in the street, has seen what he has become, and has sent money. Not a letter, not an invitation, not a word. Money. The same impersonal kindness one might extend to any

beggar. And he, in his spectacular gesture of pride, has not even managed to refuse it properly -- he threw it at the wrong person, the landlady, who will certainly keep it.

What follows is a passage of self-recrimination so intense it reads like a seizure: "I sank, simply sank, on all sides -- every way I turned; sank to my knees, sank to my waist, dived under in ignominy, never to rise again -- never!" The metaphor is drowning, and it is accurate. The narrator is going under. But even now, even in the middle of this agony, the mind that cannot add sixteenths performs its characteristic trick: it reverses. Within paragraphs, the narrator has talked himself from shame into entitlement. Ylajali sent the money because she is "in love with me -- ha! perhaps even fatally in love." The half-sovereign is not charity but tribute. "The least she could do was to send me half-a-sovereign now and then." The self-pity has become self-congratulation, and the reader watches, helpless, as the narrator's psychology performs once more its central, terrible operation: the conversion of humiliation into fantasy.

The Cake-Vendor

One of the novel's most uncomfortable comic scenes follows. Starving, desperate, the narrator remembers the cake-vendor near the chemist's under the sign of the elephant -- the

woman to whom, in an earlier part, he gave his money in one of those inexplicable gestures of generosity that punctuate the novel. Now he returns to collect.

The scene is built on a monstrous logic: because he once gave her money, the cakes are his. He has prepaid. It was a deposit. This is, of course, a fabrication -- he gave her the money impulsively and with no expectation of return -- but the narrator constructs an elaborate fiction of commercial transaction, complete with indignation that she does not remember, and condescension toward her lack of foreign travel ("She had perhaps never been outside the boundaries of her own country?"). He takes cakes from her table. She resists. He threatens to call the police. She relents, shoving some cakes toward him at the highest price she can think of. He eats them and walks away, congratulating himself on having "come out of this affair with flying colours."

The comedy here is savage because the narrator has become, in this scene, the very thing he has spent the entire novel trying not to be: a man who takes from those who have less. The cake-vendor is a street seller, a woman who sits at a table in the cold. She is not wealthy. She is not powerful. And the narrator, who has given away money to beggars, who has refused charity, who has pawned his waistcoat rather than accept pity, is now bullying a cake-vendor out of her stock by means of a lie so brazen it amounts to theft. Hunger has not

merely weakened him. It has inverted him. The man who could not stop giving has become the man who cannot stop taking.

But then, in the middle of this degradation, a flicker of the narrator's original self. He saves one cake -- the last small cake -- for "the little chap down in Vognmandsgade," the boy he saw earlier being spat on by a man in a window. He walks back to find the boy. The boy is gone. The narrator places the cake upright against the doorstep, knocks, and hurries away. "My eyes grew moist with pleasure at the thought of the little chap finding the cake." The gesture is futile -- the boy may never find it, a dog may eat it, the rain may dissolve it -- but it is genuine. Even now, even after the shameful scene with the cake-vendor, the narrator is capable of thinking of someone else, of imagining a child's pleasure, of performing a small, anonymous act of care. This is the crumb of grace Hamsun allows him before the end.

Seeking the Ship

The narrator reaches the terminus. The cakes have not helped. His head is "growing more and more confused." He fantasizes about cutting a ship's hawser, about yelling "Fire." He sits on a packing-case and stares at the Copegoro, the same Russian barque he watched that morning.

And then, with the casualness that marks every turning point in this novel, he speaks to a man at the rail.

"Do you sail tonight, Captain?"

"Yes; in a short time," answered the man. He spoke Swedish.

"Hem, I suppose you wouldn't happen to need a man?"

The narrator tells us he had "no object in talking" and did not expect a reply. He was "utterly indifferent" to the answer. This is either true or it is the deepest lie the narrator has told. Perhaps, in this moment, the question really did emerge without intention, the way so many of the narrator's actions emerge -- involuntarily, from some layer of the self deeper than conscious will. Or perhaps, beneath the claimed indifference, the narrator understood perfectly well what he was doing: he was saving his own life.

The captain's reply is conditional: he might need "a young fellow." The narrator, who is not particularly young, performs a small, precise act of deception: he takes off his glasses "furtively" and thrusts them into his pocket. Without the glasses, he looks younger. Without the glasses, he cannot see clearly. The man who has been watching the world with hallucinatory sharpness throughout the novel now deliberately blinds himself in order to be taken aboard.

There is something almost sacramental in this gesture. The narrator removes the instrument of perception -- the very faculty that has been his consolation, his proof of sanity, his one remaining competence -- and puts it away. He will not need it where he is going. The ship does not require a man who can see. It requires a man who can work.

The Captain's Interview

The exchange with the captain is brief, and every line of it matters.

"I have no experience," said I; "but I can do anything I am put to. Where are you bound for?"

"We are in ballast for Leith, to fetch coal for Cadiz."

"All right," said I, forcing myself upon the man; "it's all the same to me where I go; I am prepared to do my work."

"It's all the same to me where I go." This is either the expression of a man who has achieved a kind of freedom through the loss of all attachment, or the expression of a man who has been so thoroughly defeated that geography no longer matters. Both readings are true. The narrator no longer cares whether he goes to Leith or Cadiz or the bottom of the sea, because every destination is equally unrelated to the life he has been trying to live. He is not choosing to go somewhere. He is choosing to leave.

When the captain asks if he has ever sailed, the narrator's reply is magnificent in its desperation: "No; but as I tell you, put me to a task, and I'll do it. I am used to a little of all sorts." He is used to nothing of any sort. He is a writer who cannot write, a man who cannot add sixteenths, a lodger who cannot pay, a lover who cannot love. The claim to be "used to a little of all sorts" is the final bluff in a novel composed almost entirely of bluffs -- but this time, unlike all the other times, the bluff is not in the service of pride. It is in the service of survival.

And then the line that completes the narrator's transformation from artist to laborer:

"What do you think about it, Captain?" I asked at last. "I can really do anything that turns up. What am I saying? I would be a poor sort of chap if I couldn't do a little more than just what I was put to. I can take two watches at a stretch, if it comes to that. It would only do me good, and I could hold out all the same."

"I could hold out." The narrator, who has been holding out for the entire novel -- holding out against hunger, against humiliation, against the collapse of his ambitions -- now offers his capacity for endurance as a professional

qualification. It is the only qualification he has, and it turns out to be enough. "All right, have a try at it," the captain says. "If it doesn't work, well, we can part in England."

The conditional phrasing -- "if it doesn't work" -- echoes every provisional arrangement in the novel. Every room, every meal, every relationship has been conditional. The narrator has lived his entire life in the subjunctive, the tense of possibility rather than fact. And now the last arrangement of the novel is conditional too. He has not been hired. He has been given a trial. He can be discarded in England. Nothing is settled, nothing is secure, and the narrator's response to this is pure, uncomplicated delight: "Of course," he replies, "and I repeated over again that we could part in England if it didn't work."

He repeats the condition. He agrees to it eagerly. The man who could not bear to be patronized, who threw half-sovereigns in people's faces, who invented elaborate lies to preserve his dignity, now accepts, with gratitude, a provisional arrangement that treats him as disposable labor. Something has broken in him, or something has been released. The pride that sustained him through the novel -- that monstrous, magnificent, self-destroying pride -- has finally loosened its grip, and what remains is a man who will take what he can get.

"And He Set Me to Work"

Five words: "And he set me to work." This is the last sentence before the novel's final paragraph, and it is easy to read past it, but it deserves to be held and examined. It is the first time in the novel that the narrator has been set to work by someone else. Throughout the book, his work has been self-generated, self-imposed, self-judged. He wrote when the spirit moved him. He worked at his allegory, his drama, his articles, according to the rhythms of his own inspiration. Now someone else tells him what to do, and he does it. The sentence is in the passive voice -- "he set me to work" -- and the passivity is the point. The narrator has surrendered agency. He has stopped being the author of his own actions and has become a man who follows orders. There is a loss in this, but there is also, perhaps, a kind of relief. The terrible burden of self-direction, of having to decide each day what to write and when to write it and whether it was any good -- all of this has been lifted. Someone else is in charge now. The narrator has only to work.

The ellipsis after the sentence -- "And he set me to work...." -- is one of four dots, the translator's rendering of a pause that stands for everything the novel does not show us: the departure from the dock, the passage down the fjord, the first hours of labor aboard a ship the narrator does not know

how to sail. The ellipsis is a gap, and in that gap the novel shifts from the immediate present tense it has occasionally used throughout Part IV to the past tense of retrospection. When the narrator speaks again, in the final paragraph, he is looking back.

The Final Paragraph

Here it is, the whole of it:

Out in the fjord I dragged myself up once, wet with fever and exhaustion, and gazed landwards, and bade farewell for the present to the town--to Christiania, where the windows gleamed so brightly in all the homes.

One sentence. Fifty-three words in this English translation. No novel in modern literature ends more quietly, or with more force.

Begin with the body. "I dragged myself up once." Not "I stood up" or "I rose" but "dragged myself up" -- the language of a body that resists its own motion, that must be hauled into position by an act of will. And "once" -- a single time, one look back, as if the narrator knows he can afford only one. To look again would be to falter. To look again might be to turn the ship around.

"Wet with fever and exhaustion." The narrator is sick. He is soaked -- with sweat, with sea spray, with the physical residue of everything his body has endured. The fever is real; it has been building throughout Part IV, mentioned in passing, never treated. He is working through illness on a ship he does not know how to crew, and the wetness is a marker of how far he has come from the dry, enclosed spaces of the novel -- the attic rooms, the newspaper offices, the lodging-house in Vaterland. He is outside now, fully exposed, and the elements are claiming him.

"And gazed landwards." Not "looked back" but "gazed" -- a word that carries the weight of sustained attention, of seeing as a deliberate act. And "landwards," a direction rather than a destination, as if the city has already ceased to be a place and has become merely a bearing, a point on the compass, something receding.

"And bade farewell for the present to the town." Here is the phrase that breaks the heart: "for the present." It means "for now." It means "temporarily." It means "I will come back." It is the kind of thing people say when they are leaving forever and cannot admit it. "For the present" is the narrator's last lie, or his last hope, and the two are indistinguishable. He bids farewell for the present because to bid farewell forever would be to acknowledge what this departure really is: a final severance, the end of the life he tried to live, the

abandonment of the city where he believed he would become a writer. "For the present" holds open a door that is already shut.

"To the town -- to Christiania." The dash and the repetition. First the generic noun, "the town," as if any town would do, as if the narrator could detach himself from the specific and retreat into abstraction. But then the correction: "Christiania." The real name. The place. The city that was named in the novel's very first sentence, "this singular city, from which no man departs without carrying away the traces of his sojourn there." The narrator cannot leave anonymously. He cannot pretend this is just any town. It is Christiania, and he carries its traces.

"Where the windows gleamed so brightly in all the homes."

This final clause is where the sentence opens into something larger than one man's departure. The windows gleam. They are lit from within -- by gas, by candles, by the domestic light of inhabited rooms. Each window is a home, and in each home there is warmth, and food, and people who belong there, people who are not on a ship headed for England with no experience and a fever. "All the homes" -- the phrase is total, encompassing. Not some homes. Not the rich homes. All of them. Every window the narrator can see from the deck of the Copegoro represents a life he does not have,

a belonging he could not achieve. The gleaming is beautiful, and the beauty is the cruelty. If the windows were dark, the departure would be easier. But they gleam. They invite. They show him exactly what he is leaving and what he never had.

There is a long tradition in literature of the lighted window as an image of exclusion. Dickens's orphans press their faces to glass. Fitzgerald's Gatsby stares at the green light across the water. But Hamsun's windows are different because they are not symbolic. They are not standing for something. They are simply there, gleaming in the evening as the ship moves down the fjord, and the narrator sees them because he is the narrator -- because seeing, perceiving, registering the world with painful precision is the one thing he has never stopped being able to do. His mind could not add sixteenths. His pen could not finish an allegory. But his eyes, in this final moment, are working. He sees the windows. He sees what they mean. And he says nothing about what they mean, because Hamsun understood that the greatest effects in fiction come from the things that are shown and not explained.

The sentence does not end with a period and a moral. It does not end with the narrator's feelings about the windows, or his thoughts about his future, or his reflections on the nature of belonging. It ends with the windows themselves, gleaming. The image is the ending. Nothing is resolved. The

hunger does not end. The narrator does not become a sailor or a writer or a citizen. He is simply a man on a ship, looking back at a city full of light, and then the novel stops.

What Is Not Said

It is worth pausing over everything the final paragraph does not contain. There is no summary. No judgment. No lesson. The narrator does not tell us what he learned from his experience, because he has learned nothing -- or rather, because what he learned cannot be articulated as a lesson. You cannot say "I learned that hunger destroys the mind" and have it mean what the cheese scene means. You cannot say "I learned that pride is self-destructive" and have it contain what the thrown half-sovereign contains. The novel's knowledge is not propositional. It is experiential. It lives in the texture of the prose, in the rhythms of the narrator's thought, in the gap between what he says and what we understand. To summarize it would be to betray it.

There is also no mention of writing. The narrator, who has spent the entire novel trying to write -- who has defined himself as a writer, who has endured everything in the service of an artistic vocation he could not sustain -- does not, in the final paragraph, mention his art. He does not vow to write again. He does not mourn the unfinished allegory or the torn-

up drama. He does not even think about it. The omission is thunderous. The man who lived for writing has boarded a ship where no one will ask him to write, where his only task is physical labor, where the faculties that tormented him -- the imagination, the ambition, the impossible perfectionism -- are irrelevant. He has escaped not only Christiania but the vocation that made Christiania unbearable.

Whether this is liberation or defeat depends on something the novel refuses to tell us, which is what happens next. Does the narrator ever write again? Does he return to Christiania? Does he find what he was looking for, or forget what it was? The novel does not say. "For the present," it says, and the present is all we get.

The Footnotes

A small matter, easily overlooked: the footnotes. This translation (by George Egerton, one of the earliest English renderings) includes a handful of explanatory notes -- a barber's ticket, a cheap eating-house, the last noble family in Norway, a theater garden, a civil governor's dwelling, and the Norwegian "flitting time" (March 14 and October 14, the traditional dates for changing residences). These notes

appear at the bottom of Part IV because that is where the translator placed them, though they annotate passages from across the novel.

The footnotes are artifacts of distance. They exist because a reader in London in the 1890s would not have known what a droske was, or when Norwegians moved house, or that the Tivoli was a garden of entertainment. Each note is a small acknowledgment that the world of the novel is not our world -- that Christiania in the 1880s, with its gas lamps and its droske horses and its flitting-time rules, is a foreign country requiring interpretation. The footnotes are the translator's concession that some things cannot survive the crossing from one language to another without explanation, the way some people cannot survive the crossing from one life to another without transformation.

But there is something else in the footnotes, something the translator may not have intended. They domesticate the novel. They make it comprehensible. They fill in the gaps that Hamsun deliberately left open. When the narrator mentions the "flitting time" and the reader sees a note explaining that this means March 14 and October 14, the strangeness of the reference is absorbed into fact. The footnote closes the door that the text left ajar. And in this way, the footnotes work against the novel's deepest principle, which is that not

everything can be explained, that the gaps are part of the meaning, that the mind of a starving man is not a text that submits to annotation.

The Shape of Part IV

Considered as a whole, Part IV has a shape unlike the other three parts. Parts I through III follow a rhythm of crisis and temporary reprieve -- the narrator hits bottom, finds some momentary foothold (a sold article, a borrowed coin, a night of wild inspiration), and then falls again. The oscillation is rapid, almost manic, and the reader is carried along on the swings of mood like a passenger on a ship in rough weather.

Part IV is different. It begins with a plateau -- the narrator in his room, fed if not well, writing if not well, stable if not secure -- and then descends, steadily and without reprieve, into the final catastrophe. There are no upswings in Part IV. The cheese scene is followed by expulsion from the room, which is followed by humiliation in the family quarters, which is followed by ejection from the house, which is followed by the thrown half-sovereign, which is followed by the destroyed manuscript, which is followed by the collapse in the street, which is followed by the ship. The descent is relentless, and Hamsun manages it with a narrative control that belies the chaos of the narrator's experience. Each scene is worse than

the last. Each humiliation is deeper. Each failure is more final. The novel's structure, in its last movement, achieves the grim inevitability of tragedy -- not the tragedy of a great man brought low by a flaw, but the tragedy of an ordinary man brought low by circumstances that no amount of talent or will can overcome.

And yet the ending is not tragic. Or rather, it is not only tragic. The narrator boards the ship. He accepts work. He looks back at the gleaming windows and bids farewell "for the present." There is, in this, something that resists the word "defeat." The narrator has not died. He has not gone mad. He has not surrendered to the streets. He has done something -- the only thing left to do -- and in doing it he has preserved, however tenuously, the continuity of his life. The ship sails. The city recedes. The windows gleam. And the narrator, wet with fever, is still looking. He has not stopped looking. That is not nothing.

The Ship and the City

The relationship between the narrator and Christiania is the novel's deepest subject, deeper even than hunger itself. Christiania is not merely the setting of the story. It is the antagonist, the beloved, the mirror, the trap. The narrator loves this city. He cannot leave it. He wanders its streets with

the obsessive familiarity of a man pacing the rooms of a house he once owned. He knows every corner, every shop, every bench. He has slept in its parks, begged in its offices, written in its cafes, starved in its rooms. The city is his entire world, and his entire world has been slowly, systematically trying to kill him.

Part IV stages the final phase of this relationship: the separation. And Hamsun manages it with extraordinary subtlety, because the narrator does not decide to leave Christiania. He does not wake up one morning and resolve to try his fortunes elsewhere. The departure happens to him, the way everything in this novel happens to him -- involuntarily, almost accidentally, as the result of a chain of events he set in motion without understanding where they led. He throws the half-sovereign at the landlady. He destroys his manuscript. He staggers to the harbor. He asks, without quite meaning to, if the ship needs a man. One thing follows another, and suddenly he is aboard, and suddenly the ship is moving, and suddenly the city is behind him.

This is how people actually leave the places they love. Not in a single dramatic gesture of renunciation, but in a series of small, contingent steps, each one seeming trivial at the time, each one closing off the possibility of return. The narrator does not leave Christiania because he has chosen to. He leaves because he has used up every other option, and the

ship happened to be there, and the captain happened to need a man, and the tide happened to be right. The departure is not a decision. It is what is left when all the decisions have been made badly.

Reading Backward

Once you have read the final paragraph, you cannot help reading backward -- seeing the whole novel as a prelude to this departure, this sentence, these gleaming windows. Every room the narrator occupied was temporary. Every meal was borrowed. Every piece of writing was abandoned. Every relationship was provisional. The novel has been, from its first sentence, a story of departure postponed, of a man who should have left long ago and could not, who clung to Christiania and to his idea of himself as a writer with a tenacity that was both heroic and ruinous.

The cheese scene, read in this light, is not merely about cognitive failure. It is about the death of a self-concept. The narrator believed he was a man who could think, a man whose mind was his instrument and his justification. The cheese destroyed that belief. And once the belief was destroyed, there was no reason to stay. There was no reason to sit in a room and wait for the spirit to move him, because the spirit had nowhere to move. The allegory would not be

written. The drama would not be finished. The "Commandor" would not read his work and recognize his genius. All of this became clear in the moment the narrator stared at five-sixteenths of a pound of Dutch cheese and could not calculate what it cost.

The ship, then, is not an escape from hunger. It is an escape from the self -- from the writer, the thinker, the man of letters, the proud sufferer who would rather starve than admit he could not do what he had set out to do. The narrator who boards the Copegoro is not the narrator who began the novel. Something has been stripped away. Whether what remains is the essential self, laid bare by deprivation, or merely the husk of a man who has lost everything that made him who he was -- this is the question the novel poses and refuses to answer.

The Tone of the Ending

Read the final paragraph aloud. Listen to its rhythms. "Out in the fjord" -- three heavy stresses, the mouth opening on "out" and closing on "fjord," the vowels dark and wide. "I dragged myself up once" -- the drag of the consonants, the effort in the words themselves. "Wet with fever and exhaustion" -- the alliteration of "w" sounds, the sibilance of "exhaustion," the sentence sagging under its own weight. And then the lift:

"and gazed landwards, and bade farewell for the present to the town." The rhythm changes here, becomes more formal, almost ceremonial. "Bade farewell" is the language of ritual, of leave-taking as an act with weight and meaning. The narrator has been informal, colloquial, wild throughout the novel. In this final sentence, he becomes stately. He rises to the occasion of his own departure.

"To Christiania, where the windows gleamed so brightly in all the homes." The dash before "to Christiania" creates a pause, a breath, a moment of gathering. And then the name of the city, spoken like an incantation. And then the clause that opens outward into image: the windows, the gleaming, the homes. The sentence ends on "homes," the word that contains everything the narrator has lacked. It is the last word of substance in the novel. Not "city" or "town" or "Christiania" but "homes." The narrator, who has been homeless for the entire book, ends his story with the word for what he never had.

The thematic essay that accompanies Part IV (see ["After Hunger"](#)) places this ending in the context of other great fictional farewells -- Fitzgerald's boats, Joyce's snow, Beckett's unknowing. Those comparisons are illuminating, but they also clarify what makes Hamsun's ending unique. There is no universalizing gesture here, no expansion from the particular to the general. The narrator does not look at the

windows and think about the human condition. He looks at the windows and sees them gleam. The image is specific, local, irreducibly itself. And it is precisely this specificity -- this refusal to mean more than it shows -- that gives the ending its power. The windows gleam because windows gleam when they are lit and you are far away. That is all. That is enough.

Departure Without Arrival

There is one more thing to say about the ending of *Hunger*, and it is perhaps the most important thing. The novel ends with a departure. It does not end with an arrival. The ship is moving. The narrator is on it. He is going somewhere -- to Leith, to Cadiz, to whatever comes after. But we do not see him arrive. We do not see him step off the ship, find work, eat a meal, sleep in a bed. We do not see him write again or not write again. We do not see him recover or fail to recover. The novel cuts off at the moment of transit, the moment between one life and another, and it leaves the narrator suspended there, in the fjord, between the city he is leaving and the coast he has not yet reached.

This is the condition the narrator has occupied for the entire novel: between. Between eating and starving. Between sanity and madness. Between the writer he believes himself to be and the vagrant the world sees. Between pride and

desperation. Between Ylajali and solitude. Between the room and the street. He has never arrived anywhere. He has never settled into a stable state. The novel has been, from beginning to end, a record of transit, of a man perpetually in passage, and it is fitting -- it is the only possible ending -- that the last image should be of a man on a ship, moving, looking back, not yet where he is going.

The windows gleam. The ship sails on. And the narrator, who told us everything -- who told us about the cheese and the potatoes and the hairless cat and the paralyzed grandfather and the cake-vendor and the cabbages and the glasses he hid in his pocket -- falls silent at last. The novel does not end. It simply stops speaking. What remains is the image: a city full of light, seen from the water, by a man who is already too far away to go back.